

GAMING DEMOCRACY



HOW SILICON VALLEY
LEVELED UP THE FAR RIGHT

ADRIENNE L. MASSANARI

"MASSANARI SHOWS HOW THE LOGICS OF SILICON VALLEY HAVE
DAMAGED DEMOCRACY—AND WHAT WE CAN DO TO FIGHT BACK."
—WHITNEY PHILLIPS

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ADRIENNE L. MASSANARI

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PREFACE

The 2016 US presidential election was many things—a spectacle, a debacle, and arguably, a referendum on the viability of American democracy in the twenty-first century. Around that time, a 2013 comic by KC Green experienced new life as a meme. Circulating mostly as an abbreviated two-panel version of the original six-panel *Gunshow* comic, “On Fire” features a cartoon dog wearing a jaunty hat, sitting at a table adorned only with a coffee mug, and surrounded by flames. In the two-panel (and arguably more popular) version, the dog smiles and notes, “This is fine,” and in the longer six-panel comic, he drinks his coffee and continues, “I am okay with the events that are unfolding currently,” later stating, “That’s okay, things are going to be okay,” as the fire intensifies, engulfing the room in which he is sitting. The last frame shows the dog’s face melting with the smile plastered on his face.

While meant as a commentary on Green’s own struggles with mental health and general twenty-something malaise, the comic’s resonance and longevity suggest something beyond his original intent.¹ At one point, an animated version of the entire six-panel comic was used as an interstitial station-identification “bump” on Adult Swim, and in July 2016, the official Republican Party Twitter account used the two-panel version as a snarky commentary on the Democratic National Convention in Philadelphia, amending it with #EnoughClinton (without obtaining permission from Green).² Its popularity long after the 2016 election continues to imply that we might all be that dog sitting at the table attempting to have coffee in the midst of a conflagration.³ Slowly melting, ignoring the chaos

around us, and soothing ourselves with the mantra that “things are okay” despite ample evidence to the contrary, we find ourselves in a peculiar moment where everything is on fire and all we do remain calm and carry on (or “Hang in there, baby!” as the old poster of a cat hanging from a branch tells us).⁴ And just maybe, we will have enough wherewithal to put out one or two small fires while there’s still time.⁵



0.1 Panels from KC Green’s “On Fire” comic strip. *Gunshow*, 2013, gunshowcomic.com. It circulated on 4chan and Reddit and later became a meme during the 2016 US presidential election cycle. “©KC Green, kcgreendotcom.com.

As we stand on the precipice of yet-another US presidential election cycle, I am struck by both how much and how little has changed since 2016. This book is an attempt to understand how the fires started and how we might extinguish them. It focuses on an important and often overlooked source of tinder—the ways that the culture of Silicon Valley, platform politics, and online communities intersect. In gaming circles, when characters gain new powers and abilities, they are said to have “leveled up.” My use of this phrase in the book’s title is a nod to the ways that Silicon Valley has helped to mainstream far-right politics in the US and globally.

In particular, I argue that the design of sites like Facebook, Reddit, and Twitter/X has implicitly amplified and mainstreamed what pundits have problematically called the *alt-right* (an abbreviation for *alternative right*),⁶ a loose coalition of misogynists, White nationalists and identitarians, far-right ideologues, anti-Semites, and Islamophobes. While the ideologies that these groups espouse are not new, they have effectively embraced social media as a means of recruitment and as a tool to harass and terrorize opponents. Additionally, these often leaderless and mostly anonymous communities have demonstrated an uncanny ability to harness the organizing potential of spaces like 4chan, Reddit, and other social media to disseminate information in a way that can easily be dismissed as a form of online play. And increasingly, their odious politics have become integrated into mainstream conservative thought (by the GOP in the US and by other right-wing political groups internationally). For those unaware of these complexities between platforms, design, and play, the ascendance of the alt-right seemed to happen almost overnight. But for those who have been studying online culture since the internet's large-scale adoption in the 1990s, this is but the most recent incarnation of a problematic and relatively untold story.

This is not a book about games or democracy, despite having both subjects in the title. It lives somewhere at the intersection of both topics, but I'm not a political science scholar. And it's not about games per se. I do play games, and I occasionally write about them, but I'm using games as more of a metaphor here. My interest is in how internet spaces structure our participation through their design and affordances (more on this later) and how the unstated values that engineers, designers, and, most important, marketers⁷ hold are crafted into these platforms. And given that games structure our everyday lives—from racking up likes on Instagram to competing against others on our Peloton bikes to tracking our fitness goals on our Apple Watches—understanding how the underlying logic of gaming has permeated social media and politics is critical. This is especially true now, when so many of the individuals we see becoming radicalized by far-right political ideology are fluent in the

logic of video games and gaming culture and inhabit game-friendly platforms like Discord, 4chan, Reddit, and Twitch.

It would be easy to misread my work and suggest that I think games and gaming culture are bad (I don't) or that I blame only Silicon Valley for the rise of the far right in the US and globally (I don't). Instead, I am suggesting that the connection between the two remains underexplored. Democracy is fragile, and it's increasingly clear that authoritarianism, nationalism, xenophobia, racism, and trans- and homophobia are no longer contained in the shadows but are operating out in the open with impunity. Without critically examining how platforms structure conversations and how they've been "gamed" by far-right operatives, how can we possibly address the obvious fires that are burning?

NOTES

1. Chris Plante, "'This Is Fine' Creator Explains the Timelessness of His Meme," *The Verge*, May 5, 2016, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.theverge.com/2016/5/5/11592622/this-is-fine-meme-comic>.

2. When The Nib asked Green to respond to the GOP's appropriation of his meme, he made a one-panel, red-only version in which a cartoon elephant (the symbol of the Republican Party) reenacts the comic. Later, Green created a twelve-panel version of his original "On Fire" comic in which the same dog screams "THIS IS NOT FINE" instead of "This is fine." See Chris Plante, "The Man Who Created 'This Is Fine' Now Says 'This Is Not Fine,'" *The Verge*, August 3, 2016, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.theverge.com/2016/8/3/12368634/this-is-fine-dog-meme-update-sequel-kc-green>.

3. While I was writing this book, a draft version of Supreme Court Justice Samuel Alito's majority decision overturning *Roe v. Wade* was leaked, and some people tweeted that Green's meme might have peaked too soon. And in a world that is literally on fire because of global climate change, Green's comic is sadly looking more and more prophetic.

4. Katie Rogers, "Why 'This Is Fine' Is the Meme This Year Deserves," *New York Times*, August 5, 2016, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.nytimes.com/2016/08/06/arts/this-is-fine-meme-dog-fire.html>.

5. And contrary to the trenchant critique of Billy Joel's hit "We Didn't Start the Fire," Boomers do bear quite a bit of responsibility for these fires.

6. The term *alt-right* is problematic. The term was coined by individuals affiliated with the far-right movement to deemphasize the extremist nature of their ideas,

and it has been reproduced relatively uncritically by the popular press. My use of this term is not intended to flatten the significant differences that exist between constituent groups that fall under its umbrella. For example, not all men's rights activists believe what incels (involuntary celibates) believe, nor does every incel believe the same thing as every other incel, but they are connected by some key ideological beliefs, a point I discuss later.

7. In my mind, the term *marketeer* cannot be disentangled from *Mouseketeers*, the relentlessly cheerful child performers from *The Mickey Mouse Club*. The marketeers of Silicon Valley seem equally saccharine and unflinchingly optimistic about the positive potentials of technology and dismissive of debacles like Cambridge Analytica considering them mere glitches.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

I've been writing, thinking, and teaching about the tech space for over twenty years. I also worked in several startups before, during, and after my time in grad school. This book is born from those experiences, and in many ways represents a culmination of work I've been doing around platforms, design, games, and feminist activism for most of my academic career. But more importantly, it's the product of endless conversations with friends (some human, some animal), family, colleagues, students, and scholars (some of whom I don't know personally but admire greatly)—all of which has shaped every inch of this book. Any mistakes are my own; but any smart things I have to say here are 100 percent the result of the amazing folks around me.

Part of this book was written during the spring of 2020 when I was on research leave from the University of Illinois at Chicago (UIC). The timing turned out to be super weird because of the pandemic, but it did provide me with some space from teaching to spend time reading important things and thinking hard thoughts. I'm forever grateful to the Department of Communication at UIC for allowing me that opportunity.

This book would not be what it is without the inimitable Gita Manaktala and her amazing colleagues at the MIT Press who have championed it every step of the way. Suraiya Jetha and Deborah Cantor-Adams ushered this book through the editorial process and have my deepest gratitude. I'm especially indebted to Rob Gehl and several anonymous reviewers who provided insightful feedback on

early drafts of this work (and who probably have no idea how much their thoughts improved this project).

My colleagues at both American University (2021 through the present) and the University of Illinois at Chicago (2012 to 2021) have been inspiring in so many ways and continue to challenge me to grow intellectually and personally. Thanks are due to my GAs at American University (Kirubel Ayetenfisu, Thomas Struett, and Fritz Kessler) for their research assistance. Thanks also to JA for his keen editorial eye and amusing anecdotes in the marginalia of an early draft of this book.

The best thing about being an academic is the possibility of having friends all over the world; for me, the Association of Internet Researchers (AoIR) has made that possible. I've considered AoIR my intellectual home since I was a grad student, and many of the seeds of this book were planted during presentations or while talking with colleagues at AoIR conferences.

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And finally, to my fellow Sidewalk Adventurers in Chicago (Washington FPA) and DC (NOMA PP), and everywhere else who show up early on Saturday mornings to stand up for reproductive

rights—you continue to amaze and inspire me. Thank you for all that you do.

1

THE GAME ACCORDING TO SILICON VALLEY

Let's play a game. It's a game designed by Silicon Valley, and we've been playing it for about twenty years. It takes place mostly online.

In this game, we're told we're all equal. We will no longer have to worry about the differences that matter in the "real world," like gender and race, because they won't matter in this game. We are assured by the game's designers that they have our best interests at heart because they are self-made entrepreneurial geeks who dropped out of Harvard so they could move to Palo Alto and start a company in a garage. We are reminded repeatedly that any attempts to bring in outside referees (like the government) to ensure this game is being played fairly will mean play will no longer be fun or free or pay the designers of this game for their hard work and genius. It's better to let the game designers be in control.

The game starts, and play begins. At first, things seem okay. Fun even. Discussion boards, personal webpages, and Usenet groups abound. Memes flourish. "Numa Numa" guy begins Numa Numa-ing.¹ People connect to others around their niche interests on discussion boards, mailing lists, and blogs. There is also harassment and flaming. But that kind of behavior is mostly contained to specific communities and often dies out quickly because there's no easy way to bridge the gap between sites like GeoCities and LiveJournal. Never mind that the *lingua franca* for this game is assumed to be English (even though players live all over the world) or that not

everyone has the technology to play the game.² And please ignore that the game itself is built on a closed system owned by a few large companies and not the public.³ “Just play,” they say.

The game designers decide to make things more interesting. They introduce social media. Web 2.0 they call it. Suddenly, all of us are invited to be publishers—to create content. We’ll be provided with the platforms to publish our deepest thoughts and opinions—all for free! We will finally have the public square we’ve been longing for since the Greek agora, and the “marketplace of ideas” will ensure that only the best content will rise to the top. We’re told that our social media feeds are designed to reflect our deepest (consumerist) desires but will also enshrine liberal democracy worldwide through political activism.

Play continues. We earn likes and shares by posting. We see ads catering to our interests. In exchange, we are told we can connect to our social circles and make friends in far-flung places, keep up with our hobbies, find a job, participate in political movements, and read the news of the day. But things start shifting a bit. We start getting nervous because it seems like play is no longer optional but compulsory. If we want to exist in the new millennium, we have to create and curate and participate on all of these different platforms. If we’re lucky, we’re told, and do a good job cultivating an audience, we are rewarded with a bit of money and fame. We start noticing that a lot of these influencers look the same, but we are reassured by the game’s designers that this is just a coincidence. Still, not many of us really understand how these platforms work, and we seem to be providing a lot of personal information to the designers of this game, but we’re reassured repeatedly that it’s all safe and in our best interests. The game is certainly not addictive or harmful in any way. Our data is safe and secure, locked up in the impenetrable fortress of the designers’ server farm. No one else can see it. Now share this BuzzFeed article, “10 Pictures of Taylor Swift’s Cats Looking Like Her Exes,” before you log off.

Suddenly, some things happen that seem outside of the designers’ control. Or that’s what they tell us. While we’ve been relying for some time on these social media platforms for everything from

receiving relationship advice to understanding world events, we've been leaving behind digital traces that the game designers have decided to bundle up and sell to advertisers. Behind the scenes, our likes and dislikes and demographic information and political views have also been shaping the material we see online. We're no longer certain if our feeds are the same as those of our neighbors, and that's a problem because we're told repeatedly by the designers that our feeds represent our hopes, our dreams, and our worldviews. We are becoming increasingly suspicious of the designers' intentions. They don't even seem to know what's happening. The algorithms they've created to make gameplay more fun (they say) are just too hard for players like us to understand. The designers seem to be making lots of money and acting a lot like traditional media outlets but reassure us again that this is just coincidental and that placing any rules restricting their freedom will make the game less fun for everyone.

Around this time, a few players figure out that misinformation, outrage, clickbait, and hatred are rewarded more often in this game than earnest engagement is. These players have always existed, but now there are ways for them to amplify their harassment campaigns across platforms, thanks to algorithms the designers have created to ensure our continued attention and deliver more of the content we want to see.⁴ The players start to exploit this reality by gaming the game. We start calling them *trolls*, even though that's too cutesy a term for what many of them are doing. Some of us feel more threatened by these players than others. It's almost as if a lot of what we've been told about all players being equal in this game isn't actually true. When the trolls are told that what they're doing isn't fair play, they say that they're just joking, and anyway, *it's just a game*. The designers of the game shake their heads and say there's nothing they can do. These are just rogue players or bad actors, as they insist on calling them.

Another subset of players (who happen to have a far larger access to capital and resources than most) take note of what's happening. They start viewing the actions of these trolls as potentially useful but insufficient in helping them gain power as the

tactics are too diffuse and don't have a political message that can be exploited. So these players create one. They provide the trolls with more messaging behind their (seemingly) nihilistic memes.⁵ And they enlist other players, in the form of the mainstream media, to amplify the trolls' messages and mobilize the trolls under names—the alt-right and the intellectual dark web—that belie their intentions.⁶ These players say that they're just being "objective" and reporting "both sides" of the growing divide that we're told exists.

A bunch of in-game events happen in quick succession. First, a heated US presidential election pits a well-known and qualified woman with years of experience against a former reality television authoritarian huckster with a penchant for racism and misogyny. Thanks to the hard work of the political operatives who have been paying attention to the trolls' tactics, the wholly unqualified White nationalist wins—except he doesn't, not really. But because of some screwy game mechanics⁷ held over from another era when a lot of us weren't considered people, he is elected. Behind the scenes, we learn that part of his win has been enabled by the game designers themselves. They express regret, but, y'know, it was beyond their control.

We grow nervous. Instead of this being the cooperative game we thought it was, it suddenly seems like a winner-takes-all affair. Then a pandemic closes down everything, and we become more reliant than ever before on the game because we can't leave our houses. Antivaccine misinformation reigns. A civil rights movement roils the game and highlights that instead of starting on an equal playing field, as the designers insisted was the case, many of the players face institutional and structural limitations to their play.⁸ But other players ignore this reality and insist that the civil rights movement is actually asking for an unfair advantage. The designers are forced to allow the bad behavior to continue, they say, because the "marketplace of ideas" will take care of things.

The game seems to be spiraling out of control. And yet most of the designers still insist they have nothing to do with its outcome. A few start splintering off, though, often publishing mea culpas in op-eds or appearing in documentaries that are streamed on services

dependent on the same technologies they are decrying.⁹ They admit that the technologies they've created are doing harm—especially for younger players—but remain as relatively befuddled as the rest of us are about how we can stop playing. Another US presidential election occurs, and this time, the White nationalist is defeated. But the tentacles of the political operation that vaulted him into power are still there and have fully infiltrated every institution (even those outside this game). A group of players—who act an awful lot like nonplayer characters (NPCs)¹⁰ but insist that they're actually players—decide to attack the US Capitol. Chaos ensues, democracy falters, and we, the people, lose. The designers shrug their shoulders and say the players ruined the game—not that it was rigged or that the designers had any role in how things played out.

Sound familiar?

The morning of the US Capitol insurrection, January 6, 2021, I was aimlessly doomscrolling, writing (mostly not writing) this book, and watching the news on CNN that was coming out of Washington, DC, as the November 2020 election results for Joe Biden's presidency were being certified in the House of Representatives. As news broke of the insurrection and perhaps as an unconscious nod to the game scenario told above, I posted to Facebook: "This game of Civ is getting a little too intense, y'all."¹¹ Watching supporters of Donald Trump storm the houses of Congress while doing their best (and failing miserably) to cosplay as "patriots" was not something I had on my bingo card for 2021, and yet here we were. I was shocked—not because the events of January 6 were unexpected but because they were so damned predictable. The violence that day had been clearly telegraphed for months, and yet no one seemed to be doing anything to stop it.

In the weeks that followed January 6, pundits and journalists spent a lot of time offering unhelpful variations of "OMG, how could this happen?!?" as if no one could have seen the insurrection coming. However, a large contingent of individuals who had been studying members of the alt-right and their chatter on social media and elsewhere had been raising the alarm that events like those of January 6 were all but inevitable. Many of those who had been

warning us for years—about the danger of Trumpism, the emboldened far right in the US (and creeping fascism worldwide), and the real-life violence that online harassment might portend—had seen the signs in #Gamergate, an earlier digital harassment movement. Something was happening that connected these angry gamers and transformed them into a larger political force that found its figurehead in Donald Trump. The assemblage of platforms, politics, and cultures of social media combined forces into some awful hydra when it met the 2020 US Presidential election. And then it further exploded during the 2021 insurrection. It's that story that this book tells.

In the wake of the insurrection, social media did what it does and frantically created and shared memes about the event. Most of them emphasized the foibles of the insurrectionists. For example, images of the so-called QAnon Shaman (real name Jacob Chansley) regularly appeared with commentary that emphasized the ridiculousness of his attire: he was shirtless, he wore a headdress made of horns and fur, and his face was painted red, white, and blue to resemble the American flag.¹² But the ridiculousness that accompanied the absurdity of seeing Chansley in the atrium of the Capitol (alongside others dressed in tactical gear, camouflage, and Punisher skeleton symbols; waving Pepe the Frog, Confederate, and Trump flags; and posting selfies on Facebook, Parler, TikTok, and Twitter) belied the violent, fascist reality of what was actually happening.¹³ It was easier to focus on the absurdity of seeing someone in smeared face paint in the hallowed halls of Congress than to come to terms with the numerous violent hate symbols that were also a part of the insurrection's Stop the Steal riot.

The image that most stood out to me in the weeks that followed was a meme that reimagined the rioters scaling the walls of the Capitol steps as if they were characters in Nintendo's classic video game franchise *Donkey Kong*. The seditionists were pictured as if they were trying to climb the ladders in the first *Donkey Kong* arcade game while Donkey Kong throws barrels at Mario (in his first appearance). To reinforce the reference to the game (and the inherent Whiteness of the insurrection), the meme includes the

words “Honkey Kong” emblazoned on it in a cheerful font ([figure 1.1](#)).¹⁴



[1.1](#) The Honkey Kong meme that circulated after January 6, 2021, featuring a photo of insurrectionists climbing the US Capitol building envisioned as a scene from Nintendo’s classic video game franchise *Donkey Kong*.

While I was already deeply in the weeds of this manuscript when January 6 happened, the Honkey Kong image became my urtext (or ur-meme) soon after its appearance. It encapsulates this book’s major argument—that gaming culture has permeated all facets of American (and global) society; that “fan revolts” like #Gamergate

have paved the way for far-right/alt-right activism; that spaces like 4chan and Reddit have fanned the flames of toxicity and moved them from the fringes to the mainstream; and that the most dangerous thing we can do is to ignore the way that Silicon Valley culture has embedded itself into the social media platforms we use on a daily basis—increasingly to the detriment of our democratic institutions—and welcomed far-right activism.

I discuss three case studies—#Gamergate, Donglegate, and r/The_Donald—to offer readers a sense of how and why far-right politics has increasingly become intertwined with the culture of Silicon Valley. I demonstrate how various individuals and groups have gamed social media through play and how toxic geek masculinity has become interwoven with Trumpism. These events have taken place over the last ten or so years. In looking back over the last decade, I provide a broad context for how both the populist appeals of the alt-right in the US and the resurgence of far-right politics globally have been enabled by online platforms and video game culture, and I hope it will help us better understand how we might stop democracy from disappearing entirely.

THE FAR RIGHT IN SHEEP'S CLOTHING: DEFINING THE *ALT-RIGHT*

Over the course of researching and writing this book, the political landscape of the US has shifted dramatically as the mainstream Republican Party (in the US) moved increasingly to the right. People like Lauren Boebert, Matt Gaetz, and Marjorie Taylor Greene (members of the so-called Freedom Caucus in the US House of Representatives) gained prominence in the wake of Trump's presidency and represented a new form of right-wing politics. The seeds of this shift were in play long before Trump's 2016 election, but for many of us, this radical move seemed to have happened overnight.¹⁵ And in keeping with our new media environment, the anger and bile fomented online by these right-wing groups have been reflected back into the mainstream media and public discourse.

This new strain of hard-line right-wing ideology and angry, meme-laden online discourse has been referred to as the *alt-right* by both the media and proponents. This pithy, yet problematic term belies the reality of the misogynistic White supremacist ideology that exists at its core. Many have rightly suggested that the phrase cloaks the racist, misogynist, and transphobic intent of proponents who claim that it's merely an alternative to other forms of right-wing politics.¹⁶ The phrase also obfuscates the ideology of hatred that is embodied in the alt-right and has become mainstreamed in Republican politics in the US (and populist politics worldwide). At the same time, the term has been commonly used by journalists covering Trump—his campaign in 2015 and 2016, presidency in 2017 to 2020, first reelection campaign in 2019 and 2020, and second reelection campaign in 2023.¹⁷ As Benjamin Moffitt argues, the alt-right represents a worldview and a style of political discourse. He notes that this discursive style represents “a break from the ‘mainstream’ in terms of observing political conduct norms: namely, a rejection of ‘civility,’ an embrace of vulgarity and edgy ‘humor,’ and the adoption of an adversarial and often deliberately offensive approach to political opponents.”¹⁸

The term's origins are somewhat opaque. In late 2008, paleoconservative Paul Gottfried discussed the burgeoning ascendance of a new, younger, conservative public, which he referred to as the “alternative right.”¹⁹ Later, in 2010, White nationalist/identitarian Richard Spencer (drawing on Gottfried's ideas) launched a website called AlternativeRight.com.²⁰ Spencer popularized the term *alt-right* in an effort to distinguish his form of White nationalism as merely an “alternative” to conservative thought.²¹ According to the Southern Poverty Law Center, alt-right adherents “eschew ‘establishment’ conservatism, skew young, and embrace white ethnonationalism as a fundamental value.”²² Matthew N. Lyons emphasizes its connection to ironic internet culture, arguing that individuals share “a contempt for both liberal multiculturalism and mainstream conservatism; a belief that some people are inherently superior to others; a strong internet presence and embrace of specific elements of online culture; and a self-

presentation as being new, hip, and irreverent.”²³ According to journalist Mike Wendling, the alt-right is an amalgam of four different groups—intellectuals (folks like Spencer), racialsists (individuals from already active online White nationalist groups like Stormfront and The Daily Stormer), channers (denizens of 4chan and other imageboards), and meninists (communities dedicated to men’s rights and antifeminism).²⁴ While the alt-right is not a phenomenon limited to the US, the centrality of spaces like 4chan and Reddit for mainstreaming alt-right communities (and their largely American, White, cisgender, and heterosexual male audiences) cannot be overstated.²⁵ However, the alt-right is also difficult to define because it encompasses contradictory perspectives and communities that might otherwise be at odds with each other.

Many have equated Donald Trump’s presidency with the ascendance of the alt-right, but there’s also a crossover with other, less explicitly political strands—especially within online spaces. For example, the manosphere—an informal collection of subreddits and blogs dedicated to the men’s rights movement and more extreme spaces such as those dedicated to incels (involuntary celibates) and Red Pillers (men who dispute systemic sexism, believing themselves to be oppressed by the gains of feminism and the purported power that woman hold in heterosexual romantic relationships)—overlaps with the alt right’s antifeminist rhetoric and general misogyny. However, it’s hard to imagine that figures like mansosphere influencer Andrew Tate or former Breitbart News editor and now-disgraced social media gadfly Milo Yiannopolous do not think that the typical incel is a sad sack who has only himself to blame for not getting laid, even if they all hate women and think “feminism is cancer.”²⁶ And Gavin McInnes, self-described “Western chauvinist” and founder of the Proud Boys, would likely view the average gamer who was radicalized through #Gamergate as both oddly fixated on a hobby for kids and questionably dressed. What, then, connects these disparate figures?

First, they harness a particular outrage about a perceived decline of White maleness. This is rooted in a feeling of *aggrieved entitlement*—a sense shared by many White men (and some

women) that they are somehow losing what they were promised because of gains made by others.²⁷ While in part reflecting real, long-term demographic shifts in the US (and worldwide), the alt-right harnesses a particular narrative that suggests the supremacy of the White experience and encourages adherents to feel victimized and angry. For these individuals, gains in the civil rights of minorities and the success of movements like #BlackLivesMatters and #MeToo are proof that their own identity and centrality are on the decline. Individuals who align with the alt-right not only are suspicious of mainstream arguments made by both conservatives and liberals about race- and gender-based discrimination (and deny that it exists) but think they are on the receiving end of discrimination based on their identity. This also connects to the ways in which Whiteness is discussed (or is not discussed) within the US. As critical race scholars have long argued, a kind of color-blind racism precludes real conversations about race and the privileges of Whiteness in the US.²⁸ In particular, it creates a kind of defensive posture, in which any attempts to connect Whiteness to larger systems of privilege are angrily denied. The alt-right takes this White fragility a step further, making Whiteness something that is under attack and threatened, suggesting it is a marginalized identity rather than a dominant, hegemonic force. And this identity becomes intertwined with a nostalgia for “traditional” masculinity.²⁹ Thus, the alt-right often conjoins two ideas—White supremacy/White nationalism (whether stated outright by figures like Richard Spencer or merely present in the form of racist dog whistles) and hegemonic masculinity.³⁰

Second, the alt-right projects the decline in status of White men as being caused by the gains made by others. As John M. Berger argues, extremism requires an out-group (or several) to which the in-group’s ire is directed.³¹ For the alt-right, this includes a wide variety of targets, including immigrants, Muslims, women, members of the LGBTQIA+ community, Jews, people of color, liberals, academics (especially those who work in the humanities or other “soft” disciplines), and the disabled. Many of these individuals are accused of being *social justice warriors* or SJWs—a pejorative term

that gained traction online during #Gamergate (discussed further in the next chapter) but is now frequently used by right-leaning pundits and mainstream conservative news outlets such as Fox News. A reformulation of the term *keyboard warrior*, which early online communities used to refer to people who wrote screeds against a given individual or group, the SJW is pictured as a neurotic, “feminist killjoy” who lives only to spoil others’ fun.³² In this formulation, SJW figures are both monstrous and threatening in their attempts to police political correctness.³³ For the alt-right, the SJW represents a kind of threat that connects a vast set of disparate individuals—for example, the denizens of 4chan’s /pol/ (political incorrect) imageboard, men’s rights activists, #Gamergate supporters, and Trump champions—who might have different political leanings but share a disdain for identity politics. And while it might be easy to dismiss this trope as simply an online boogeyman, research into extremist groups suggests that over time, demonizing out-group members presents a real possibility of radical action or violence against out-group members.³⁴

Third, denizens of the alt-right view these out-groups as restricting unfairly their right to speak. Invoking earlier moral panics about political correctness and the campus culture wars from the 1990s, the alt-right is suspicious about contemporary political discourse. In their formulation, liberals are overly preoccupied with concepts like civility and identity and use these concerns as a weapon to restrict certain ideas from being expressed. College campuses are seen as particular hotbeds of political correctness and thus are viewed with suspicion. University professors are portrayed as dangerous ideologues, invested in exposing their students to Marxist and postmodern thought. This so-called cultural Marxism is most often equated with the humanities and social sciences, both of which the alt-right generally views as “soft” because of the methods scholars in these areas employ (often qualitative or critical and thus perceived as unscientific or biased) and their subject matter (often messy things like values and human experience rather than pure science like chemistry, biology, and physics). And while conservatives have long made university campuses a favorite target, the alt-right

has found new life in critiquing a wave of curricular changes across universities meant to reflect the important work that queer folks, women, people of color, disabled people, and indigenous individuals have produced and that has often been left out of many disciplines. Coupled with the increasing diversity of college campuses and the fact that many Millennials and Gen Z members embrace far more liberal views on race and sexuality than prior generations, universities are a primary threat to the White supremacist project the alt-right embraces.³⁵

Fourth, the alt-right's ideology is uniquely spread and amplified online. These groups engage in irony and a language of trolling or shitposting as a way to cloak and disavow the intention behind these messages. As Rob May and Matthew Feldman note, this aspect of the alt-right is not new, as "speaking in forked tongues to a wider public while signalling a fealty to committed activists has long been a tactic for the postwar far right."³⁶ But the speed and ease with which this material spreads *are* new. More important, the alt-right has shaped the discursive contours of online platforms. This is because conversations that happen in, for example, Reddit's r/The_Donald (a community that supported Donald Trump discussed in chapter 4) are not simply limited to those spaces. Members of the r/The_Donald subreddit were also active participants in other subreddits and across social media more broadly. In a media ecosystem where mis- and disinformation, clickbait, hot takes, and conspiracy theories are easily disseminated, the alt-right thrives. Coupled with its members' technical prowess and creativity (hallmarks of spaces like Reddit and 4chan) and a nihilistic worldview, this chaotic coalition increasingly dominates political life online. The so-called intellectual dark web (also discussed in chapter 4) has also provided convenient, mainstream cover for alt-right ideology. Most often associated with figures like Sam Harris, Jordan Peterson, Joe Rogan, and Dave Rubin, these podcasters, pundits, and provocateurs often profess a disinterest in politics (or characterize themselves as classic liberals). At the same time, they create expansive social media presences that implicitly promote ideas and feature podcast guests embraced by the alt-right in the guise of "free speech."³⁷

Finally, the alt-right effectively mobilizes online mob action to perpetuate conspiracy theories and sustained harassment campaigns against its perceived enemies. Events like #Gamergate and conspiracy theories like #Pizzagate and QAnon (see chapter 2) have been used to both recruit new adherents and stoke further paranoia. Conspiracy theories, as David Aaronovitch argues, are often populist in nature and encourage believers to see themselves as the true intellects—above the “sheeple” who refuse to see the plain truth in front of their faces.³⁸ Embedded in the alt-right is a sense of paranoia and cultural persecution that often finds purchase in the form of conspiracy theories that target particular groups. Extremists often make the argument that out-groups control their fate—with a shadowy and powerful elite at the helm that must be stopped at any cost.³⁹

These connections are broad, general strokes. There are significant differences between, for example, an incel and someone who belongs to the American Identity Movement (a group devoted to White nationalism). The former is motivated more by sexual frustration and less by racial resentment than the latter is, but both individuals would likely share the same sort of aggrieved entitlement that they were somehow being deprived and oppressed by out-group members. Who constitutes this out-group varies, however. For the incel, it would likely be women and feminists, and for the White identitarian, it would be immigrants and people of color. What does connect these seemingly disparate groups is their embrace of geek/nerd masculinity as a marginalized identity (a point I discuss more in chapter 3) and their technical prowess and comfort with the discursive possibilities of certain online communities.

It’s increasingly clear that the underlying political ideology and populist and confrontational style of the alt-right has become embedded within the mainstream Republican Party. Fealty to Donald Trump (or rather the *idea* of Trump since he does not hold political office at this time) has become a kind of litmus test for many seeking support from the GOP. During his presidency, individuals like Steve Bannon (former Breitbart News chair) and Stephen Miller (former adviser to President Trump) were the hidden architects

behind Trump's politics, while the Oath Keepers, the Proud Boys, and other militia groups constituted its armed public face (they were prominent during the January 6 insurrection and are a continued force in linking these political ideologies to violence).⁴⁰ However, since Trump left office on January 20, 2021, the reality is that mainline conservatism *is* the alt-right. With few exceptions, the GOP has embraced a form of Christian nationalism that is almost indistinguishable from the alt-right of 2016.⁴¹ Likewise, far-right populist politics continue to dominate in other countries as well, where many of the same nationalist, xenophobic, and transphobic appeals are becoming popularized as mainstream political discourse.

PLATFORMS AND THEIR POLITICS

The ascendance of the alt-right is due in no small part to the current online media landscape. Social media platforms have played an outsized presence in mainstreaming and amplifying the alt-right, so understanding how their culture and design intersect is critical. In addition, the larger media environment in which these platforms sit is increasingly consolidated, centralized, and monolithic, with a few media and technology companies controlling a large percentage of content shared on- and offline.⁴² Simultaneously, we see platforms monetizing content created by users. While this is potentially liberating as these spaces are at the heart of what Henry Jenkins terms "participatory culture," we are also subject to new forms of digital selfhood in which we are increasingly datafied, commodified, and algorithmically organized.⁴³ Critically, the consequences of datafication and these algorithmic logics are not evenly distributed, as Safiya Umoja Noble and others argue persuasively; they often act as a kind of "technological redlining" depending on a person's social location.⁴⁴ This is largely a result of the way designers think about their audiences and the political and economic realities of the technology industry.

At its core, design is a rhetorical, persuasive act directed toward solving "wicked problems."⁴⁵ The word *design* is used as both a noun and a verb—as an artifact that is created and as the process by

which that artifact is made. Early computer histories demonstrate a tendency for software developers (who were simultaneously responsible for these programs and their interfaces) to see design as an afterthought. Functionality was more important than usability, and so early computer programs were often utilitarian and reflected an autobiographical approach to design, where developers pictured themselves as the target audience for a given program. Users were an afterthought or viewed as a problem to be solved. As personal computers gained a foothold in homes and businesses, this kind of systems-centered design shifted. In the 1980s, Donald Norman's work foregrounded the importance of designing for those who were actually using these devices and popularized the concept of *affordances*—or the actions that we think we can take when faced with a particular set of design elements.⁴⁶ With the widespread adoption of the internet in the 1990s, this approach became formalized into user-centered design. Designers were encouraged to research their user base or audience using qualitative approaches. These included methods like contextual interviewing (talking with potential users), personas (creating prototypical users for whom the interface is designed), and usability tests (walkthroughs of potential interface designs with users).⁴⁷ Contemporary design practice focuses more on what is known as rapid development (whereby potential designs are quickly iterated and deployed to users) and A/B testing (with metrics such as clickthrough or revenue rates serving as primary data for whether a given design is successful).

While user research and usability testing are still used in the initial phases of the design process, A/B testing is largely the norm, as it fits Silicon Valley's endless desire for metric-based decision making and mirrors its "Move fast and break things" ethos.⁴⁸ It also echoes a larger cultural shift that's been happening toward using big data and analytics as tools for personal improvement in every aspect of everyday life, from exercise to sex, and this shift is championed and embraced by the denizens of Silicon Valley (more on this in chapter 3).⁴⁹ Each of these approaches positions designers (and developers) as somehow apart from users and provides little in the way of actual audience input in the design process. Less common in large US

technology firms are design approaches that equalize the power differential between user and designer. These range from relatively well-known formalized participatory design approaches (such as collaborative prototyping) to radical design, feminist human-computer interaction (HCI), and design that is oriented toward social justice.⁵⁰ These approaches are especially valuable when working with marginalized audiences or indigenous populations, but they are seen largely as irrelevant, unnecessary, time-consuming, and costly and thus rarely embraced by large technology firms. In addition, involving “outsiders” in the design of new technologies is often couched as a security risk that might threaten the ability of a given company to retain its competitive edge.

The political and economic realities of technology companies are often at odds with the goals of any design process, especially those that might enlist potential users as codesigners. For example, companies often use the proprietary, patentable nature of their technology as a rationale for why these more egalitarian design techniques are not desirable or possible to implement. In their stead, designers must rely on other methods (like the persona approach) that often create simulations of the audience for their designs. These kinds of techniques focus on a particular type of person as a prototypical user—one who is almost always middle-class, heterosexual, cisgendered, able-bodied, and White. While the desire to empathize as a first step toward creating a usable interface or product is ostensibly well-meaning, it can quickly become patronizing and reductionist.⁵¹ But it might not be just the tools that are commonly used to support design thinking that are problematic. As Ruha Benjamin argues, “design [itself] is a colonizing project.”⁵²

Broadening out from the specific design approach taken, platforms and their politics are shaped by two larger factors. The first is their role as actors under capitalism. This is a critical component of the ways that we might understand these companies’ actions (and that scholars such as Nick Srnicek argue should form the primary way of thinking about them), but this is not the focus of my analysis.⁵³ Instead, I am interested in the second factor that shapes platforms and their politics—the cultural backdrop in which

platforms, politics, and their communities intersect. To this end, this book explores how culture, design, and platforms intertwine in a kind of *platform politics*. This phrase is inspired by Tarleton Gillespie's work on the ways that the term *platform* has been deployed by technology companies and strategically works to encourage a particular way of thinking about these spaces by users and potential regulators.⁵⁴ Like other work within science and technology studies (STS) and the social construction of technology (SCOT), this approach attunes us to the reality that platforms are not just neutral technological objects but reflect certain assumptions about how and by whom they are to be used. These ensure platforms will be viewed by the press, public, and regulators in particular ways—most often those that just so happen to work in these companies' favor. For example, YouTube insists that it is just a platform for user-generated content, despite the ways in which adults can be radicalized on it and children might be exposed to its disturbing content.⁵⁵ Rather than reflecting its realities—a complex and large-scale assemblage of advertising and monetization strategies, minimal content oversight, algorithmic logics, and a larger attention economy that almost inevitably ensures that extremist content will spread prolifically—the company suggests any problems the press or public unearths are mere glitches or one-off issues. By minimizing these realities, technology companies implicitly welcome more of this disturbing content under the guise of simply providing a service, and they fail to acknowledge their outsized role in shaping public discourse.

This book argues that the platform politics of social media also reflect a larger cyber- and technolibertarian perspective that permeates Silicon Valley (a point I discuss further in chapter 3).⁵⁶ Hallmarks of this perspective include meritocratic explanations for success and failure, an embrace of technology as a force for social good, a disdain for technology regulation, a blurring of the boundaries between work and play, a kind of free-speech absolutism, and an embrace of capitalism and free-market economic policies. One of the defining features of Silicon Valley's cyberlibertarianism can be seen in how online platforms approach

issues of speech. With few exceptions, social media companies have wielded the protections provided under section 230 of the Communications Decency Act of 1996 (which in the US suggests that internet companies are not liable for the speech of people using their services) as a shield against regulation, despite the ways the Metas and Googles of the world act as de facto media companies.⁵⁷ While this approach to speech conveniently lets these companies off the hook for legal liability, it also reflects a particular technocratic belief that rational discourse will ultimately prevail in the marketplace of ideas.

This kind of ideology is present in early manifestos about the web. For example, John Perry Barlow's "A Declaration of the Independence of Cyberspace" from 1996 repeats a well-worn Cartesian fallacy (that the mind and body are split) and claims that cyberspace is ultimately free of the cultural prejudices that taint "meatspace" (and thus is more rational).⁵⁸ Given ample evidence to the contrary (including numerous privacy breaches, the Cambridge Analytica scandal, the explosion of extremist content, and the rapid proliferation of dis- and misinformation online), Barlow's manifesto now reads as not only naive and utopian but patently arrogant. And the public pays the price while tech companies continue to hide behind section 230 as if it's a cloak of invisibility.⁵⁹ Unfortunately, coupled with a dysfunctional and hyperpartisan Congress, a conservative SCOTUS majority, and a risk-adverse Federal Communications Commission heavily tilted toward free-marketeers and self-regulation, this brandishing of section 230 as a shield against regulation is unlikely to change any time soon. While countries in the European Union and elsewhere have taken steps to reduce hate speech online, make algorithms more transparent, and limit personal data collection by corporations, the US continues to lag far behind in limiting Silicon Valley's reach.

It's also important to note how Silicon Valley's general approach to free speech is reflected in specific design choices and policies. As Alexander Cho and others have suggested, assumptions about the default "publicness" of content on most social media platforms, for example, are normative, often "rehearsing a hegemonic gaze that

assumes that the public is neutral terrain.”⁶⁰ In turn, this logic provides a way to monetize and commodify online behaviors and requires users (particularly marginalized ones) to either conform to or work around platform designs that are fundamentally unsafe. Additionally, spaces like Facebook and Reddit often rely on a vast network of un(der)paid workers to moderate the content that flows through their networks. These individuals are often contract workers who encounter the worst of humanity daily online—animal cruelty, child pornography, hate speech, and graphic violence—while working in metric-driven environments that provide relatively little in the way of mental health resources or support.⁶¹ And this, I would argue, is by design. If social media companies addressed the real toll this material has on their own workforce, they would be tacitly acknowledging the significant role they play in spreading and amplifying it and ultimately invite regulation.

A final important aspect of Silicon Valley culture (a concept I explore further in chapter 3) is geek masculinity. Geek or nerd masculinity, as developed by Lori Kendall and others, repudiates some aspects of hegemonic masculinity while embracing others.⁶² It embraces niche technical interests (like computers, comics, video games, and programming) and eschews overt elements of hegemonic masculinity (like sports and sexual prowess). While not always toxic, many expressions of geek masculinity in fan communities often perform gatekeeping functions, and they either covertly or overtly (as in the case of #Gamergate) imply that anyone who is not a straight White cisgender and heterosexual man is unwelcome to participate. At the same time, geeks or nerds see themselves as victims of a larger social structure that valorizes the jock and the sexually successful ladies’ man. This remains true despite the reality that geeks increasingly hold significant amounts of economic and social capital, as individuals such as Jeff Bezos and Elon Musk demonstrate. This creates a tension that is never quite resolved: geek masculinity represents a marginalized status in relation to hegemonic masculinity but also confers a certain amount of privilege.⁶³

THE GAMES WE ALL PLAY

Media coverage of the alt-right often suggests it has been made by the internet. While this argument is an oversimplification, there's no denying that the alt-right successfully mobilized the culture of internet spaces such as 4chan and Reddit to recruit and radicalize individuals. Through memes and a form of ambivalent play, the alt-right's ideological messaging has become interwoven with everyone's everyday experiences.⁶⁴ Internet-born phenomena such as Pepe the Frog and terminology such as *social justice warriors* (SJWs) and *cultural Marxism* are now part of the political lexicon writ large. However, certain real-world events—like the August 2017 murder of Heather Heyer during a Unite the Right rally in Charlottesville, Virginia, and the January 6, 2021, insurrection at the US Capitol—remind us that the play that characterizes 4chan's /pol/ board or Reddit's r/The_Donald community is not about superficial online fun but has deeper roots and darker consequences. While online misogyny and White supremacy are nothing new, our collective ability to dismiss memes and trolling as mere play is both problematic and insufficient. In chapter 4, I argue that much of this material is better understood as a form of what Richard Schickel has termed “dark play”⁶⁵ (or what game scholar Aaron Trammell might simply call play), in which only a portion of those involved recognize the goals of the game.⁶⁶

Play and games shape our everyday lives. Early scholarship within game studies suggested play was integral to the development of culture, hence the title of Johan Huizinga's influential 1938 book, *Homo Ludens: A Study of the Play-Element in Culture*, which argues that play is distinct from other aspects of our lives (like work).⁶⁷ Later research by anthropologist Clifford Geertz underscores the way that play reflects cultural values.⁶⁸ Still, it could be easy to dismiss games and video gaming as a niche hobby—the domain (we're told) of mostly young, White men. However, the reality is far more complex. Video games are a multibillion-dollar industry, far larger than the global box office receipts of Hollywood films.⁶⁹ This means that many of us are playing games all the time—mobile phone

casual games like *Candy Crush*, action-adventure console games like *Legend of Zelda*, massively multiplayer online (MMO) games like *World of Warcraft*, and sandbox games like *Minecraft*. The largest gaming companies (referred to in the industry as AAA or triple-A studios), however, continue to imagine a particular demographic when designing and marketing their games. This core gamer is typically a young, straight, cisgendered White man. This limited perspective shapes both the kinds of games made by large studios and the ways some players think about who should play games and what kinds of games they should play. We often see this in the ways that gaming fans themselves argue about who constitutes a gamer, as if it were a singular (and marginalized) identity (a point to which I return in chapter 2).⁷⁰

Women and girls have always played games, but their status as gamers has been fraught since the arcade days of the 1970s.⁷¹ As marginalized media objects from the beginning, games have been legitimized by video game companies and game scholars who point to their potential educational benefits, such as encouraging young peoples' interest in the STEM fields (science, technology, engineering, and math) and teaching what James Paul Gee calls "semiotic domains."⁷² For a long time, this led to interest in making games that target girls and women (unfortunately, these two groups were often conflated) instead of broadening the kinds of representations and playing styles seen in triple-A titles. But the rise of independent game studios has encouraged a growing desire to diversify the gaming industry and a recognition that women, queer folks, and BIPOC (Black, Indigenous, and people of color) all play (and make) games. These changes have not been welcomed by everyone. A small but vocal subset of the gaming community has loudly protested this diversification, as evidenced by the hashtag activist campaign #Gamergate (discussed in detail in chapter 2). This 2014 event (and the ongoing #Gamergate-inspired harassment of women game developers, journalists, and critics) has prompted a divisive conversation about the role of women and minorities in gaming communities and the inadequate responses of online

platforms to those who harass, intimidate, and otherwise suppress others.

Moving beyond the actual events of #Gamergate, pockets of online culture are intensely influenced by games as a cultural product and by play more broadly. Platforms like 4chan, which is alternatively derided as “cesspool” nearly in the same breath as it is lauded as a “meme factory,” are steeped in gaming culture.⁷³ This gaming culture familiarity takes several forms. First, these communities share an enormous amount of content that refers to games and gaming fandom. We can see this on spaces like Reddit, where numerous communities (subreddits) discuss specific video games (such as r/Terraria) or gaming culture more broadly (such as r/Games). But even moving beyond specific communities dedicated to games, conversations that occur across Reddit or 4chan assume a basic familiarity with games and geek culture more broadly.⁷⁴ Knowledge of games and gaming culture serves as a kind of subcultural capital in these spaces.⁷⁵ Second, and perhaps less obvious, Reddit (in particular) is structured as a kind of game. Reddit members (Redditors) upvote and downvote material. Individual accounts, in turn, receive what are known as karma points that mark their overall contribution to the community. Karma points, while meaningless outside of Reddit, have endogenous value on the platform. Famous Reddit accounts typically have exceptionally high karma points, are often mentioned by username, are well known across the platform, and often receive Reddit coins and awards from other users for comments found to be interesting or otherwise worthy in some way.⁷⁶ Third, and critical for this project, play inform the kinds of interactions that happen on these platforms. While humorous memes are a popular example of this play, more insidious is a kind of “dark play” (discussed in more detail in chapter 4)—a blurring of the lines between play, seriousness, nihilism, and earnestness, all wrapped up in a veneer of ironic detachment and easily dismissible as simply trolling.

One of the more important concepts (and a major sticking point) in the field of game studies has been the magic circle, formalized by game designers Katie Salen and Eric Zimmerman in their influential

text *Rules of Play: Game Design Fundamentals*.⁷⁷ The magic circle was originally offered by Huizinga as a way to articulate the theoretical space that games (and play) inhabit and to emphasize that this space is separate from the real world. When we play a game of tag, for example, we collectively agree that the goal of the game is for one person who is “it” to tap a second person on the shoulder, which makes that person “it.” Outside of the playground, this action would be perplexing or unwelcome. Strangers in a coffee shop probably would be confused if I suddenly tapped them, yelling “You’re it,” and ran away. Likewise, if I tried to pay for a coffee with *Monopoly* money, the barista probably would not give me the drink. These actions—shoulder tapping and using play money—have meaning only in the context of particular games (tag and *Monopoly*, respectively) and require all who play the games to recognize them as legitimate moves.⁷⁸

So there is some truth to the idea that games create a special, invisible space in which players agree to follow specific rules for the duration of the game. However, the magic circle concept has been critiqued by multiple scholars who suggest that it is both overly formalistic and too simplistic.⁷⁹ Mia Consalvo argues that play should be understood as an ongoing negotiation between competing contexts—a space in which issues of what constitutes legitimate play versus cheating, for example, are in flux.⁸⁰ This point becomes critical when we consider that the logic of games extends beyond simply the playing of games themselves. The kind of meritocratic, win-or-lose mechanics that characterize most games are also reproduced within the culture more broadly, as when billionaires are lauded as self-made entrepreneurs despite often being born into wealth and the poor are derided as lazy, shiftless, or unmotivated rather than as facing structural inequalities that make their success difficult if not impossible. Christopher A. Paul suggests that problematic meritocratic logics are embedded in many video games, making them “self-insulating and self-replicating.”⁸¹ And as Aaron Trammell notes, even our definitions of play and games are embedded in a system of Whiteness, presuming (incorrectly) that play is always pleasurable. He argues that play can be a tool for

subjugation and that we must reckon with how our definitions of play work to marginalize BIPOC experiences.⁸²

When we view play as distinctly separate from real life or as somehow not consequential, we deny its potency and power. This book's main argument is grounded in the idea that extremist groups are increasingly interested in changing the political landscape by gaming technological platforms, often using playful and easily dismissed forms of discourse (like memes). But beyond gaming the platforms themselves, the far right is actually *metagaming* democracy (a concept I return to in chapter 5). Metagames are games about and around games. The term grew out of the *Dungeons & Dragons* role-playing community and originally was a pejorative for using out-of-game knowledge to make in-game decisions. For example, the dungeon master, a narrator of the gameplay, might describe a new creature as a large, almost invisible cube of goo. If players encounter this new creature and use knowledge that they wouldn't have as their characters (that is, if they say, "Oh, this is a gelatinous cube, and if I'm not careful, it can paralyze me!"), they are metagaming. In the era of video games, the term *metagaming* grew beyond simply using out-of-game knowledge to gain an advantage within the game. The term began to be used to describe things like mods or modifications (community-created add-ons to games, such as new levels and new features), play styles that circumvent the developer's original intention (such as pacifist runs or speedruns), and tools that explicitly allow players to cheat.⁸³ In their book about metagames, Stephanie Boluk and Patrick LeMieux lean toward a more conceptual examination of metagaming by tying it to artistic avant-garde games that reflect on the nature of play and gaming culture.⁸⁴ In their closing chapter, they discuss how certain games—ones that remain true to the "ideological avatar of play"—are acceptable. But metagames that challenge the dominant nature of play—for example, by expanding calls for diversity, equity, and inclusion in games and the gaming industry—are resisted by game developers and players.

The rather expansive way I use the term *metagaming* in this book reflects the ways games have permeated our everyday lives and also

gives a nod to the larger cultural and social implications that gaming social media and technical systems has for our democratic institutions and civil society. In this case, the alt-right (and increasingly the GOP and other mainstream political parties worldwide) are actively pursuing a strategy that hopes to undermine our faith in democracy entirely. From spreading misinformation, engaging in harassment campaigns, and pursuing disingenuous arguments rather than reasoned debate, the far right and its GOP enablers are playing an entirely different game than the rest of us. And unfortunately, this metagame has been enabled by the culture of Silicon Valley and the online platforms it creates.

OVERVIEW OF THIS BOOK

In chapter 2, “From #Gamergate to the Alt-Right,” I offer the first of three case studies that examine the relationship between online platforms, Silicon Valley culture, and the alt-right. I introduce the concept of the alternative web—a collection of platforms and websites like Reddit and 4chan that embrace values (such as anonymity and free-speech absolutism) that are different from the values of mainstream social media platforms like Facebook. Parts of the alternative web have been especially effective in moving alt-right ideology into the mainstream. I then discuss the 2014 hashtag campaign #Gamergate, which demonstrated the ways that far-right and extremist movements have found certain fandom communities particularly welcoming to their ideology. I argue that #Gamergate underscored the relationship between platforms, culture, and politics and that subsequent harassment campaigns—such as #Comicsgate (a fan uprising against diversity and social justice in comics), #Ghostbustersgate (a fan uprising against the all-woman sequel to the 1984 film *Ghostbusters*), #Pizzagate (a right-wing conspiracy theory that a pedophilia ring affiliated with the Democratic Party was being run out of a Washington, DC, pizzeria), and QAnon—are rooted in similar misogynistic and racist ideologies. Members of certain online fandom communities also tap into what I am calling an *identity nostalgia*—that is, the belief that outsiders (such as, social

justice warriors, progressives, minorities, and women) present a core existential threat to their own identity (as a gamer or fan). I argue that individuals associated with the political arm of the alt-right (such as Steve Bannon, a former White House adviser and Breitbart News executive) cannily understood why gaming communities in particular could provide powerful support. In part, this was because members of these communities were steeped in the logics of games, which provided them with the technological prowess to game the affordances of social media platforms. Bannon and other operatives were able to use #Gamergate to broaden the conversation beyond diversity in games to a larger debate about diversity in society.

In chapter 3, “Geek Masculinity and the Cult(ure) of Tech,” I examine a 2017 memo written by former Google employee James Damore (a White man) that has been described as an antidiversity manifesto. I argue that his screed represents a long history within Silicon Valley of embracing individualistic rather than systemic explanations for the failure of White women and people of color in technology. This chapter unpacks the concept of geek and nerd masculinity and the ways in which it can damage marginalized communities. As a counterpoint to Damore’s manifesto, I discuss the case of Adria Richards, a Black woman and software developer who in 2013 complained on Twitter about two male conference attendees who made sexually charged jokes about the computer terms *dongle* and *forking* in her presence. This led to a series of events dubbed Donglegate by online commenters. While both Damore and Richards were later fired, Damore was welcomed into the alt-right fold, while Richards was silenced by her experience. I argue that these cases exemplify how tech culture valorizes particular bodies over others—demonstrating, as Lori Kendall suggests, that the term *nerd* conjoins the notion of technological adeptness with White, male bodies.⁸⁵ I also discuss how burgeoning spaces like the intellectual dark web (a collection of podcasters, political pundits, and journalists) have welcomed the ideas espoused by the alt-right. The intellectual dark web (and later Damore) demonstrate the right’s attempt to *game* the idea of free speech.

Chapter 4, “Reddit’s Love Affair with r/The_Donald,” revisits the notion of platform politics discussed above and in chapter 2 and offers a case study of Reddit’s r/The_Donald, the most popular, mainstream online community for Donald Trump supporters. I argue that members of this subreddit engaged in a particular kind of memetic play that is best understood as a form of dark play.⁸⁶ While it embodied elements of the carnivalesque, r/The_Donald also peddled in conspiracy theories and a common language that allowed for plausible deniability about the darker elements of the ideology that it embraces.⁸⁷ It also demonstrated how “pedes” (supporters called themselves “centipedes” or “pedes”) have become a kind of fandom identity, with the figure of Trump himself as a transmedia object. Additionally, I suggest Reddit’s platform politics provided fertile ground for this community to flourish. r/The_Donald was symptomatic of a much larger problem that Reddit administrators face—their reliance on unpaid moderation and community self-governance. I also discuss Reddit’s role as a platform that straddles both the alternative web (mentioned in chapter 2) and the mainstream media environment. My analysis suggests that r/The_Donald represented an attempt by the right to *game* politics through humor and play.

Finally, in chapter 5, “Metagaming Democracy,” I argue that each of these case studies represents aspects of the alt-right’s attempt to use technology to metagame democracy. Far-right extremist messages spread successfully in part because of the algorithmic logics and design politics of social media platforms. I argue that the alt-right has successfully manipulated spaces like Reddit and YouTube and polluted our information environment by weaponizing internet ambivalence.⁸⁸ As technology companies increasingly shape our everyday lives, the existential threat that far-right movements pose to democratic institutions grows. We must take responsibility for how these technologies reflect particular values and reconsider what role we want them to play in the future. To that end, I offer some thoughts as to how we might stop the game that the far right (and Silicon Valley) wants us to play.

NOTES

1. In 2004, Gary Brolsma uploaded to the Newgrounds site a video that he called “Numa Numa” in which he lip syncs to the Moldovan pop song “Dragostea din tei” (Love in the Linden Tree). This was an early example of a pre-YouTube viral video. Know Your Meme, “Numa Numa,” Viral Videos, March 30, 2009, updated February 8, 2019, accessed February 15, 2024, <https://knowyourmeme.com/memes/numa-numa>.

2. Not everyone has the skills or access to the infrastructure needed to use the internet. This difference in access is often referred to as the *digital divide*.

3. The internet, in addition to being mostly privately owned, has a set of physical, tangible infrastructures that are rarely seen. See, for example, Andrew Blum, *Tubes: A Journey to the Center of the Internet* (New York: Ecco, 2013); Nicole Starosielski, *The Undersea Network* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2015).

4. I’m referring to #Gamergate (see chapter 2).

5. For more on how political messaging became embedded in play and memes, see chapter 4.

6. I discuss the intellectual dark web in chapter 3.

7. Here I’m referring to the US Electoral College system, established in the US Constitution, which often results in a presidential election where the winner of the popular vote loses the election. The practice effectively protected chattel slavery to ensure the votes of Southern delegates to the constitutional convention. For a more thorough critique of how the Electoral College works to disenfranchise much of the population, see George C. Edwards III, *Why the Electoral College Is Bad for America*, 3rd ed. (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2019). And for why we’ve yet to eliminate the practice despite knowing its racist origins, see Alexander Keyssar, *Why Do We Still Have the Electoral College?* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2020).

8. I’m referring to Black Lives Matter here.

9. See the docudrama *The Social Dilemma*, dir. Jeff Orlowski (Netflix, 2020). For a critique of the tendency for the tech industry to look to its own people (rather than to researchers) for solutions to the problems it causes, see Lilly Irani and Rumman Chowdhury, “To Really ‘Disrupt,’ Tech Needs to Listen to Actual Researchers,” *Wired*, June 26, 2019, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.wired.com/story/tech-needs-to-listen-to-actual-researchers>.

10. In video and role-playing games, nonplayer characters (NPCs) are controlled by the game’s artificial intelligence (AI) or by the person running the game (called the dungeon master in *Dungeons & Dragons*). They are distinguished from players or player characters, who are controlled by whoever is playing the game.

TVTropes, "Non-Player Character," TVTropes, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://tvtropes.org/pmwiki/pmwiki.php/Main/NonPlayerCharacter>.

11. "This game of Civ" refers to the turn-based strategy game *Civilization* created by designer Sid Meier in 1991. In *Civilization*, you can play any number of former or current civilizations. Players attempt to gain wins either through a technological victory (by completing science projects that lead to the colonizing space by the civilization), cultural imperialism (by building the most wonders), or military might (by conquering other civilizations on the map). Later games allow you to win via diplomacy. The game is steeped in problematic colonialist narratives. See Souvik Mukherjee, *Videogames and Postcolonialism: Empire Plays Back* (Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan, 2017).

12. Chansley was later sentenced to forty-one months for his role in the riot. Hannah Rabinowitz and Katelyn Polantz, "'QAnon Shaman' Jacob Chansley Sentenced to 41 Months in Prison for Role in US Capitol Riot," CNN, updated November 17, 2021, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.cnn.com/2021/11/17/politics/jacob-chansley-qanon-shaman-january-6-sentencing/index.html>.

13. For an excellent description of the memetic roots of the Stop the Steal insurrection, see chapter 10 of Joan Donovan, Emily Dreyfuss, and Brian Friedberg, *Meme Wars: The Untold Story of the Online Battles Upending Democracy in America* (New York: Bloomsbury, 2022).

14. "Honkey Kong" is also the title of an album (and song) by rapper Apathy that was released in 2011 and possibly served as the inspiration for the meme. My thanks to JA for informing me of this bit of trivia.

15. Nancy MacLean, *Democracy in Chains: The Deep History of the Radical Right's Stealth Plan for America* (New York: Penguin, 2017).

16. Stephanie L. Hartzell, "Alt-White: Conceptualizing the 'Alt-Right' as a Rhetorical Bridge between White Nationalism and Mainstream Public Discourse," *Journal of Contemporary Rhetoric* 8, no. 1/2 (2018): 6–25, http://contemporaryrhetoric.com/wp-content/uploads/2018/02/Hartzell8_1_2_2.pdf.

17. Burton Speakman, "A Knight in Sheep's Clothing: Media Framing of the Alt-Right Can Alter the Image of Racist Groups," *Journal of Creative Communications* 16, no. 1 (2021): 81–96, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0973258620977983>.

18. Benjamin Moffitt, "What Was the 'Alt' in Alt-Right, Alt-Lite, and Alt-Left? On 'Alt' as a Political Modifier," *Political Studies* (February 2, 2023), <https://doi.org/10.1177/00323217221150871>.

19. Paleoconservatives (as opposed to neoconservatives) champion American nationalism and isolationist foreign policies. See Jean-François Drolet and Michael C. Williams, "America First: Paleoconservatism and the Ideological Struggle for the

American Right," *Journal of Political Ideologies* 25, no. 1 (2020): 28–50, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13569317.2020.1699717>.

20. Identitarians stand against multiculturalism, instead are intent on preserving the supposed ethnic "purity" of the White European (or in this case, American) identity. George Hawley, *Making Sense of the Alt-Right* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2017).

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22. Southern Poverty Law Center, "Alt-Right," accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.splcenter.org/fighting-hate/extremist-files/ideology/alt-right>.

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24. Mike Wendling, *Alt-Right: From 4chan to the White House* (London: Pluto Press, 2018).

25. Few public demographic studies of Reddit exist, but a Pew Research Center study suggests it is visited mostly by college-aged white men. Michael Barthel et al., "Nearly Eight-in-Ten Reddit Users Get News on the Site," Pew Research Center, February 25, 2016, https://www.pewresearch.org/wp-content/uploads/sites/8/2016/02/PJ_2016.02.25_Reddit_FINAL.pdf. According to 4chan's own advertising metrics, 70 percent of its visitors are male, and a vast majority are more likely to be from the US than other places. "Advertise," 4chan, <https://www.4chan.org/advertise>. A complete discussion of the roots and ideological underpinnings of the alt-right (and far-right populism more broadly) is beyond the scope of this book. For more, see Kathleen Belew, *Bring the War Home: The White Power Movement and Paramilitary America* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2018); MacLean, *Democracy in Chains*; Elizabeth Sandifer, *Neoreaction a Basilisk: Essays on and around the Alt Right* (Ithaca, NY: Eruditorum Press, 2017); Wendling, *Alt-Right*.

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- [32.](#) Sara Ahmed, *The Promise of Happiness* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2010).
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FROM #GAMERGATE TO THE ALT-RIGHT

In April 2019, Carl Benjamin announced he was running for a European Parliament seat as a member of the UK Independence Party (UKIP). Benjamin, a British gamer and YouTube personality known by his pseudonym Sargon of Akkad, gained notoriety in 2014 during #Gamergate. #Gamergate, a hashtag activism campaign ostensibly created to raise awareness about ethical issues in game journalism, served as a convenient banner for the large-scale harassment of prominent women journalists, game developers, and media critics. Sargon of Akkad's audience grew between 2014 and 2019 (as of July 2023, his YouTube channel had about 881,000 followers), and his videos quickly moved away from discussions of the video game industry to lengthy screeds against social justice warriors (SJWs), political correctness, and feminism. Perhaps it is not surprising that Benjamin found UKIP, the anti-immigrant party of Brexit, to be a welcoming place for his right-wing beliefs and misogynistic vitriol. But how did Benjamin, a relatively unknown British gamer, rise to prominence so quickly and move beyond discussing video games to become a political candidate?

For those paying attention to #Gamergate (and especially those who were harassed and attacked by the leaderless mob), the suggestion that a ragtag group of gamers eventually might have political ambitions was not surprising. The campaign became both a rallying cry for the alt-right and a larger cultural flashpoint.

Harassment campaigns and far-right organizing in online spaces are nothing new, but #Gamergate was different in both its ferocity and breadth.¹ Additionally, #Gamergate was amplified and made possible by the rise of what I'm calling the *alternative web*—a collection of imageboards, social media platforms, and streaming services (such as Twitch and YouTube) that afforded proponents the ability to recruit new members to their cause and engage in the targeted harassment of those they deemed enemies. In fact, #Gamergate offered a kind of social media playbook for the burgeoning alt-right. It involved both anonymous gaming fans and conservative upstarts like Milo Yiannopoulos, a British editor at Breitbart News from 2014 to 2017, and the odd B-list Hollywood actor who fueled the fire.² While proponents of the #Gamergate campaign framed the issue apolitically, it was clear from the beginning that they were tapping into much deeper fears about the perceived decreasing status of young White men globally. Steve Bannon, a White House strategist in the early days of the Trump administration and later an architect of the January 6, 2021, insurrection at the US Capitol, was particularly important, as he understood both video game culture and the disaffected nature of many of the young men considered “core gamers.”³ This was at least in part because of his own interest in video games. Bannon had encountered gaming when he was a principal at Internet Gaming Entertainment, a gold-farming company he led from 2007 to 2011, and was also rumored to be a big fan of *World of Warcraft*, the popular massively multiplayer online (MMO) game.⁴

Fully understanding how disaffected gamers were mobilized into becoming Trump supporters is complicated, especially for those not steeped the corner of the internet where memes are born, remixed, and reposted. These platforms, message boards, and communities represent a variety of subcultures but were mobilized into a unitary body during #Gamergate. While far-right political groups with populist agendas have long held power in global politics, in this chapter I suggest the activist movement was a clarion call for a new group of technically savvy, young, cisgender and heterosexual (cishet), and mostly White men⁵ to become politically active. Their

focus moved quickly from the domain of video games to the domain of culture, in part because of websites like Breitbart News and various figures—like Steve Bannon, Milo Yiannapolous, and assorted YouTubers (like the aforementioned Carl Benjamin, the Internet Aristocrat, TotalBiscuit, and other pseudonymous individuals), 4channers, meninists, and Redditors—who worked to radicalize the loose coalition. At the same time, less savory aspects of the movement were simultaneously disavowed by its members, attributed to trolls, and derided as false-flag operations intended to gain sympathy from the general public. I argue that #Gamergate demonstrated that the same platforms celebrated for their democratizing effect could be easily manipulated by the alt-right. This is partially because of Silicon Valley's free-speech absolutist ethos and technologists' refusal to consider how their platforms might be used for harassment purposes and antidemocratic ends. It also reflects a larger shift post-Trump on the right, in which political discourse is increasingly less about policy and more about personality. In this chapter, I focus on the ways that #Gamergate demonstrated that the alt-right was interested in *gaming* the affordances of social media.

First, I discuss the alternative web—an alternative set of communities, platforms, and technologies that have served as the primary driver of contemporary digital popular culture—or the “vernacular web.”⁶ These networks and platforms are unique in online spaces as they rely on technological features (affordances) such as (pseudo)anonymity and community-based moderation, and they resist the overt hypercommercialization that is integral to social media sites like Facebook. While a subset of these spaces called *alt-tech* is designed to support far-right political ideologies,⁷ much of the alternative web is seemingly apolitical—or in the case of Tumblr and the fediverse (platforms joined in a federated universe, described briefly below), even oriented toward social justice. And yet, I argue that the design and politics of two of the most prominent members of the alternative web—4chan and Reddit—have become fertile grounds for extremist content and misogynistic organizing. Second, I offer a brief review of the hashtag activist movement #Gamergate

and detail the ways that an anonymous mob manipulated platform affordances. I then argue that as the movement grew, far-right political operatives helped shift its narrative—away from a mere consumer revolt and toward a populist movement driven by nostalgia for a particular raced and gendered gamer identity. Finally, I discuss how #Gamergate set the stage for larger conspiracy theories such as #Pizzagate and QAnon, both of which had elements of alternate-reality games (ARGs), further cementing a connection between gaming and far-right activism.

DEFINING THE ALTERNATIVE WEB

Numerous journalistic histories of the web often fawn over the founders of companies like Amazon, Facebook, and Twitter as visionaries who are “disrupting” every other industry. However, these stories neglect the reality that individuals like Jeff Bezos, Mark Zuckerberg, and Jack Dorsey are not really genius entrepreneurs so much as modern-day carpetbaggers, and they ignore other social media spaces like Discord, 4chan, Reddit, and Tumblr, despite the important role they have played in shaping digital culture. These Silicon Valley cheerleaders often suggest that technology is somehow distinct from rather than embedded in culture.⁸ However, scholars like Anne Balsamo and Sasha Constanza-Chock articulate the critical importance of understanding the cultural values underlying technological design, which often reflect the limited perspectives of their creators.⁹ Their work connects to larger discussions happening within the fields of science and technology studies (STS) and human-computer interaction (HCI) that engage with the concept of the affordances of technology.

Affordances are the ways technologies enable and constrain behavior. As Jenny L. Davis notes, “affordances mediate between a technology’s features and its outcomes. Technologies don’t *make* people do things but instead, push, pull, enable, and constrain. Affordances are *how* objects shape action for socially situated subjects.”¹⁰ The mainstream web prizes a particular set of affordances that includes visibility (we are findable) and publicness

(our contributions are shared with everyone by default). Social media platforms often assume our identities are unitary and static—a kind of unified self. However, this assumption contrasts with postmodernist understandings of the self as an overlapping, sometimes contradictory set of performances that is both mutable and contextually dependent.¹¹ But a mutable, fluid self is not easily datafied, monetized, or surveilled. And so social media platforms instead embrace a unified-self model through affordances—such as public profiles, liking, sharing, upvoting, and constant connectivity—that ultimately benefit their own advertising models rather than mirror the ways many of us move through the world. Algorithms further structure our experiences in these spaces, offering only a limited set of acceptable social practices if we are to remain visible.¹²

There exists another vision of the web, however, with a different set of assumptions underlying its design, one that I am terming the *alternative web*.¹³ This encompasses both platforms like Craigslist and Tumblr but also spaces like 4chan and (the now-shuttered) Parler. While not entirely immune to the political and economic realities of the mainstream web, the alternative web feels different. It is decidedly subcultural, existing beside, between, and sometimes in direct opposition to the mainstream web. It is less overtly ad-driven, typically embracing an “internet ugly” aesthetic that is both visually stripped down and at moments functionally inscrutable.¹⁴ These platforms often prioritize ephemerality and celebrate their niche status, creating communities that are connected around shared interests rather than social networks, personalities, or influencers. A primary hallmark of the alternative web is that these spaces often afford partial or full anonymity, in striking contrast to the real-name and verified-checkmark policies that platforms like Facebook and Twitter/X require or encourage. As Jessa Lingel astutely notes, communities like Craigslist, which embrace the “messy serendipity” that characterized the early web, push back against the gentrification and “slick commercialism” of today’s corporate internet.¹⁵ At moments, the alternative web embraces the utopian (if sometimes problematic) vision of the early web that message boards like the WELL and Usenet represented.¹⁶

The alternative web is not merely a set of websites but also an assemblage of platforms (like 4chan and Reddit) and infrastructures (like hosting providers Cloudflare and Epik) that exist in tandem with the mainstream web. And while the alternative web traditionally does not represent any particular brand of political ideology, one of its subsets (alt-tech) has courted far-right activists.¹⁷ Alt-tech platform owners often embrace a more extreme version of cyber- or technolibertarianism (discussed in chapter 3) than the mainstream web does, especially as it relates to offensive content. Many of these spaces practice a kind of free-speech absolutism, tolerating words that are both offensive and violent. In particular, parts of the alternative web, like the mainstream web, suggest that the words (and deeds) of their users do not represent the views of the platform owners, but they often go further in platforming toxic and sometimes violent speech.

The alternative web is related to but ultimately different from the *dark web*. Some have suggested that the dark web is a subset of the *deep web*—the materials that search engines like Google do not index.¹⁸ Robert W. Gehl argues that the dark web is best understood as primarily technological in nature, as it requires browsers to use special routing tools—like Freenet, the Invisible Internet Project (I2P), and the Onion Router (Tor)—to access these spaces anonymously.¹⁹ Similarly, commerce on the dark web relies almost exclusively on untraceable cryptocurrencies such as Bitcoin.²⁰ This focus on anonymity (which is fundamentally at odds with spaces like Facebook) and its technical hurdles has inspired media coverage to focus largely on its criminal aspects. Journalists regularly portray the dark web as a shadowy underworld where individuals can buy drugs, weapons, and other illicit material normally forbidden on the rest of the internet. However, the dark web doesn't enable only criminal enterprises. As privacy advocates note, Tor can also provide safety for political activists who organize in repressive, authoritarian regimes.²¹ Still, the dark web remains unique in its almost singular focus on protecting user privacy over law enforcement and national security efforts.

Privacy is also a key element of the alternative web. In this way, many of these spaces (such as 4chan and Reddit) retain the early web's emphasis on identity play and (pseudo)anonymity. This contrasts with the mainstream web's reliance on commodifying user data and reselling it to advertisers.²² But outsiders to these spaces (however they are defined) are rarely afforded such protections. For example, when members of the imageboard 4chan were in the throes of their #Gamergate campaign against Zoë Quinn (discussed in more detail below), no attempts to stop the harassment were taken until after Quinn had been doxed multiple times. It's hard to imagine that harassment like this would be tolerated if someone posted Elon Musk's home address.²³ Platforms like Reddit that straddle the line between the alt-web and mainstream web have strict policies about sharing private information, even though enforcement depends on a given subreddit's moderators, but in other parts of the alternative web, harassment is not only tolerated but encouraged under the guise of trolling. For example, users at Kiwi Farms, a website dedicated to targeting internet personalities it terms "LOLCows" (those who can be "milked for laughs"), have focused their rage at mostly low-level internet celebrities and streamers because they are trans, queer, BIPOC, feminist, or fat. Doxing, insults, and death threats are common in the space.²⁴ Likewise, users at the now-shuttered Encyclopedia Dramatica—which originally was developed to chronicle LiveJournal drama and eventually morphed into an even more mean-spirited version of 4chan's /b/ (random) board—eviscerated whatever internet target they deemed worthy of their rage.²⁵ So privacy on the alternative web is fluid depending on who is speaking. This might be called a kind of "privacy for me but not for thee" policy.

PEDOBEAR TO PEPE THE FROG: 4CHAN AND BEYOND

Perhaps no corner of the alternative web is better known than the imageboard website 4chan. While internet culture has always been playful and transgressive (see, for example, Nancy K. Baym's early work on humor in a Usenet group),²⁶ a particular brand of internet

humor developed on 4chan in the early 2000s that was absurd, chaotic, geeky, and often mean-spirited. A successor to the Japanese imageboard website 2chan (two channel), 4chan was started by fifteen-year-old wunderkind Christopher “moot” Poole. Long known as a cesspool of the internet, 4chan is both bewildering and disturbing. It is relatively unique among contemporary web spaces in that it is anonymous and ephemeral (content is quickly replaced and not archived). It is also not a unitary body, despite media coverage that tends to suggest that /b/ (random) and /pol/ (politically incorrect) are 4chan’s only imageboards. Its boards represent a large set of interests, from anime to sports, with a subset devoted to NSFW (not suitable for work) content (mostly, but not exclusively, porn). At the same time, 4chan (like much of the alternative web) has a shared culture that exists beyond a single individual or board. But /b/ is especially productive, and its role in spawning new memes has led it to be dubbed the “internet’s meme factory.”²⁷ As some have noted, 4chan’s anonymity, ephemerality, lax moderation policies, and rapid pace of interactions on its various boards have cultivated a culture where the lulz (the laughs, especially unsympathetic laughter) are king.²⁸

4chan has been particularly good at combining a *kawaii* (cute) sensibility with a provocative sense of humor that can be summed up by the cartoon image of Pedobear, a brown teddy bear with sparkly eyes and an excited facial expression. The image was derived from an earlier text-based ASCII version of a bear that appeared on 2chan (the earlier Japanese text- and imageboard that inspired 4chan’s creation).²⁹ In the mid-2000s, the cartoon form of the character became associated with child pornography and often was posted next to or photoshopped onto photos of minors. Over time, Pedobear came to represent 4chan’s trolling, edgy ethos, and individuals dressed up as the bear during the trial of former Pennsylvania State University football coach Jerry Sandusky for child molestation.³⁰ As Pedobear became a polysemic object, it was able to take on several meanings depending on use. It also is an example of what Whitney Phillips and Ryan M. Milner have described as “fetishized sight,” which encourages the viewer to fixate on the

memetic content without considering the larger context.³¹ This narrow focus coupled with what the authors term a “white racial frame” created fertile ground for racist, xenophobic, transphobic, and misogynistic discourse to flourish on the platform.³² And given 4chan’s role as an outsized purveyor of popular memes, these problematic frames have come to dominate both the alternative web and the mainstream web.

While 4chan’s politics could be described as nihilistic and anarchic, when its anonymous hordes are aggrieved, they have been shockingly effective at directing their energy toward people and groups that they perceive as being their enemies (particularly those who represent religious and governmental institutions). In 2003, 4chan denizens came together under the banner of Anonymous, an informal hacktivist collective that has targeted groups such as the Church of Scientology and the Westboro Baptist Church, government agencies in the US and globally, and corporations such as Visa and PayPal.³³ Anonymous has also lent support to global protest movements such as the Arab Spring and Occupy Wall Street and have provided intel to surveillance watchdogs such as WikiLeaks.³⁴ While the targets might be varied, Anonymous seems to be most interested in unmaking institutions (corporate, religious, and governmental), aligning it at times with cyberlibertarianism (which is discussed at length in chapter 3). At the same time, Anonymous casts itself as an apolitical force—an absurd claim that mirrors the kind of geek masculinity (see chapter 3 for more on geek masculinity) that permeates much of the culture on 4chan, Reddit, and other platforms of the alternative web. And while Anonymous may not be explicitly partisan, after the 2016 US presidential election the collective struggled with the possibility of waging an “Operation Trump” against the newly elected president. At odds were parties advocating that Donald Trump’s actions were antidemocratic (and thus worthy of attention) and others who argued that targeting Trump or the Republican National Committee would violate the group’s “neutrality.”³⁵ Later, Anonymous engaged in cyberattacks against Russia to protest of its invasion of Ukraine.³⁶ Still, the group’s influence has arguably waned in the last few years.

Many of the alternative web's prominent platforms embrace free-speech absolutism and implicitly encourage extremist political ideologies. For example, when discussions of #Gamergate were banned from 4chan, 8chan's founder Fredrick Brennan welcomed them. After its founding in 2013, 8chan (an imageboard with a structure similar to 4chan's) quickly became a welcoming home for communities trading in racism, anti-Semitism, Islamophobia, misogyny, child pornography, and QAnon conspiracies.³⁷ Several mass shooters posted their "manifestos" on 8chan, eventually leading Brennan to call for the site's closure after he left its helm in 2015.³⁸ Likewise, the alt-tech sites Gab and Parler were both critical platforms for organizing the January 6 insurrection.³⁹ At the same time, critics of these spaces often suggest that it is simply their anonymity that encourages bad actors. The reality is much more complex, and focusing only on the role that anonymity plays in enabling individuals to coordinate harassment and undertake violent acts ignores the reality that most of the mainstream web is also a dumpster fire (even when people use their real names). As is clear in the cases I examine in this book, a complex combination of platform policies and algorithmic logics emphasizing visibility and virality are as much (or more) to blame. So from Pedobear, arises Pepe the Frog, a character from an underground comic who became synonymous with the alt-right and Trump supporters during his campaign.⁴⁰

However, important and relatively unique elements of certain platforms within the alternative web ecosystem have made those spaces not only meme machines but welcoming to conspiracy theories like #Gamergate. Unlike their mainstream web cousins, platforms such as Gab (2016), Parler (2018), Trump's Truth Social (2022), and Voat (2014–2020) have actively courted far-right supporters.⁴¹ They reject the veneer of neutrality that more mainstream platforms use as a shield for criticism (despite the reality that remaining "neutral" is itself a political stance)—hence the use of the *alt* part of *alt-tech*.⁴² Viewing these platforms in a siloed kind of way (which I'm doing now) suggests that their audiences do not float between and among them, but the denizens of Gab or Parler

don't just stick to their playgrounds, spewing their right-wing conspiracies in a kind of perverse, pedophilia-obsessed echo chamber.⁴³ Members of r/The_Donald (the toxic, now-banned subreddit for Donald Trump supporters discussed at length in chapter 4) might also have posted in Reddit's r/Aww (a subreddit dedicated to cute animal pictures). Many of these people also are happily ensconced on Facebook, Twitter, and your neighborhood Nextdoor group. They are us, and we are them. The platform algorithms and advertising models that structure our experiences inevitably expose us to their toxicity—which is a serious bummer if you're a privileged middle-class cis het White woman but can be literally life-threatening if you're a poor Black trans woman (for example). And yet mainstream web platforms continue to operate as if they are not a part of a much larger media ecosystem on which we are all (for good or for ill) dependent.

Suggesting that the alternative web embodies only platforms like the chaotic and nihilistic 4chan and the far-right wonderland Parler is not accurate, however. The alt-web also embraces spaces like LiveJournal and Tumblr (havens for mostly a young, progressive, queer BIPOC population) and Craigslist (whose stripped-down marketplace and discussion boards represent a different vision of the mainstream internet).⁴⁴ Still other platforms live in a murky space between the mainstream web and the alternative web—especially considering their politics. For example, Substack, a platform that allows writers to monetize their newsletters, has become a haven for both the intellectual dark web (discussed in chapter 3) and progressive journalists.⁴⁵ And platforms like Reddit, which hosts subreddits (communities) often hostile to marginalized identities, still have those that are decidedly feminist, queer, and BIPOC-centered.⁴⁶

It might be easy to dismiss the alternative web as it has been positioned as fringe in the era of Facebook and Twitter/X dominance.⁴⁷ But increasingly, there's renewed interest in some of the more liberatory spheres of the alternative web. For example, the fediverse (a series of open-source, decentralized platforms) experienced rapid growth after Elon Musk's acquisition of Twitter in 2022. The fediverse offers open-source versions of many

mainstream platforms. For example, Mastodon is a Twitter-like microblogging service, and PeerTube is the fediverse's answer to YouTube. Unlike the mainstream web, the fediverse allows anyone to host a server and create different rules about what material is allowed, and content can also flow freely between its platforms. The decentralized nature and (thus far) anticapitalist ethos of fediverse technologies offer a stark contrast to the ad-laden, tracker-heavy, privacy nightmare of the mainstream web. Meta's new Threads platform (which was launched in July 2023 as a competitor to Twitter) is also to be a part of the fediverse.⁴⁸ So it's unclear if these alternative spaces will actually remain alternatives for long.

REDDIT AS PLATFORMED CHAOS

Reddit is uniquely situated between the alternative web and the mainstream web. While the alternative web has never been particularly welcoming to outsiders or corporate interests in the traditional sense, Reddit represents a reskinning of the alternative web's geek credibility with a corporate veneer that increasingly mirrors the ethos of larger platforms such as Facebook and Twitter.⁴⁹ The site's mechanics and culture are unique, and the platform serves as a kind of bridge between fringe spaces (like 4chan) and conventional spaces (like Instagram and YouTube). It also played an outsized role in #Gamergate (discussed below), is wildly popular (fourteenth most visited site in the US and nineteenth globally as of this writing), and yet is still marginal within the larger media ecosystem.⁵⁰

Created by two college students, Steve Huffman and Alexis Ohanian, Reddit launched in 2005. The original platform was a minimalist link aggregator that allowed users to submit and vote on links but not discuss them (comments were enabled later in that year).⁵¹ In 2008, interest-based communities (subreddits) were added.⁵² In keeping with Reddit's democratic ideals and hope that the site would remain active if the company ever disintegrated, the platform's code was made open-source in 2008.⁵³ This meant that anyone could use the code to create their own Reddit-like

environment. The platform remained relatively niche until August 2012, when then-US President Barack Obama held a one-hour Ask Me Anything session, at which point it exploded in popularity. In 2017, the company announced the platform would no longer be open source, noting that because Reddit was no longer run by a small team but was a larger player in the social media ecosystem, it was moving toward a proprietary code base. Responses to the announcement were generally negative.⁵⁴ Reddit created its own video platform the same year—a nod, perhaps, to the popularity of posts that include video and of video-sharing apps like TikTok. The move also signaled an increasing interest on Reddit's part to keep people on the platform (rather than linking them elsewhere) and indicated an intensified interest in monetization and advertising revenue.⁵⁵

While Reddit has elements of imageboards like 4chan and social networking spaces like Facebook, it is more akin to the discussion boards that populated the early web. Long-form comments and discussions are common. Members (called Redditors) can subscribe to communities (subreddits) of interest and vote on content and comments that appear. As anyone can create a subreddit of interest, the communities represented on Reddit are broad in their scope and include discussing US politics (r/Politics), sharing pictures of terrible-looking meals (r/ShittyFoodPorn), and celebrating hip-hop (r/HipHopHeads). Subreddits are moderated by volunteers who have extensive leeway in creating and enforcing rules, even though the platform itself has relatively few rules about prohibited content. Moderators can also change the design and, to a lesser degree, the functionality of their subreddits by altering their Cascading Style Sheets (CSS). This is often done to reflect the individual identity of a given community. For example, r/Chicago has a header image featuring the iconic Chicago Theater and a logo with one of the stars from the Chicago flag. r/SubredditDrama features a background image of containers filled with popcorn (in keeping with the idea that watching Reddit's drama unfold is like watching a movie and thus requires sustenance). Other subreddits have altered the look of the upvote and downvote arrows. The subreddit dedicated to *Married at*

First Sight (a reality television show begun in 2014 in which people marry strangers), r/MAFS_TV, modded the site's default upvote and downvote buttons using black heart emojis (with the downvote button being a broken heart). Prior to Reddit's sitewide redesign in 2018, moderators also had some control over aspects of their community's functionality.⁵⁶ For example, they could remove nonsubscribers' ability to vote on content or remove the downvote and upvote buttons entirely.

Reddit's algorithm shows the most recent and most upvoted content higher on any given page. Redditors can also change the default sorting mechanism so that the newest comments or postings appear at the top of the page or so that the most "controversial" ones (those that received about the same number of upvotes and downvotes) appear first. At first glance, this creates the appearance that the voting system is democratic, but it is also easily manipulated (which I discuss briefly in chapter 4 in the context of the r/The_Donald subreddit). Since popularity (in terms of the number of upvotes something receives) impacts a posting's relative visibility, it is possible that Reddit works to reinforce what is already popular, subtly incentivizing visitors to upvote content that has already been upvoted. Reddit's algorithm also used to rank the earliest votes more heavily, implicitly incentivizing the weight of subreddit moderators and other power users who spent more time on the site than casual Redditors.⁵⁷

I've written before how Reddit embodies a carnivalesque spirit, often reflecting a kind of geek masculinity that champions both niche technical prowess and clever humor.⁵⁸ At the same time, the platform's policies, governance, and culture have provided a safe place for communities that engage in far-right rhetoric or represent harassment campaigns. Since its inception, Reddit has championed a hands-off approach to moderating content shared on the platform, pushing responsibility for complying with its few rules onto volunteer moderators. Most of the rules Reddit enforces concern doxing (posting private information about a person) and interfering with the platform's voting system. It's generally understood that Reddit's other rules have been implemented only after extensive negative

press coverage. For example, Reddit implemented rules banning sexually suggestive content of minors only after journalist Anderson Cooper did an exposé on users who shared child pornography.⁵⁹ Other rules were also the likely result of negative press coverage—rules against nonconsensual pornography (revenge porn), creepshots, and content that threatens or harasses.⁶⁰

Moderation for Reddit and other platforms is punishing work that often exposes individuals to the worst of humanity, including animal cruelty, violence, explicit sexual content, child abuse, racism, homophobia, transphobia, Islamophobia, anti-Semitism, anti-immigrant bias, and misogyny.⁶¹ Content moderation involves what Arlie Russell Hochschild terms “emotional labor,” which “requires one to induce or suppress feeling in order to sustain the outward countenance that produces the proper state of mind in others ... [and] calls for a coordination of mind and feeling.”⁶² It’s also a form of affective labor that, according to Michael Hardt, “produce[s] social networks, forms of community, [and] biopower.”⁶³ Both Hochschild and Hardt are discussing paid labor that results in a wage and has some sort of exchange value. Reddit moderators’ status as unpaid workers complicates this formulation. This reality mirrors larger shifts in labor in tech companies (and beyond) that increasingly rely on low-paid independent contractors (gig workers) for the most difficult and inarguably critical aspects of their mission.⁶⁴

Shifting the responsibility and risk of moderating onto unpaid volunteers allows Reddit to remain a lean organization with few employees but also creates a kind of plausible deniability when it comes to infractions of its rules. At the same time, the overreliance on volunteer moderators can create problems for Reddit, as was the case with the infamous Violentacrez—a moderator of numerous, now-deleted problematic subreddits (r/Jailbait and r/Creepshots among them) who had a cozy relationship with Reddit admins because he also reported instances of child pornography found on the site.⁶⁵ Moderation on the platform is generally opaque, with moderators responsible for enforcing both their own subreddit’s rules and norms (which can vary widely) and also the platform’s rules and norms, despite having few tools (automated or otherwise) at their

disposal.⁶⁶ Researchers have noted that moderators themselves are often unable to be transparent about why a given piece of content is removed.⁶⁷ Sentiment across the platform likewise suggests that the platform's higher-level administrators are capricious in applying the sitewide rules, especially when it comes to the most problematic subreddits (such as r/The_Donald, discussed in chapter 4).

#GAMERGATE: FROM THE ABYSS TO THE MAINSTREAM

The marginalized spaces of the alternative web, like Reddit and 4chan, produced a critical flashpoint that highlighted the broken nature of most discourse on the internet and set the stage for the alt-right's eventual emergence. This episode involved a group of video game fans, far-right political operatives, and trolls and had an overarching narrative (ethics in video games journalism) that both obscured and radicalized a group of disaffected mostly young White men.⁶⁸ For some, it was a logical extension of the refusal by technology companies, the media, policymakers, and the public to fully acknowledge two important issues—the ease with which multiple platforms could be “gamed” and the power of technologically savvy, mostly anonymous groups to rewire the affordances of social media for antisocial and antidemocratic purposes.

I'm speaking, of course, about #Gamergate. Numerous excellent analyses of the #Gamergate harassment campaign detail the events that took place in 2014 and 2015 and the ways it reverberated beyond the gaming industry and fan communities, so this is a brief outline what happened.⁶⁹ In August 2014, a former romantic partner of independent game developer Zoë Quinn (Quinn uses they/them pronouns) wrote a screed about their relationship under a thread about “cringeworthy breakups” on Something Awful, a set of message boards dedicated to edgy web humor that birthed numerous memes (such as “All Your Base”) and is part of the alternative web (described above). His account also suggested that Quinn received a favorable review for their game *Depression Quest* from a reporter in exchange for sexual favors (an allegation later

debunked). Moderators quickly removed the posting, but the screed was expanded and reposted to the former romantic partner's *The Zoe Post* blog and shared on 4chan, where it became wildly popular. It fit 4chan perfectly: it was misogynistic, geeky, salacious, and memeable. And it was relatable. Many of the denizens of 4chan imagine themselves as noble heroes in a world that is unfair to their kind (nerds), and they see women (at the time, Quinn was using she/her pronouns) and social justice warriors as being feminist spoilsports who ruin their favorite things (including games, comics, and movies).⁷⁰

At this point, I must highlight a critical reality: harassment within gaming communities is not new. Despite numerous journalistic pieces about this particular instance of sexist terribleness, the gaming industry has always been awash in similarly vile moments like this. One of the more famous examples involved game developer Kathy Sierra, who was terrorized by a neo-Nazi White supremacist, self-described internet troll, Andrew Auernheimer, who went by the pseudonym "weev." Weev harassed and threatened Sierra through numerous online channels and eventually doxed her years before #Gamergate.⁷¹ What was new about #Gamergate was both its scale and its weaponization of social media visibility. This meant that the bulk of #Gamergate harassment happened in the open, which served two purposes: it encouraged others to join in the attacks and warned others that they might find themselves in the crosshairs of the #Gamergate mob. I discuss the specific tactics used during #Gamergate later in this chapter.

Within a week of the posting by Quinn's former partner, #Gamergate conversations spiraled viciously on 4chan's /b/ (random) and other boards, with numerous individuals making threats against Quinn. After Quinn was doxed several times, the site's founder, Christopher "moot" Poole, banned discussions about the topic from the platform. Although such harassment activities were technically against the rules of the platform, banning was an unprecedented move given the board's anything-goes reputation and eventually led Poole to leave the company he'd founded. It also raised the ire of 4chan denizens, who quickly established Reddit's

r/KotakuInAction as their primary public platform (along with Twitter) as a space to promote their agenda. In addition, the anonymous mob was welcomed on 8chan, another imageboard best known for its connection to numerous incel- and White supremacist-motivated mass shootings and the January 6 insurrection.^{[72](#)}

In moving from 4chan to Reddit, #Gamergate could obtain a veneer of legitimacy, even as the press and public were starting to notice how toxic it was. As mentioned earlier, Reddit sits somewhere between the alternative web and the mainstream web, in many ways embracing the ethos of the alternative web while being more accessible to a larger audience. Given this reality, supporters were able to mobilize using Reddit while suggesting their actions didn't constitute harassment, as the platform has strict rules banning the release of personal information.^{[73](#)} On Reddit, #Gamergate looked less chaotic than it had on 4chan, and it became increasingly focused on larger public-awareness campaigns that might draw attention to the cause rather than simply harass Quinn and others. For example, in late August 2014, #Gamergate supporters started Operation Disrespectful Nod, which involved emailing advertisers whose ads appeared on journalistic outlets that supporters determined were hostile to their perspective (among them Gawker Media, Gawker's gaming blog *Kotaku*, and the gaming development blog *Gamasutra*).^{[74](#)} Chip manufacturer Intel briefly pulled ads from *Gamasutra* because of #Gamergate's complaints.^{[75](#)}

The primary targets of the #Gamergate harassment campaign—among them Quinn, Anita Sarkeesian, Brianna Wu, and others—were featured in news segments in print and on network and cable TV shows. Sarkeesian also appeared on Stephen Colbert's parody news show *The Colbert Report* in late October 2014 to discuss the harassment campaign with the comedian.^{[76](#)} By the middle of 2015, #Gamergate had mostly fizzled out, but its impact was still reverberating.^{[77](#)} In the aftermath of #Gamergate, Quinn founded the Crash Override network as an advocacy group to provide support for victims of online harassment, doxing, and revenge porn. Several of the most prominent individuals targeted by the mob (among them

Quinn and Sarkeesian) later testified before Congress and the United Nations about gender-based harassment and online violence.⁷⁸

HOW #GAMERGATE ACTIVISTS GAMED SOCIAL MEDIA

The specific tactics used by #Gamergate supporters were enabled by social media and have become increasingly familiar in the years since. In 2015, I wrote an article about the role Reddit played in perpetuating and introducing #Gamergate to a broader audience.⁷⁹ I combined my analysis of #Gamergate with another event that occurred during August 2014—the large-scale hack of celebrity photos referred to as Celebgate or, more disgustingly by Redditors, as the Fappening.⁸⁰ In that article, I argue that both were the result of a potent combination of the platform's technical affordances and the community it attracted. While #Gamergate was not limited to Reddit, the site continues to remain a key platform for activists and has become welcoming to other misogynistic and racist conspiracies. But Reddit's role in the harassment and exploitation of women (and minors) was an issue long before #Gamergate (and the Fappening). One of the more notorious subreddits on the platform, r/Jailbait, featured nonconsensual images of underaged women (girls) and was banned only after significant negative media coverage. Likewise, a number of racist subreddits have found a home on Reddit, in part because of the reluctance of administrators to ban them in the misguided hope that their subscribers stayed in their own toxic areas of the platform. But Reddit's structure means that the toxicity that characterized a subreddit like r/The_Donald, for example, did not stay contained. In the article, I discuss the ways that Reddit's algorithm, few content rules, reliance on unpaid moderators, and general culture contributed to the rise of both r/KotakuInAction (the #Gamergate subreddit) and r/TheFappening. While Reddit's dominant culture has changed somewhat in the wake of the Donald Trump presidency (becoming, I would argue, less willing to tolerate far-right speech), plenty of sympathetic subreddits and users remain.

#Gamergate is an example of what I call *toxic technocultures* in the article. The term “describe[s] the toxic cultures that are enabled

by and propagated through sociotechnical networks such as Reddit, 4chan, Twitter, and online gaming. Toxic technocultures are related to, but distinct from other issue-based, networked [boyd 2011] and affective publics [Papacharissi 2015], as they may coalesce around a particular issue or event, but tactics used within these cultures often rely heavily on implicit or explicit harassment of others.”⁸¹ I further argue that toxic technocultures are embedded in and dependent on the underlying culture of the internet, which prizes visibility (on the one hand) and anonymity (on the other):

Toxic technocultures are unique in their leveraging of sociotechnical platforms as both a channel of coordination and harassment and their seemingly leaderless, amorphous quality. Members of these communities often demonstrate technological prowess in engaging in ethically dubious actions such as aggregating public and private content about the targets of their actions (for potential doxxing purposes or simply their own enjoyment) and exploiting platform policies that often value aggregating large audiences while offering little protection for potential harassment victims. At the same time, individuals affiliated with toxic technocultures both champion the power of the community as a way to effect change or voice displeasure with others they view as being adversaries, while still distancing themselves from what they perceive as the more ethically dubious (and illegal) actions of others, suggesting they are “not really part” of whatever toxic technoculture under which they are acting.⁸²

In the article, I argue that it’s not surprising that Reddit became a hub for #Gamergate and other examples of toxic technocultures. The confluence of geek masculinity and the underlying politics of Reddit generally provided fertile soil for the toxicity of the alt-right to take hold in the wake of #Gamergate.

Ultimately, #Gamergate demonstrated that coordinated groups could easily game social media platforms. Through a canny manipulation of affordances of the social media ecosystem (among them visibility, publicness, networked information gathering, coordinated action, advertising-based revenue models, and automated moderation tools), #Gamergate supporters promoted their cause and attacked others. In other words, they gamed social media. They were able to do this, in part, because the denizens who supported #Gamergate were geeks who, as Christopher Kelty

argues, “use technology as a kind of argument.”⁸³ While Kelty’s observation is directed toward technologists working within the free or open-source software movement, #Gamergate supporters also broadly used the technology of games and gaming as a way of making an argument. They used their experiences as game players to exploit and refract affordances of platforms for their own ends.

But the reality is also more complex. While #Gamergate activists exploited aspects of social media platforms for their own ends, they also could do so only because these affordances *were designed into* the platforms to begin with. In some ways, #Gamergate used social media exactly as it was intended. Its supporters created a multiheaded hydra of harassment that bridged the immaterial world of the internet with the material day-to-day lives of their targets. As a part of their strategy to draw attention to their cause, as well as harass and silence their critics, #Gamergate supporters employed a set of effective tactics harnessing social media’s design and politics. These tactics were often inspired by a twisted version of the ethos of the alternative web (especially its more unsavory platforms, like 8chan) and the ultimately weaponized aspects of mainstream social media.

In the same way that the alt-right has shifted the nature of political discourse within the Republican Party (and beyond), our collective experiences online have been indelibly shaped by #Gamergate and its toxic tactics. The #Gamergate participants intuitively understood what Sarah Banet-Weiser refers to as the “economy of visibility” of social media and the ways that simply becoming visible can be a precursor to political advocacy.⁸⁴ Unlike the often vaunted social movements that have been enabled through social media (such as the Arab Spring and Occupy Wall Street), however, #Gamergate activists weaponized visibility for their own ends. This connection was loosely acknowledged in alt-right activist Vox Day’s book *SJWs Always Lie: Taking Down the Thought Police*. One of the book’s illustrations suggests that some of the main figures associated with #Gamergate (including Mike Cernovich, Sargon of Akkad, Milo Yiannopoulos, and others) would later be remembered as having staved off the decline of Western civilization.

The cartoon envisions them as being memorialized in a new Mount Rushmore that replaces former presidents with the #Gamergate activists.⁸⁵ The success of #Gamergate set the stage for political operatives to create an overarching strategy (both on- and offline) that has worked to undermine our collective faith in democratic institutions and inspire violent action among those on the right.

The first toxic tactic developed during #Gamergate was brigading (launching a coordinated attack on) communities or accounts perceived as disagreeing with #Gamergate activists (and later, Trump supporters). This approach takes many forms depending on the platform. On Reddit, brigading can involve direct messaging pornography, violent content, and hate speech to moderators (thus making the moderation queue untenable); mass downvoting any material that appears on the subreddit (using bots or human accounts); posting spam or hate speech in threads (or derailing threads); “reporting” content that the interlopers disagreed with (again, to clog up the moderation queue); and repeatedly posting material that goes against the subreddit rules to make the subreddit unusable. As a result, subreddits might be locked to allow only subscribers to be able to post and comment. During the height of #Gamergate on Twitter, activists used a variation of this tactic to bait opponents. This approach became known as “sealioning,” named for a David Malki 2014 comic strip that envisioned #Gamergate activists as sea lions who show up uninvited, disingenuously and repeatedly “ask questions,” which basically amount to offering a series of pro-#Gamergate talking points.⁸⁶ This type of online trolling often worked to derail and make the platform useless for any real conversation. Other examples of brigading included publicly drawing attention to particular users for further harassment by flooding their mentions (basically, weaponizing the @ feature of the platform) and spamming a particular hashtag with material to make it unusable. Often #Gamergate activists brigaded targets and the hashtag using so-called new egg accounts created for this purpose. At the time, new Twitter accounts featured a profile image of a cartoon egg. These accounts were easily noted because they also had no or very few followers and almost no public posting history but followed a

number of pro-#Gamergate conservative pundits. #Gamergate activists also launched a competing hashtag (#NotYourShield) with the intent of making it trend on Twitter and other platforms. The hashtag was filled with messages of support from BIPOC and queer individuals, who routinely mentioned that they were tired of feminist activists using them for their social justice purposes. However, many of these accounts were later linked to 4chan-created sockpuppet accounts created for an earlier operation trying to discredit feminist activists, making any claims to the identity of these individuals questionable.^{[87](#)}

The second toxic #Gamergate tactic involved doxing, or the release of private information into the public sphere, and swatting (making false reports to local law enforcement). While not unique to #Gamergate, doxing was used by supporters with impunity, suggesting that the possibility of doxing was simply the cost of being visible online. While platforms like Reddit ostensibly ban the sharing of private information, activists were able to mobilize and strategize on anonymous, more ephemeral parts of the alternative web like 8chan and Discord to share material with ease. These plans were then discussed by the harassers themselves on spaces like Twitter. Making doxing efforts public served two purposes: it was effective harassment of existing targets, and it was an intimidation tactic toward potential targets—a promise that “you could be next.”^{[88](#)} #Gamergate activists disavowed these actions, either denying that the target had been doxed or suggesting that any doxing was done by trolls who intended to sow chaos and were unaffiliated with the movement. Regardless, doxing became an effective way to silence dissent. And #Gamergate supporters used this information in various ways that ranged from relatively benign (delivering unordered and unpaid-for pizzas to a target’s house) to life-threatening (telling law enforcement that targets were holding hostages in the hopes that armed police officers would be mobilized).^{[89](#)}

A third critical toxic tactic of #Gamergate took the form of memetic warfare. #Gamergate supporters created memes to denigrate targets and draw attention to the movement. One set of memes was directed toward harassing individuals, mostly feminist

games critics like Feminist Frequency's Anita Sarkeesian. This included sharing a "game" where you could punch Sarkeesian and see her face become bloodied as a result (the game was actually released after the first episode of her *Tropes vs. Women in Video Games* video series two years prior to #Gamergate but was recirculated) and images featuring Sarkeesian's face Photoshopped onto pornographic stills.⁹⁰ Another set of memes worked to pollute the information environment, creating material that seemed superficially benign but was meant to antagonize targets and publicize the #Gamergate cause. Like the alt-right's cooption of the "okay" hand gesture, many of the memes were effective because they signaled to insiders while still being able to be dismissed as a form of play by outsiders (a point discussed further in chapter 4).⁹¹ This included the cartoon figure of Vivian James—the "average female gamer" who made a frequent appearance on 4chan and Reddit.⁹² The colors that James wears (green and purple) refer to a long-standing 4chan joke about rape.⁹³

Other toxic #Gamergate tactics were less visible. They involved spaces outside public social media but were no less destructive. As Shira Chess and Adrienne Shaw argue, activists were keen to disrupt, derail, and deface anything they saw as supporting their narrative that gaming was overrun with social justice warriors (SJWs).⁹⁴ A public Google document created to preserve the discussions on feminist game scholarship at the Digital Games Research Association (DiGRA) conference in 2014 was defaced repeatedly. These actions highlighted the networked nature of platforms. Later, #Gamergate supporters took to DiGRA's GamesNetwork mailing list, suggesting that since DiGRA and game researchers generally seemed invested in promoting what activists viewed as SJW research, they would conduct a peer review of all papers available on DiGRA's website and report their findings to the list. While somewhat amusing, as it was clear that the activists were not as qualified as the scholars who worked in game studies to undertake such an assessment, the threatened assault was also terrifying. This effort quickly fizzled out, perhaps when the activists realized how much work was required to read academic papers and

write lengthy reviews. However, it highlighted a grave reality that documents could be decontextualized and lifted to suit whatever larger point #Gamergate supporters were making about DiGRA, game criticism, and feminist scholarship generally. This approach might be called *archival warfare*, as it both highlights the archive's status as a boundary object but also signals that even the most seemingly mundane object can be recontextualized in ways that suit a particular narrative.⁹⁵ Perhaps unsurprisingly, this tactic is still used by #Gamergate supporters. Rule 2 on the list of rules that appeared in the sidebar of r/KotakuInAction as of October 2022 states "Archive what you can" ([figure 2.1](#)). The rationale offered by #Gamergate activists is that archiving simply protects articles from being edited after the fact and ensures that comment brigading doesn't occur on articles posted outside of r/KotakuInAction, but the implication is clear: #Gamergate is watching you and is taking notes.⁹⁶

r/KotakuInAction Rules

1. Don't Be a Dickwolf 
2. No Crusading / Trolling 
3. No Brigading 
4. No Personal Information 
5. Posting Guidelines 
6. No Personal Army Requests 
7. Archive What You Can 

This is to preserve articles in their original format in case they are edited in the future, as well as to ensure that the articles comments sections are not brigaded. Record-keeping is important, and archiving pages are our way to preserve those records. Additionally there is an active blacklist of sites that will automatically be pulled by the automod if not archived.
8. Don't Post Misleading Content 
9. No Reposts
10. No Metareddit posts 

2.1 List of rules in the sidebar at the r/KotakuInAction subreddit (captured October 28, 2022 from <http://www.reddit.com/r/KotakuInAction>).

The #Gamergate activists also demonstrated a savvy understanding of the sociotechnical affordances of various online media and the ways that legal remedies might be twisted to meet their own goals. On YouTube, they repeatedly flagged videos for copyright violations, which required a lengthy review process before the videos could be reinstated.⁹⁷ Some prominent supporters of #Gamergate also doctored Digital Millennium Copyright Act (DMCA) takedown notices to suggest that Zoë Quinn (or other targets) had filed them to have pro-#Gamergate videos removed from YouTube.⁹⁸ Since most platforms remove content while reviewing it for potential violations of content policies or service terms, this toxic tactic effectively silenced those who relied on these outlets for their livelihood or activism. It also worked to reinforce #Gamergate's assertion that humorless SJWs were censoring them for their views.

As mentioned earlier, many of our experiences on social media require particular forms of visibility. The line between cultivating (and maintaining) our reputation and manipulating the algorithm to ensure (or dissuade) our visibility remains razor thin. However, platform administrators suggest a clear binary between tweaking an online presence and cheating the platform's algorithms, despite the often murky distinction between these two realities. This creates an asymmetrical power relationship whereby platforms both depend the labor of their users and also entirely control their relative visibility. Hacking and resisting these regimes of visibility in the way that many #Gamergate targets did are often framed by the platforms (in what's been called *platform paternalism*) as deviant or a kind of cheating.⁹⁹ Part of what was so frustrating about #Gamergate was that those within the mob were able to play superficially by the rules that the platforms outlined and thus received little punishment. And yet tools created by those targeted to minimize the harassment (such as Randi Harper's Good Game Auto Blocker, which automatically blocked Twitter accounts that were presumed supporters of #Gamergate based on the accounts they followed) were often reported as running afoul of a given platform's terms of service (TOS).¹⁰⁰ This asymmetry left many who were targeted by

#Gamergate feeling as though platforms were more interested in enforcing visibility at the expense of their own safety.

GAMERS ARE DEAD. LONG LIVE GAMERS.

While the events and tactics of #Gamergate are relatively straightforward, the underlying causes of the harassment campaign are far more complex. These involved a set of unspoken expectations about what games are, who plays them, and for whom they should be made. These are rooted in a particular fantasy about the centrality of the White cis het male identity as a core audience for games and other pop culture texts. According to Lauren Berlant, “fantasy is the means by which people hoard idealizing theories and tableaux about how they and the world ‘add up to something.’”¹⁰¹ For #Gamergate activists, game narratives and mechanics should always be apolitical, meaning that they should not challenge the player’s worldview in any substantive way. Games should embody a simplistic version of Joseph Campbell’s monomyth (the hero’s journey), with the character moving from a position of relative weakness to strength. This perspective echoes the meritocratic discourse embraced by technologists and American culture at-large (a point to which I return in chapter 3).

Many of the most popular games franchises (which are referred to as AAA or triple-A titles) have clear rules and narratives that often employ simple good versus evil structures. As players navigate the game’s mechanics over time, becoming more successful and adept, their character also becomes more powerful. This suggests a linear path of growth and mastery open to all regardless of social location. Life is not like this, but these kinds of narratives seduce us with their simplicity, suggesting that individuals are entirely in control of their own destinies. These narratives also create a series of norms around what constitutes a game, deriding those that don’t fit this ideal as merely “walking simulators.”¹⁰² One of the common refrains #Gamergate supporters repeated about Quinn’s *Depression Quest* was that it wasn’t just a bad game but that *it wasn’t a game at all*. The fact that Quinn was subverting certain game mechanics by

removing choices for the player (thus simulating the experience of depression) was either conveniently ignored or so out of line with what #Gamergate activists thought a game *should* be given their diet of triple-A games that prize virtuosity and mastery as a rule and rarely simulate mental illness realistically.¹⁰³ There is no actual win condition in the game. As with actual depression, *Depression Quest* suggests we learn ways to manage around and work with chronic illnesses and disabilities. They become a part of who we are and are not necessarily something to overcome.

For #Gamergate activists who saw themselves as the ultimate arbiters of what was and was not a game, *Depression Quest* was anathema not just because Quinn created it but also because it challenged their belief that games were fun. Fun might mean that a game could be challenging in terms of its difficulty, offering more difficult levels and enemies as one played. But fun for #Gamergate activists was decidedly not about challenging one's perspective regarding mental illness or looking through a window into one person's experience. Games were meant to be epic adventures, not mundane simulations of everyday life, even though parts of gaming can be mundane—hence the term *grinding*, which describes how routine and boring certain activities are in games like *World of Warcraft* if you want to level up your character. In fairness to #Gamergaters,¹⁰⁴ this epic perspective has been shaped by the obsession of the mainstream, triple-A video game industry with particular genres of games and the limited agency they offer players. The mechanics of first-person shooter (FPS) video games, for example, offer few options for interacting with other humans. They aren't well suited for thinking about racism or capitalism (for example) as their combat-driven mechanics offer limited options for dealing with other humans, and those options involve shooting them. Even if a game were to feature an engrossing story in which an anarchist is bent on destroying the foundations of capitalism as a way to create a more just and egalitarian world, the narrative is subsumed by FPS game mechanics that provide guns (and not much else) to solve our problems. As game scholar Noah Wardrip-Fruin argues, while we can make games about ideas, "the ideas must be

consonant with the playable models that enable the core gameplay. And the fact is that the combat model that dominates FPS gameplay is not compatible with a story about interacting with anything human, unless our role is to play a soldier, assassin, or psychopath.”¹⁰⁵

If games themselves were a contested category for #Gamergate activists, who constituted a gamer was even more so. One of the key texts that sent the #Gamergate community into a frenzy during those early days in August 2014 was an article by a Black woman critic, Leigh Alexander. In an opinion piece titled “‘Gamers’ Don’t Have to Be Your Audience. ‘Gamers’ Are Over” written for the game development blog *Gamasutra*, Alexander argues that most triple-A companies create a narrow definition of their core gamer audience and that tightly defining the audience in this way both constrains the kinds of games that are made as well implicitly encourages gamers to feel like anyone else who plays games are interlopers.¹⁰⁶ As scholars like Adrienne Shaw have noted, representation of marginalized communities as players and in games matters, as it “provides evidence for what forms of existence are possible.”¹⁰⁷ But as Kishonna L. Gray’s work on Black Twitch streamers suggests, those who aren’t cis het White men are often marked as “deviant” in gaming spaces.¹⁰⁸ Their presence reminds us that BIPOC folks and women have always played video games, even if they are rarely represented within the games themselves or in the industry at-large.

Both ideas—a unitary gamer identity and a belief that only certain games should really be considered games—imply a kind of nostalgia. According to Svetlana Boym, nostalgia is a longing for an imagined past—one that no longer exists or never existed to begin with. It is “a romance with one’s own fantasy” that causes people to ignore the realities of the past for a more appealing imaginary version.¹⁰⁹ As Edoardo Campanella and Marta Dassù argue, nostalgia also arises in response to uncertainty, as “it removes its victims from an unpleasant present and throws them into a familiar past, reinforcing their self-esteem and the self-confidence needed to navigate periods of sustained stress.”¹¹⁰ But #Gamergate’s identity nostalgia goes even further by embracing a kind of nihilistic world view that reduces

the act of playing video games to pure consumption without, as critic Elizabeth Sandifer argues, any desire. As she writes, "it is a vision of video gaming reduced to passively accepting the products of big-name developers on the terms that are offered, without any sort of opinion or personal identity involved."¹¹¹ Thus, the figure of Vivian James, the mascot of #Gamergate, becomes a literal "fake geek girl" who "loves video games without desiring anything of them, which is to say utterly unlike the way in which any piece of art has ever been loved by anyone."¹¹²

Beyond who could be marked a gamer and what was appropriately called a game, #Gamergate supporters were united in their belief that the movement was concerned (at least publicly) with "ethics in games journalism." To outsiders, this was a rather odd way of characterizing what was, at its core, a harassment campaign. The "ethics in journalism" refrain suggested that these activists were most concerned with the supposed lapse on the part of the journalist discussed in "The Zoe Post" written by Quinn's former romantic partner and their perception of a too-cozy relationship between journalists covering the industry and the industry itself. At the same time, this formulation suggested that Quinn was yet another example of a video game developer who received an unfair advantage in terms of press coverage and that this was the natural outgrowth of an industry that pandered to pressure from the media and public to diversify gaming.

But if the goal was to draw people to the cause, tweeting about the supposed ethical problems with video games journalism was a confusing tactic. Most of the public has little understanding of or interest in journalism ethics generally (let alone within games journalism).¹¹³ However, focusing on this issue allowed #Gamergate activists to retain a sense of moral superiority while deflecting from what was plainly apparent: they were engaging in a harassment campaign. The issue was also nebulous enough to invite response because, frankly, no one knew what it meant. And even asking what #Gamergate meant benefited the movement as a whole, creating new recruits (those who agreed with the way #Gamergate supporters framed the issue) and new targets for harassment (those

who didn't). By rhetorically distracting from the real targets of abuse—including women game developers, feminist game critics, and BIPOC journalists, especially Zoë Quinn, Anita Sarkeesian, Brianna Wu, and others—it perpetuated the narrative that any harassment was the result of anonymous bad actors or trolls who used the cover of #Gamergate for their own ends or that these bad actors were secret social justice warriors intent on discrediting the movement. This wasn't actually the case, and numerous Discord logs and chats and Reddit conversations demonstrate that the activists were aware of the targets of their ire, a fact that was irrelevant to them.¹¹⁴ #Gamergate lived in a land of fantasy where repetitions of the lie "It's about ethics in games journalism" and convoluted conspiracies involving academia, the media, and indie game developers were normalized despite their absurdity.

#Gamergate has not been the only fan-based harassment campaign targeting women and minorities. Others followed in its wake. In 2016, #Ghostbustersgate was a response to an all-woman reboot of the *Ghostbusters* franchise from the 1980s in which Milo Yiannopoulos incited his Twitter followers to harass costar Leslie Jones. Fans sent Jones (a Black woman) racist and misogynistic tweets and violent pornographic images. When director Paul Feig (a White man) came to Jones's defense, he was also harassed.¹¹⁵ And later, in 2017, #Comicsgate activists attacked women artists working for Marvel Comics after the women posted a selfie celebrating Flo Steinberg, a recently deceased longtime Marvel employee, an action that seemed to trigger the rage of fanboys.¹¹⁶

It's hard to believe the justifications that supporters have offered about any of these "fan revolts." Just as #Gamergate was never really about "ethics and games journalism," #Ghostbustersgate was never really about fans' unhappiness with the quality of the *Ghostbusters* reboot. So what were all these hashtag harassment campaigns *really* about, and how did they get repurposed for political ends? I contend that these campaigns were less concerned with the changing nature of diversity in geek culture per se and more concerned with the mostly cishet White men who supported these movements and their *relationship* to those changes. What

drew together the anonymous #Gamergate mob was a paranoid concern that games and gaming culture were becoming too preoccupied with “political correctness,” and it’s true that games are becoming increasingly diverse, both in mechanics and narrative.¹¹⁷ However, #Gamergate activists often framed the movement as a normal response to an authoritarian overreach by the progressive left as represented by the social justice warriors they believed had infiltrated the gaming industry. If we dig a bit deeper, that justification crumbles. #Gamergate was ultimately a reaction to a larger sense of loss and nostalgia for a time when cishet White men were the dominant, presumed audience of gaming (and other geeky pursuits like science fiction movies and comics). Its proponents were nostalgic for the gamer identity discussed above. As Suzanne Scott argues, there is an inherent tension here: those who “police ‘authentic’ fan identity along gender lines are typically those who have gained the most power and privilege from geek culture’s movement from the margins to the mainstream. It is thus, paradoxically and overwhelmingly, White, cishet men who tend to decry the loss of fandom’s subcultural authenticity, even as they reap the demographic, industrial, authorial, and representational benefits of this loss.”¹¹⁸ The loss of marginality is therefore both embraced by a subset of the community (as it means more cultural products are made that cater to their tastes) and, at the same time, mourned (as it also means welcoming more diverse fans into the fold).

In this way, #Gamergate is an example of what Arlie Russell Hochschild terms a “deep story.” As she argues, “a deep story is a *feels-as-if* story—it’s the story feelings tell in the language of symbols. It removes judgment. It removes fact. It tells us how things feel.”¹¹⁹ Our deep stories project outward and tell us something about the “other side,” creating what she terms a “subjective prism” through which we view their actions.¹²⁰ For #Gamergate activists, their deep story revolved around being the target audience for triple-A games (and other cultural products). Sure, other people could play games, but the presumption of #Gamergate was that cishet White men were the true fans—the ones for whom games would offer a meritocratic fantasy world in

which they were the perennial heroes *and* antiheroes. Even if games have always been played by a diverse audience, the construction of the gamer identity that was shaped by large game companies and reinforced by media discourse suggested otherwise.¹²¹ And while it might be said that our identities are increasingly defined by the pop cultural products we consume, #Gamergate ushered in a new era of toxic fandom and created a deep story that later (in the guise of Donald Trump's campaign and presidency, discussed in chapter 4) became indistinguishable from alt-right politics. #Gamergate provided an effective way to see a media object as being critical to who these fans were—and to see their displacement as the object's primary audience as a deeply personal affront that mirrored a larger sense that social justice warriors were unfairly undoing meritocracy as an organizing principle in gaming and in society. (For more on meritocracy and its connection to Silicon Valley, see chapter 3.)

So the deep story that #Gamergate supporters told themselves was that the movement was concerned with "ethics in games journalism," but it was actually a proxy war being fought between those who viewed their own centrality—within the world of games and pop culture and in their private lives—as being diminished and replaced. This move also mirrors Corey Robin's work on what drives the "reactionary mind" (as he calls it). In his formulation, there is a deep fear among conservatives that progressive causes will fundamentally shift how they organize their private lives.¹²² Despite conservatives' apparent focus on public issues like taxes, abortion, immigration, and gun rights, Robin argues that what actually drives conservative belief is the restructuring of power within the private domain. As he argues, "For the conservative, equality portends more than a distribution of resources, opportunities, and outcomes—though he certainly dislikes these, too. What equality ultimately means is a rotation in the seat of power."¹²³ Thus, #Gamergate's deep story (as retold by Steve Bannon and other alt-right operatives) was that not only were gamers being shut out of their favorite pastime by humorless feminists and an industry that no longer cared about them but they also were being shut out of American political

and social life. The only solution was to resist the normies and vote Trump.

For Bannon, a significant selling point was that those involved with #Gamergate were highly proficient technologically and steeped in digital and internet culture in ways that many conservatives were not. And Trump became a logical point of connection between the #Gamergate campaign and the intellectual conservatism championed by political operatives on the right. His media savviness and outsized presence on platforms like Twitter made him both accessible and larger than life. In other words, he was perfectly memeable (a point revisited in chapter 4). Because many of these gamers felt ostracized and left behind in a world that was quickly moving beyond gaming narratives that catered solely to the core gaming demographic (White, cis, straight, young, middle-class men) to narratives that increasingly reflected diverse gaming audiences and to changing production models that led to the rise of the indie game studios, recruiting and radicalizing this base of gamers became an effective strategy for mobilizing a new far-right movement in the US (and globally).^{[124](#)}

#GAMERGATE LAUNCHES QANON

While not the first “born digital” conspiracy,^{[125](#)} #Gamergate was arguably its most successful and widespread. And it came to represent a fundamental shift from conspiracy theory (which intends to explain a particular set of events) to conspiratorial thinking (which views the world and particularly institutions as inherently dangerous). One of the more remarkable aspects of #Gamergate is the ease with which it laid the foundation for more extremist and dangerous conspiracy theories, such as #Pizzagate and eventually QAnon. Proponents fully embraced the vernacular internet and leveraged the connected nature of online platforms as an effective messaging and recruiting tool.

#Gamergate gained traction among a subset of the gaming community because of the convincing narratives it wove. Tying together the seemingly disparate influences of game developers,

journalists, cultural critics, and academics required supporters to craft an elaborate set of conspiracy theories. These theories conveniently offered clear opponents (such as Leigh Alexander, DiGRA, the *Kotaku* blog, Zoë Quinn, Anita Sarkeesian, and Brianna Wu) that increasingly grew broader as time went on. As the narrative was promoted and coopted by conservative pundits like Milo Yiannopoulos, it conveniently aligned with popular alt-right targets (including social justice warriors, progressives and leftists, feminists, diversity advocates, journalists, and academics). As Jenny Rice aptly notes, conspiracy is an “affective process” rather than a “static artifact.”¹²⁶ #Gamergate embodied this move from conspiracy theory to conspiratorial thinking as supporters marshalled a sense of outrage (that they directed at video game journalists, indie game developers, and feminist game critics) and then mobilized it in both consumer actions (for example, boycotting advertisers who placed ads on journalism outlets like the *Kotaku* website) and larger cultural critiques (such as sharing the numerous ways they felt they were being victimized in the name of diversity). Conspiracy theories shared by the supporters remained emotionally resonant and appealed to populist sentiment.

Conspiracy theories provide a sense of control and order over something that is fundamentally disordered and chaotic. In his classic (but contested) political essay, Richard Hofstadter notes the prevalence of a particular “paranoid style” that characterizes much of American political life and that inspires a sense of broad cultural persecution.¹²⁷ This often finds purchase (on the right) in the form of conspiracy theories that target particular communities—such as Muslims, Jews, women, and BIPOC folks.¹²⁸ Extremist groups often argue that these kinds of out-groups control their fate—with help from a shadowy and powerful elite at the helm that must be stopped at any cost. Conspiracy theories, whether relatively benign (that Elvis faked his own death) or deeply troubling (that Trump won the 2020 presidential election), test the status quo. Therefore, as Jodi Dean succinctly notes, “conspiracy theory is everyday politics.”¹²⁹ But Dean also argues that Hofstadter misses the point because he starts from the assumption that the political and social sphere is normal,

rational, and inclusive. Instead, Dean suggests that conspiracy theory is often a reaction to our hypermediated daily life under late capitalism. So conspiracy theory plays on our feelings of alienation and abjection and “codes critical reflections on democratic society as a particularized set of threats.”¹³⁰ Mark Fenster concurs, arguing that it is the idea of a paranoid *style* that is the most useful aspect of Hofstadter’s formulation as it “productively opens analysis to the study of political culture, and popular discourse.”¹³¹ Fenster, like Dean, reminds us to not give in to narrow analyses that suggest any challenge to consensus within the public sphere is necessarily pathological.¹³²

In many cases, the internet plays a key role in spreading and reinforcing conspiracy theories. In her 1998 analysis of ufologists, Dean argues that the internet provides a sense of a “fundamental interconnectedness,” offering both narrative coherence and community for individuals who themselves feel alien in mainstream society.¹³³ But the rise of social media and platform capitalism have also enabled a new form of conspiracy theory—what Russell Muirhead and Nancy L. Rosenblum call “conspiracism,” or conspiracy theory without the actual theory.¹³⁴ Rather than reflecting an ideological political stance in the way traditional conspiracy theories might, conspiracism exists merely to undermine institutions and experts and confuse the public. So its targets include higher education, the media, government, scientific expertise, and democracy itself, and because there is no theory, it is “destabilizing, degrading deconstructing, and finally delegitimizing.”¹³⁵ Thus, institutions fundamental to a functioning democratic society are viewed by conspiracists with skepticism and increasingly inchoate rage, as they represent a public sphere that is hostile to their worldview. This moves beyond Dean’s ufologists, who do not see their views as tolerated by the mainstream, may see certain institutions as corrupt, but may not question their entire legitimacy.

While the ufologists Dean studied viewed the internet as a critical space for sharing evidence of abduction and receiving social support, Muirhead and Rosenblum suggest that for conspiracists, the internet is a sphere for repetitive assertion of “the truth.” As they note, “For

classic conspiracists, the internet is a source of dots and patterns—information that falls into the narrative and solidifies their explanation of events. For the new conspiracists all the energy is directed at repetition and affirmation.”¹³⁶ And this new conspiracism has increasingly become embedded in the language of the internet in memes. Memes are especially potent for conspiracism as they are infinitely transmittable and semiotically powerful. If old conspiracy theory is embodied in the character played by Charlie Day in the TV show *It’s Always Sunny in Philadelphia*, where Charlie connects the literal dots on a corkboard to determine who Pepe Silvia is ([figure 2.2](#)),¹³⁷ the new conspiracism is a gamer who repeatedly spams “Actually, it’s about ethics in games journalism” whenever someone uses the #Gamergate hashtag on Twitter. Repetition and remix become key ways of introducing and radicalizing individuals in these spaces, and the meme format may make it easier for outsiders to dismiss them as a form of trolling or play (see chapter 4 for more on this).



2.2 Charlie Day connecting the dots as he tries to unravel the mystery of Pepe Silvia. From *It's Always Sunny in Philadelphia*, season 4, episode 10, "Sweet Dee Has a Heart Attack," directed by Matt Shakman, aired October 30, 2008, 20th Century Fox Television.

The events of #Gamergate represented this transition—from conspiracy theory to conspiracism—and modeled what became an effective way of organizing and arguing online. While earlier social movements (most notably the Tea Party movement) flirted with conspiracism in online settings, #Gamergate by and large represented a "born digital" conspiracism.¹³⁸ It represented a shift toward a conspiracism populated by much younger, more technically savvy individuals who were mobilized by cunning political operatives like Steve Bannon. By embracing the underlying logic of spaces like Reddit, Twitter, and YouTube, #Gamergate demonstrated an effective playbook for far-right activism that innately understands the underlying logics of social media: platforms are connected, and the

visibility core to their functioning is easily weaponized.¹³⁹ Much of the anger underlying #Gamergate was later mobilized in support of the #Pizzagate conspiracy (a convoluted theory that claimed Democratic politicians were abusing children in a Washington, DC pizzeria) and, more recently, the QAnon political conspiracy.¹⁴⁰ Through QAnon, the roots of #Gamergate proponents' deep story (about their replacement as primary protagonists in the world) grew and solidified conspiracism's move from the peripheries of the far right to mainstream conservatism via the alternative web.

As some have noted, QAnon is notable not just because of the vastness of its conspiracy theory but also because of its similarity to alternate reality games (ARGs).¹⁴¹ ARGs are large-scale games where the play uses the backdrop of everyday life. Play starts when one player finds a "rabbit hole" (a clue embedded in an innocuous website about beekeeping, a poster plastered on a light pole, or some other entry point in the game).¹⁴² Following this clue whisks away players into an alternate reality in which the game story exists. Like the conspiracism of QAnon, ARGs rely on having players probe seemingly mundane objects and collectively solve puzzles to move closer to solving the mystery at the ARG's heart. In QAnon, however, the story is not created by game designers but is an expression of populist anger that is both inscrutable and, at moments, extremely violent. And any attempts to debunk the conspiracy theory are considered further "proof" by believers that the conspiracy is indeed true. In the world of QAnon, nothing exists outside of the game.

GAMING THE AFFORDANCES OF PLATFORMS

The technical acumen of #Gamergate supporters and their self-righteous rage were capitalized on by right-wing political operatives in the months after the harassment campaign ended. What began as a fan revolt became a referendum on the status of young, White cis het men in the face of the existential threat that feminists and the left supposedly posed to them. The overarching strategy of #Gamergate activists was predicated on valorizing a particular fandom identity (the gamer). Seeing their own status threatened by

increasing diversity within the gaming industry and fandom, #Gamergate supporters used the affordances of social media to direct their ire toward journalists, feminists, and indie game developers. While fan mobilization around fandom objects as an expression of the fans' personal politics is not a new phenomenon, #Gamergate was notable for its toxicity, scale, scope, and multiplatform nature.¹⁴³

As gamers, #Gamergate supporters understood what Aaron Trammell argues—that antisocial and violent actions (he uses torture as one example) can be a form of play.¹⁴⁴ The harassment that took place was seen as *fun* for those playing but not so much for those who were targeted. Through a large-scale, mostly anonymous, multiplatform coordination effort, #Gamergate activists were able to find the weak points in the design of platforms themselves, and, I would argue, this was because they approached these spaces *as gamers*. Open-world games, for example, encourage players to think of the game environment as one that is almost infinitely moldable to their desires. This means that some players might try to win a game like *Fallout* without killing a single enemy. It's not easy, but it's possible.¹⁴⁵ Such an approach is usually praised as it demonstrates a kind of virtuosity that pushes the boundaries of the game itself. Likewise, #Gamergate activists did not view harassing, doxing, brigading, and inappropriately flagging content as cheating but instead considered these actions to be creative ways to win the game.

Supporters also remained self-righteous in their outrage and anger even when confronted by the terrible consequences victims faced, partly because that's the moral territory in which most triple-A games inhabit. In games, the player is the hero, and everyone else is either an enemy or a nonplayer character (NPC). So what happens to NPCs is inconsequential. Coupling this narrative framework with the concept of the magic circle (mentioned in chapter 1) means that gaming culture often frames what happens in games as having no consequences in the real world. So #Gamergate activists could take pleasure in the very real harm they wreaked at the same time that they disavowed it as mere trolling or ultimately inconsequential.

Broadening out from this particular case, #Gamergate serves as a potent reminder of the ways that technological platforms have enabled misogynistic and racist activism to flourish. It also, as Joan Donovan and her coauthors astutely note, demonstrated that online media could radically reshape the discourse of the mainstream mediasphere.¹⁴⁶ I argue that something fundamentally shifted as a result of the events of 2014 and 2015, both in the kinds of attacks that have long become commonplace for marginalized communities and the ways that conspiracy theory and conspiracism have transformed the political landscape and our everyday lives. While alternative web platforms like 4chan and Reddit offer an alternative of pseudonymous communities organized around niche interests that stand in stark contrast to the slick commercialism of social media platforms like Facebook and Twitter/X, some of these platforms also have championed toxic cultures. #Gamergate reminds us that the design of platforms often unintentionally welcome harassment in the guise of preserving visibility and amplification as core values. In their attempt to claim a unitary gamer identity, #Gamergate activists tapped into larger cultural narratives about masculinity and nostalgia for an imagined past. They crafted a deep story that resonated and was eventually exploited by political operatives on the right. In addition, the tactics they employed provided a social media playbook for the then-burgeoning alt-right.

In a rare moment of self-reflection, the link between #Gamergate and support for Trump was directly acknowledged by the founder of the pro-#Gamergate subreddit r/KotakuInAction (KIA). In a posting made in July 2018 to r/Drama (another subreddit focused on Reddit-based drama), founder u/david-me described in detail his thoughts about his subreddit's trajectory, noting that it was "infested with racism and sexism ... [becoming] one of the many cancerous growths that have infiltrated reddit. The internet. The world."¹⁴⁷ He blamed Reddit's site administrators for letting the toxicity run rampant, suggested that it was in part due to the money that the subreddit made for the company, and finished by suggesting that r/The_Donald (a subreddit for Donald Trump supporters discussed in

detail in chapter 4) was born of the kind of toxicity that KIA fomented and the Reddit platform implicitly enabled:

Shout out to /r/The_Donald/. Compared to you, I'm a Mini-Me. I'm scratching an itch, yet you are a viral cancer that is destroying the minds of millions of Reddit users each day; And they allow it. They, in fact, have to. Conflict breeds users and drives viewer counts, driving advertisers and required profits.¹⁴⁸

After posting the missive, u/david-me closed r/KotakuInAction, but Reddit admins quickly reversed his actions, both reopening the subreddit and removing u/david-me's moderator access.¹⁴⁹ Reddit never publicly responded to u/david-me's critiques. And somewhat surprisingly, given the harassment, r/KotakuInAction remains on the platform as of this writing.

In the next chapter, I further explore Silicon Valley's embrace of cyber- and technolibertarianism and geek masculinity. Through an examination of two contrasting cases—a Black woman developer who was harassed after going public about sexually inappropriate jokes made at a tech conference and a White former Google engineer who wrote a memo about diversity at his company—I demonstrate that Silicon Valley rewards a particular kind of raced and gendered understanding of the geek figure. I also explore the emerging relationship between the intellectual dark web and the ways that an assortment of podcasters, journalists, and public intellectuals harnessed the sociotechnical realities of online platforms to radicalize individuals into the underlying logic of the alt-right. I argue that these moments demonstrate the far right's interest in *gaming* free speech.

NOTES

¹. For an excellent primer on the early days of online harassment, see chapter 1 of Julian Dibbell, *My Tiny Life: Crime and Passion in a Virtual World* (New York: Henry Holt, 1999).

². Actor Adam Baldwin (not a member of the well-known Baldwin family of actors but admired within the geek community as a costar of the short-lived but beloved television show *Firefly*) coined the term *#Gamergate* in a tweet. Caitlin Dewey, "The Only Guide to Gamergate You Will Ever Need to Read," *Washington Post*,

October 14, 2014, accessed July 29, 2023, <http://www.washingtonpost.com/news/the-intersect/wp/2014/10/14/the-only-guide-to-gamergate-you-will-ever-need-to-read>.

3. For a more thorough account of how Breitbart News and Bannon became ground zero for the alt-right's move into mainstream conservative circles, see Joseph Bernstein, "Here's How Breitbart and Milo Smuggled White Nationalism into the Mainstream," BuzzFeed, October 5, 2017, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.buzzfeednews.com/article/josephbernstein/heres-how-breitbart-and-milo-smuggled-white-nationalism>.

4. Gold farming involves playing large, massively-multiplayer online games to amass virtual currency and valuable in-game items, which can then be sold to other players for real currency. Joshua Green, *Devil's Bargain: Steve Bannon, Donald Trump, and the Storming of the Presidency* (New York: Penguin, 2017).

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6. Robert Glenn Howard, "The Vernacular Web of Participatory Media," *Critical Studies in Media Communication* 25, no. 5 (2008): 490–513, <https://doi.org/10.1080/15295030802468065>.

7. Joan Donovan, Becca Lewis, and Brian Friedberg, "Parallel Ports: Sociotechnical Change from the Alt-Right to Alt-Tech," in *Post-Digital Cultures of the Far Right*, ed. Maik Fielitz and Nick Thurston, 49–66 (Bielefeld, Germany: Transcript, 2018).

8. Leah A. Lievrouw and Sonia Livingstone, *Handbook of New Media* (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage, 2006).

9. Anne Balsamo, *Designing Culture: The Technological Imagination at Work* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2011); Sasha Costanza-Chock, *Design Justice: Community-Led Practices to Build the Worlds We Need* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2020).

10. Jenny L. Davis, *How Artifacts Afford: The Power and Politics of Everyday Things* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2020), 6 (emphasis in original).

11. Judith Butler, *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity*, 2nd ed. (New York: Routledge, 2007).

12. Taina Bucher, "Want to Be on the Top? Algorithmic Power and the Threat of Invisibility on Facebook," *New Media & Society* 14, no. 7 (November 1, 2012): 1169–1180, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444812440159>.

13. I struggled with the terminology of what to call the assemblage of these sites and platforms. Even though it would be easier for readability to call this space the alt-web, I want to distinguish it both from the alt-right and the alt-tech mediasphere (described in Donovan, Lewis, and Friedberg, "Parallel Ports"), which uniformly embraces far-right politics.

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15. Jessa Lingel, *An Internet for the People: The Politics and Promise of Craigslist* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2020), 2.
16. The WELL (Whole Earth 'Lectronic Link) was an early and influential message board started by Stewart Brand. Howard Rheingold, *The Virtual Community: Homesteading on the Electronic Frontier*, rev. ed. (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2000).
17. Donovan, Lewis, and Friedberg, "Parallel Ports."
18. Michael Chertoff, "A Public Policy Perspective of the Dark Web," *Journal of Cyber Policy* 2, no. 1 (2017): 26–38, <https://doi.org/10.1080/23738871.2017.1298643>.
19. Robert W. Gehl, *Weaving the Dark Web: Legitimacy on Freenet, Tor, and I2p* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2018).
20. Robert W. Gehl, "Power/Freedom on the Dark Web: A Digital Ethnography of the Dark Web Social Network," *New Media & Society* 18, no. 7 (2014), <https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444814554900>.
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22. John Cheney-Lippold, *We Are Data: Algorithms and the Making of Our Digital Selves* (New York: NYU Press, 2017); Shoshana Zuboff, *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for the Future at the New Frontier of Power* (New York: PublicAffairs, 2019).
23. A Twitter account dedicated to following Elon Musk's private jet (@ElonJet) regularly posted its flight plans, which is public information, but after Musk's purchase of Twitter in 2022, he banned the account. See Gustaf Kilander, "Teen Private Jet Tracker Who Irked Elon Musk Stops Reporting on Mark Cuban after 'Friend for Life' Offer," *Independent*, June 17, 2022, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.independent.co.uk/news/world/americas/jet-tracker-mark-cuban-elon-musk-b2103546.html>. In late 2022, Musk claimed that he was doxed by journalists, and he removed those journalists' accounts from Twitter. See Haleluya Hadero and Kelvin Chan, "Elon Musk Claims He Was Doxxed. But What Exactly Is That?," *AP News*, December 16, 2022, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://apnews.com/article/elon-musk-technology-business-5bf13ebcd0bfa4995099bb44c72da944>.
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Protecting Controversial Kiwi Farms Site,” Kotaku, August 24, 2022, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://kotaku.com/twitter-drop-kiwi-farms-hashtag-cloudflare-keffals-1849451829>.

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33. Gabriella Coleman, *Hacker, Hoaxer, Whistleblower, Spy: The Many Faces of Anonymous* (London: Verso Books, 2015).

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humor or shock value (as is the case with sociopathic Trevor in *Grand Theft Auto V*, for example).

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[107.](#) Adrienne Shaw, *Gaming at the Edge: Sexuality and Gender at the Margins of Gamer Culture* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2014), 4.

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[117.](#) See, for example, Consalvo and Paul, *Real Games*.

[118.](#) Suzanne Scott, *Fake Geek Girls: Fandom, Gender, and the Convergence Culture Industry* (New York: New York University Press, 2019), 4.

[119.](#) Arlie Russell Hochschild, *Strangers in Their Own Land: Anger and Mourning on the American Right* (New York: New Press, 2018), 135 (italics in original).

- [120.](#) Hochschild, *Strangers in Their Own Land*, 135.
- [121.](#) Kishonna L. Gray, *Intersectional Tech: Black Users in Digital Gaming* (Baton Rouge, LA: LSU Press, 2020); Gray, “They’re Just Too Urban”; Shaw, *Gaming at the Edge*.
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- [130.](#) Dean, *Aliens in America*, 143.
- [131.](#) Fenster, *Conspiracy Theories*, 42.
- [132.](#) Fenster, *Conspiracy Theories*.
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- [134.](#) Russell Muirhead and Nancy L. Rosenblum, *A Lot of People Are Saying: The New Conspiracism and the Assault on Democracy* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2020).
- [135.](#) Muirhead and Rosenblum, *A Lot of People Are Saying*, 8.
- [136.](#) Muirhead and Rosenblum, *A Lot of People Are Saying*, 32.
- [137.](#) In the episode called “Sweet Dee Has a Heart Attack,” one of the characters (Charlie) starts working in the mail room of a large company and becomes convinced that there’s a conspiracy involving someone named Pepe Silvia. The image of Charlie pointing at the corkboard later became a well-known reaction GIF shared on Reddit and elsewhere. Know Your Meme, “Pepe Silvia,” March 24, 2017, updated March 7, 2023, accessed February 15, 2024, <https://knowyourmeme.com/memes/pepe-silvia>.

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[141.](#) Adrian Hon, *You've Been Played: How Corporations, Governments, and Schools Use Games to Control Us All* (New York: Basic Books, 2022).

[142.](#) *I Love Bees*, an alternative reality game developed in 2004 to promote the game *Halo 2*, centered around a supposed beekeeping website titled "I Love Bees." The rabbit hole was introduced during a theatrical trailer for the game in which the website's URL was briefly shown. See more about the game in Jane McGonigal, "Why I Love Bees: A Case Study in Collective Intelligence Gaming," in *The Ecology of Games: Connecting Youth, Games, and Learning*, ed. Katie Salen, 199–227 (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2007).

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3

GEEK MASCULINITY AND THE CULT(URE) OF TECH

In May 2021, Tesla and SpaceX CEO (and later Twitter owner) Elon Musk hosted *Saturday Night Live*. While *SNL* has occasionally featured hosts who are nonactors, most who fill the role are, in some sense, entertainers—musicians, sports stars, or (in the case of Trump) reality stars-turned-politicians. Musk is none of these. He does have money, a lot of it, and a large Twitter/X following.¹ In many ways, his ascendance mirrors the internet's own—from a disparate, niche set of websites whose blingy GeoCities layout and perpetually under construction animated GIFs scream “nerd,” to sleek, uniform Instagram hot-girl-summer influencer profiles that manage to remain charmingly authentic while they shill for corporations. Musk's own image has mirrored these changes. Pictures of him from his early PayPal days show him with an awkward smile, an ill-fitting button-down shirt, and terrible posture, but photos of him in his current incarnation show him with a tailored suit, a full head of hair, and scruffy facial hair, while standing next to Canadian musician Grimes or a starlet he's currently dating. Musk's performance on *SNL* was lackluster, and a number of cast members expressed concern about his presence on the show, as he was known for his COVID-19 skepticism.² Despite the controversies surrounding the entrepreneur, in 2021, he was named Person of the Year by *Time* magazine, where a glowing review suggested a tech-

bro-as-savior narrative: “The man from the future where technology makes all things possible is a throwback to our glorious industrial past, before America stagnated and stopped producing anything but rules, restrictions, limits, obstacles and Facebook.”³ Anointing the wealthiest person on the planet (at the time of this writing) the honor reinforced a problematic account of technological progress that suggests that only entrepreneurs like Musk (whose companies have shirked labor laws and have faced repeated claims of racial discrimination and sexual harassment) can save us from ourselves.⁴

From Bill Gates to Steve Jobs to Jeff Bezos to Mark Zuckerberg, Silicon Valley histories are replete with stories about lone inventors who will revolutionize the world through technology. These innovators are often portrayed as singularly focused and obsessive, making them rather insufferable as bosses but adept at convincing others (primarily venture capitalists and the press) that their vision is desirable and achievable. Their vision—for the things that technology can and should do and for the kind of bloodless revolution they desire—almost always reflects a privileged perspective. Any ethical or moral problems with the technologies they create are reduced to bugs or, more often, portrayed as the simply the public’s inability or unwillingness to understand their vision of how society should work. While not always intentional, this kind of utopian and, frankly, naive approach to how technology will solve social ills and help us live longer, healthier, more connected lives is reflected in Silicon Valley’s culture. And our everyday experiences are indelibly touched by the culture these technology companies promote.

Opting out of Silicon Valley’s vision of the future is nearly impossible. Instead, we are awash in solutions offered by tech companies to solve the very problems they’ve created. To counteract the addictive nature of social media, for example, we are encouraged to download “digital wellbeing” apps. Are you unhappy with the amount of time you spend reading and typing on a computer? Here’s a fitness tracking device that gamifies your exercise routines to encourage you to move your body more (but that also harvests that data and shares it with advertisers). Technological solutions beget more technological solutions, but the

underlying logic of platforms, algorithms, design, and data-sharing practices remains static.

In this chapter, I outline some of the key assumptions of cyberlibertarianism, which shapes much of Silicon Valley's culture, the ways social media platforms are governed, and the digital culture(s) they foster. I then turn my attention to geek/nerd masculinity (briefly mentioned in chapter 2 in the context of #Gamergate) and explore how a particularly toxic strand of it has come to dominate online discourse in the form of what has been termed the *intellectual dark web*. Finally, I turn my attention to this chapter's two case studies. In the first, I discuss James Damore, a White software engineer, and the antidiversity memo he wrote while working for Google. I suggest that many of the arguments he makes in his manifesto are echoed by the podcasters and pundits active in the intellectual dark web. In the second, I compare Damore's case to that of Adria Richards, a Black software engineer whose attempts to point out the sexist language of peers at a tech conference led her company to fire her. I conclude by arguing that the nerd or geek stereotype connotes a particular set of assumptions about race and gender and that our digital platforms often reflect these same assumptions.

CYBER- AND TECHNOLIBERTARIANISM AND ITS ENDURING IMPACT ON TECH

Underlying the histories we tell about Silicon Valley is a set of very American values that shape the way that tech companies are structured and platforms are regulated, and the corporate and social culture of the Bay Area (and attendant spaces in Seattle, Austin, New York, London, Tel Aviv, Shenzhen, and Bengaluru). Typically referred to as techno- or cyberlibertarianism, it has also been called the Californian ideology after its geographical origins (with *Wired* magazine serving as the paradigmatic example of this ideology in practice).⁵ Like other ideologies, cyberlibertarianism is fluid and relatively unstated, but its interlocking principles guide the industry and influence how the public thinks about technology. This

worldview has been discussed by numerous authors, most notably Paulina Borsook, J. A. English-Lueck, Fred Turner, and Langdon Winner, whose work informs this summary.⁶

The first and foremost key principle of cyberlibertarianism is that it embraces an uncritical technological determinism.⁷ Technology is understood not as a neutral player in society but as a net good that exists somehow separate from the cultures in which it is crafted. It is world-changing and inevitable, solving social ills and radically reshaping all sectors of industry and our everyday lives. Technology, according to Silicon Valley, will bring peace and prosperity to the developing world, creating a utopia that is like something out of *Star Trek*, where nation-states and differences between people are eliminated in favor of a society solely guided by rationalism.⁸ Like the 1997 MCI anthem commercial that presents the internet as a utopia⁹ or the 1999 science fiction movie *The Matrix*, where characters live in either a dystopian material world or an artificial virtual reality, we will connect “mind to mind” and leave our messy bodies behind—a false proposition that is attractive to those who believe we live in a postracial or postdifference society.¹⁰ This perspective also allows for few interventions or ways of understanding the possible consequences of new technology for society. As Judy Wajcman has noted, embracing a hard technological determinist view “narrows the possibility for democratic engagement ... present[ing] a limited set of options: uncritical embracing of technological change, defensive adaption to it, or simple rejection of it.”¹¹ Nuanced critiques are missing in favor of broad pronouncements of the benefits (or ills) of technology, ultimately handing its development to a technocratic few.

A second key principle of cyberlibertarianism, which is explored in detail in this chapter, is the sacrosanct nature of the individual and an unwavering belief in meritocratic explanations for success and failure. Diversity is valued in principle by many Silicon Valley companies, but it is secondary to individual merit. Individuals are seen as solely responsible for improving their own lot in life, and any institutional or systemic barriers to success (such as the very real prejudices that women and BIPOC face) are irrelevant in the

meatless sphere of cyberspace. The lack of women participating in open-source software development or Wikipedia editing, for example, is explained as a failure of the individual rather than as a reflection of systemic barriers that might reduce women's ability to participate.¹² Paradoxically, the success of those who are marginalized in some way in these same spaces is often attributed to their identity. So a woman game developer might immediately face suspicion that she is successful only because she's a woman or because she's used her feminine wiles to "game" what is purported to be a level playing field (such as in #Gamergate, discussed in chapter 2). In making these claims, those who advocate for merit do so often as a defense against diversity. The distinction they make also adheres to a false Cartesian mind and body split. Put simply, merit is all about minds. Diversity is all about bodies. In cyberspace, minds are good, and bodies are bad. So it follows that merit is good and diversity is ... less good.

A free-market approach to capitalism serves as the third key principle of cyberlibertarianism. While the utopian fantasy of *Star Trek* suggests a postcash economy, Silicon Valley instead embraces capitalism and the free market. In this view, technological progress is predicated on a libertarian approach to the economy. Cyberlibertarianism embraces right-wing economic policy and sees governmental intervention as both undesirable and potentially dangerous in that it might impede technological progress (and thus social progress). As David Golumbia argues, this perspective sees the government not as a servant of the public but as its enemy. Markets are inherently self-regulating, and any attempts to limit or subject them to governmental restrictions ultimately damage the public.¹³ He notes that "this market-based form of accountability does not merely trump the electoral and legal accountability built into representative government, but also shields corporate forces from the political critique to which the right routinely subjects government. In other words, no matter how much power corporations take, their power can never be 'evil' in the way that governmental power inherently is."¹⁴ Implicit in the cyberlibertarian ideology is an embrace of what Nick Srnicek terms "platform

capitalism,” in which huge companies like Google and Amazon control large quantities of data.¹⁵ In this world, consumers and their behaviors are the product. Another formulation of this, offered by Shoshana Zuboff, argues that our economy has become one of “surveillance capitalism,” which “claims human experience as free raw material for translation into behavioral data. Although some of these data are applied to service improvement, the rest are declared as a proprietary *behavioral surplus*, fed into advanced manufacturing processes known as ‘machine intelligence,’ and fabricated into *prediction products* that anticipate what you will do now, soon, and later.”¹⁶ Under this perspective, humans and their activities are data points to be mined and commodified. The structural inequalities of capitalism are considered unfortunate coincidences rather than predictable outcomes.

Relatedly, a fourth key principle of cyberlibertarianism is its reliance on gift economies and unpaid labor. This is easily recognizable on today’s social media platforms, which would not exist without vast quantities of user-generated content. As Tarleton Gillespie argues, the very notion of a platform suggests that these companies are merely providing a set of technological tools (a foundation) for individuals to share their own content.¹⁷ This conveniently allows platform administrators to remain value neutral, as content is generated by the community and not the company itself—even though spaces like Facebook often act as de facto media companies (but without the attendant legal and ethical consequences). The earliest online communities (such as the WELL) featured robust gift economies where individuals frequently shared information and social network connections without the explicit assumption that others would reciprocate.¹⁸ But as in all gift economies, reciprocity was implied, and a set of social relationships developed as a result.¹⁹ Fred Turner argues that “the rhetoric of community provided the ideological cover necessary to transform a potentially stark and single-minded market transaction into a complex, multidimensional act ... members ... could simultaneously recognize and ignore the degree to which they were also exchanging financially valuable goods within a newly informational economy.”²⁰

The term *virtual community*, which Howard Rheingold popularized in the early 1990s to describe spaces like the WELL, blurred the line between the social and the economic and obscured the ultimate beneficiary of these activities—corporations.

A fifth key principle of cyberlibertarianism is an assumption that technology is a net good for society or at the very least, neutral (when it's convenient). From this perspective, technology (and the internet, in particular) will increase democratic participation, help activists overthrow authoritarian governments, and lead to more prosperity as entrepreneurs from the Global South access new forms of capital and markets. Much like the neoliberal view that capitalism necessarily leads to democratic forms of governance, cyberlibertarianism relies on the idea that technology empowers businesses and individuals by flattening barriers to their political (and market) participation. When confronted with the ways that technology can lead to further authoritarianism or has tilted in favor of conservatives, as Jen Schradie persuasively argues, Silicon Valley apologists change their tune—suggesting that actually what they meant was that technology is in fact *neutral*.²¹ This insistence that technology is neutral and that almost any regulation brought to bear on the internet industry would be devastating economically allows companies to imply that they themselves are politically neutral. This badge of supposed neutrality has vast implications for how these companies approach content and allows the largest social media platforms (such as Facebook and Twitter/X) to avoid the scrutiny that publishers face—despite acting as de facto media companies.

A sixth, and related, key principle of cyberlibertarianism is a reliance on Western frontier myths as a defense against critique, political intervention, and regulation on behalf of the public. These myths were an especially prominent element of the early web manifestos and other writings by individuals like John Perry Barlow, Stewart Brand, and Howard Rheingold, who were critical players in shaping how we think about the contemporary web and were influenced by the New Communalist movement of the 1960s and 1970s.²² As Fred Turner persuasively argues, the New Communalists were heavily invested in a particular flavor of the hippie

counterculture that emphasized personal growth, established small communities and communes, and explored cybernetics as a unifying principle for understanding the world.²³ These individuals were less interested in political or activist engagements with the world and, instead, venerated psychedelics, yoga, EST, transcendental meditation, and other “new age” interests because they could highlight our interconnected nature and allow us to explore new frontiers in personal development. Likewise, indigenous ways of knowing were fetishized (and retooled in publications like *The Whole Earth Catalog*) as a way of getting back to the land, as if colonization was simply a thing of the past and not an everyday reality for many people around the world. The early web was variously described as an “electronic frontier,” an “information superhighway,” “cyberspace,” and a “global village”—metaphors that recalled “uncivilized” landscapes that needed to be tamed by pioneers and “cybernauts.” As Laura Miller argues, “the Western narrative connects pleasurably with the American romance of individualistic masculinity; small wonder that the predominately male founders of the Net’s culture found it so appealing.”²⁴ Any possible restrictions on the way companies “settled” these uncharted lands were therefore cast as stifling innovation and eventually leading to economic devastation. Cyberlibertarian ideology suggests that the frontier is merely a collection of individuals and businesses that require little, if any, government intervention—or, rather, that they are beyond the reach of the government, as John Perry Barlow suggests in his manifesto.²⁵

Despite the clear political implications of cyberlibertarianism, Silicon Valley denizens insist their technocratic vision is apolitical. At the same time (as is mentioned in chapter 2), both the alternative web and the mainstream web champion a vision in which technology is a force for social good. But when it comes to regulations or policies, many of these same platforms espouse their neutrality. As mentioned above, even their use of the word *platform* works to frame services for their various constituencies—advertisers, regulators, and the public—in ways that ultimately benefit the companies themselves rather than the public interest.²⁶ Political movements that arise from alternative web spaces (in particular)

conveniently mirror the cyberlibertarian ideology championed by platform owners and creators—often targeting institutions (governmental and religious) and championing both social liberalism and fiscal conservatism. The frontier mythos is deeply embedded in these movements as well, suggesting that the old ways of doing things must be “disrupted” by internet pioneers for the benefit of humanity.

FROM NERD TO BRO: NERD AND GEEK MASCULINITY

Silicon Valley, beyond any political underpinnings, is *nerdy*. As Chris Kelty argues, nerds (or in his words, geeks) form a kind of “recursive public” that shares “an abiding moral imagination of the technical infrastructure, the Internet, that has allowed them to develop and maintain this affinity in the first place.”²⁷ The nerds and geeks of Silicon Valley have become increasingly prevalent figures in the media, due in no small part to their growing economic and social capital. Since the 1980s, popular culture has led this charge with movies like *Real Genius* (1985), *Revenge of the Nerds* (1984), *Sixteen Candles* (1984), and *Weird Science* (1985) crafting tales of revenge and nerd triumphalism.²⁸ This also mirrors the changing landscape of fandom and the power of audiences generally, as fans of particular genres and types (including science fiction, fantasy, comic books, and gaming) have long been constructed as both nerdy but potentially lucrative by Hollywood because of their enormous textual and semiotic productivity.²⁹ Sarah Thornton suggests that this productivity creates a kind of subcultural capital that structures these spaces, connects individuals within the fandom around a shared object of interest, and marks who is and is not a fan.³⁰ This process can be twisted into a form of gatekeeping whereby certain individuals are chided for not being “real fans” or are construed as being outside the fandom in some way. Moments like this suggest that the default geek or nerd is a cisgender, heterosexual (hereafter cishet) White man. Women, BIPOC, and the queer community are as a result left out in the cold.

The difference between geeks and nerds has been discussed endlessly.³¹ As David Bell writes, it's "something to do with the balance between obsessive overinterest in specialist knowledge, an orientation toward intelligence, and degrees of self-awareness."³² For the purposes of this book, I use the terms interchangeably. The word *geek* derives from *geck*, a German and Dutch term used as early as the 1500s to describe a fool, dupe, or simpleton.³³ The word eventually morphed into *geek* and was a commonly used US slang term in the late 1800s. In the early 1900s, it gained a second meaning describing circus or carnival performers whose acts were bizarre or grotesque (like biting off the heads of live snakes), presumably because they were so unskilled that this was their only talent.³⁴ In this formulation, the geek is wholly other, an outsider among outsiders. In the 1980s, the term was reformulated to describe someone who was adept with computers but lacked charm or grace.³⁵

Images of the nerd in popular culture remain deeply racialized as (mostly) cishet White men, despite Silicon Valley's attempt to portray itself as increasingly diverse.³⁶ As Christopher T. Fan argues, "the figure of the nerd makes it easy to accept the rhetoric of 'white and Asian' predominance, and thus grant Silicon Valley a baseline level of diversity that downplays its racism."³⁷ This formulation is reductive (Asianness in tech gets conflated with skilled H1B visa holders and middle- and upper-class workers when the reality is more complex)³⁸ and underplays the larger classism and racism present in tech culture.

Lori Kendall offers the concept of "geek masculinity" to describe the ways that the geek/nerd identity often conjoins masculinity with technical prowess and niche interests.³⁹ While geek/nerd masculinity repudiates some aspects of hegemonic masculinity, it embraces others. Or as David Bell suggests, geek masculinity "resists, reaffirms, *and* ironizes hegemonic masculinity."⁴⁰ In contrast to dominant forms of masculinity, the geek or nerd is often pictured as socially awkward, sexually undesirable, and unathletic. And while nerds are having a bit of a moment with the ascendance of Silicon Valley entrepreneurs like Elon Musk and Hollywood films that

embrace comic books, fantasy, and science fiction, the nerd identity remains fringe in other ways.

Geek and nerd masculinity therefore can be viewed as falling under the umbrella of what Tristan Bridges and C. J. Pascoe term “hybrid masculinities.”⁴¹ This concept highlights the “selective incorporation of elements of identity typically associated with various marginalized and subordinated masculinities and—at times—femininities into privileged men’s gender performances and identities.”⁴² But others have disagreed with the notion that geek masculinity is somehow subordinate to other forms of hegemonic masculinity. Instead, Heather Mendick and her coauthors suggest that the rise of “geek entrepreneurs” like Elon Musk and Jeff Bezos “should not be viewed as a threat or an inflection of earlier hegemonic formations but as their success, his ambiguity and fragility being not a weakness but a strength.”⁴³ They identify three interlocking characteristics that create a framework by which the geek identity has become hegemonic. Discourses of suffering, genius, and disruption are frequently mentioned as key aspects of the geek entrepreneur’s success, allowing them to lay claim to a new form of masculinity that, while seemingly contradictory, is actually complicit in late-stage capitalism and patriarchy.⁴⁴

Geek masculinity embraces hegemonic masculinity’s belief that cisgender women are romantic and sexual objects. This is evidenced by the “nice guy” phenomenon—a trope seen across social media where a man suggests that a woman should be happy to receive attention from a geek because he will treat her nicely (in contrast to the other jerks and jocks out there). If she ignores his overtures, she is immediately branded a “whore” or “slut,” suggesting that the nice guy is hiding his misogyny under a veneer of politeness.⁴⁵

While this embrace of marginalized masculinities might suggest a move toward a more egalitarian and inclusive society, hybrid masculinities instead often re-entrench existing systems of inequality (around gender, race, and sexuality), perpetuating them in new and more pernicious ways. In her examination of how gender and popular culture intersect with food culture, for example, Emily J. H. Contois notes that the increasing acceptance of having men cook for

their families (as represented by the popularity of heterosexual “dude” chefs like Guy Fieri) doesn’t actually lead to systemic changes in how domestic labor is shared.⁴⁶ Instead, men are showered with praise for doing domestic chores often associated with femininity while women’s labor is rarely valued.

The increasing prevalence of the *brogrammer*—a portmanteau of the words *bro* (used to describe someone who fits hegemonic standards of masculinity) and *programmer*—is a potent example of how the inclusion of subordinated masculinities does not necessarily lead to structural changes. As a brogrammer, the nerd transcends the image of the STEM-inclined young man who is socially awkward, sexually frustrated, and physically inept. Instead, the brogrammer is the college fraternity nerd—physically fit, successful with women (as brogrammers are imagined as cishet men), and interested in tech in the same way jocks might be interested in sports.⁴⁷ He also uses his nerdy technical expertise and interest in how systems operate to manage other aspects of his daily life. He may weightlift and track his macros, wear a FitBit or Apple Watch to track his exercise, explore drugs like nootropics and microdose psychedelics to enhance his creativity and productivity while coding, and use an assortment of apps and smart home devices to make his life more efficient and “frictionless.” While the classic nerd or geek might see the body as the enemy—an impediment to his success with women or the reason for his unpopularity—the brogrammer views the body as merely another program to be debugged and optimized. He views each aspect of his life (professional, social, spiritual, and romantic) as a self-improvement project that can be gamified and improved if he listens to the right podcast, finds the right subreddit, or subscribes to the right YouTube channel.⁴⁸ Thus, the brogrammer’s media diet is awash in lifehacks and pseudo-philosophical conversations that highlight his superiority over others and suggest that his success in each of these domains is because of his natural, innate abilities, not because he happened to be playing the game on the easiest level of difficulty.⁴⁹

At the same time, the brogrammer (or nerd or geek) remains convinced of his own status as a perennial outsider. Kom Kunyosying

and Carter Soles argue that geeks share a “simulated ethnicity,” viewing their subcultural identity as a form of marginalization.⁵⁰ And while some forms of geek masculinity *are* subordinate when compared to hegemonic masculinity (as Raewyn L. Connell argues in her canonical 1995 *Masculinities*), the increased economic, social, and cultural power of Silicon Valley means that many geeks no longer inhabit this position.⁵¹ Or as Joseph Reagle writes, “Geeks believe that being smart and idiosyncratic contributed to their past marginalization. These same attributes contribute to their present success.”⁵² Mendick et al. question this perspective, noting that while “suffering is constitutive of geek status ... the increasing social power of geeks makes it more difficult to assert their claim to moral authority through it.”⁵³ It is critical that we do not discount the privilege that many White men within the tech industry have, even while acknowledging that they themselves might feel like their own interests are not mainstream.

This duality—a sense of marginalization paired with a reality of increasing economic capital and cultural relevance—creates an odd tension. Geeks may see themselves as objects of ridicule and scorn, but they likely also benefit in tangible ways from their interests. It becomes a point of pride on platforms like Reddit, where niche expertise is celebrated but where suggestions of structural barriers to participation in these same communities are rejected. Likewise, the *habitus* of the tech industry prizes markers of (White) geek masculinity as a form of cultural capital—demarcating those who do not fit this raced, classed, and gendered image as somehow other.⁵⁴ The increasingly diverse nature of fan communities and the diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) efforts within STEM fields question this particular construction and challenge the centrality of the cishet White man as the prototypical nerd. And this tension increasingly dominates public life and has been easily coopted by operatives within the alt- and far right.

When reinforced by the right diet of media content and peer interactions, the feeling of superiority shared by both the classic geek/nerd and the brogrammer can be transformed into the misogyny and White supremacy inherent in alt-right ideology. As

Elizabeth Sandifer notes in her examination of neoreactionism (a philosophy with deep connections to both geek culture and the alt-right), adherents believe that the world would be better off if they were allowed to run it. This suggests both a stunning arrogance (the cyber- and technolibertarian ideals of the geek should be applied to every domain of modern life) and a disdain for the expertise of others.⁵⁵ This can have catastrophic consequences, as happened when Redditors tried to identify the people who set two bombs at the Boston Marathon on April 15, 2013, thinking they could do a better job with the investigation than the police, only to accuse the wrong individual.⁵⁶

MERITOCRACY AS KEY TO TOXIC GEEK MASCULINITY

Not all geek masculinity is toxic, but there are reasons that geek culture often welcomes toxicity.⁵⁷ One reason is its reliance on meritocratic explanations for a person's success as a programmer, a gamer, or a tech entrepreneur. As Christopher A. Paul suggests, there is a pernicious connection between gaming culture and an embrace of meritocratic explanations for why certain people succeed and others don't.⁵⁸ It is reinforced by many of the underlying logics of games—that every encounter results in a win or lose outcome and that those who succeed in winning the game do so because they are simply better players. This mindset is seductive as it provides a framework for understanding the world under late capitalism and offers a simplistic rationale that removes any structural explanations for why some people succeed and others don't. It's also intertwined with the ways firms are organized in Silicon Valley, with corporate hierarchies based on seniority being eschewed for ones that emphasize merit.

While this perspective might seem relatively innocuous, it serves to eliminate possible objections to the current power structure—whether political, military-industrial, or cultural—by suggesting that those who are at the top (and who have the most) earned their way there and that those who aren't at the top didn't try hard enough. As Jo Littler argues, “the idea of meritocracy has become a key means

through which plutocracy—or government by a wealthy elite—perpetuates, produces and extends itself.”⁵⁹ In particular, the notion of meritocracy props up and supports neoliberal capitalism.⁶⁰ For Silicon Valley firms and video game companies, meritocratic ideology provides them a convenient rationale for why their organizations fall well short when it comes to attracting and retaining BIPOC, women, and members of the LGBTQIA+ community. For the video game players and fans of comics, anime, sci-fi, and other geeky pursuits, meritocratic discourses provide an attractive framework for understanding how the world works and create a false sense of agency in a system that pretends structural and cultural advantages don’t exist. In many ways, accepting this vision of reality is indeed “playing the game” within the confines of how the game designers (in this case, the plutocracy) intended it. And hegemonic media narratives reproduce and normalize these power structures as simply how things are.

This narrative is further complicated by the nature of fandom. As mentioned above, fan communities are bound together by subcultural capital, which often means that members engage in a form of gatekeeping to determine who is (and isn’t) a part of the scene. But geek communities often further marginalize those who are viewed as interlopers by requiring certain individuals to demonstrate their deep subject knowledge repeatedly. This may take the form of mansplaining, in which a cishet White man feels the need to explain in boorish detail some aspect of a game or fandom to a woman (and there seems to be extra bonus points if she’s BIPOC or part of the LGBTQIA+ community) who is already well aware of these details.⁶¹ Instead of reveling in shared interests (presumably the ones that actually bind these subcultures together), these interactions suggest a deep-seated and often unspoken assumption that women are not capable of being geeks. Embedded within the “fake geek girl” trope is the implication that girls and women who are interested in comic books or video games are doing so only for male attention. As Suzanne Scott argues, this kind of “spreadable misogyny” works to disenfranchise women and their contributions to fan cultures and requires that they “perform their

competency in masculinized modes of fan engagement (textual mastery, collecting, trivia, etc.).⁶² It also implies that the fandom will become somehow diluted because media producers will cater to these perceived interlopers and the experiences of cishet White men will no longer remain central—a point that drove much of the #Gamergate discourse. As noted in chapter 2, this gets tied up into the sticky category of gamer (for example), an odd formulation that somehow excludes as many people as it includes.

While geek masculinity embraces aspects of gender equality, at least in principle, clinging to meritocratic ideals quickly breeds resentment and toxicity. Geeky women are presumed to have the same opportunities as men, with any differences in their success being attributed to choices they've made rather than structural barriers. In this way, geek masculinity implicitly suggests a postfeminist and postracial reality in which the work of civil rights activism of the 1960s and 1970s has been completed.⁶³ In this formulation, men (particularly cishet White men) are victims of feminism and other social movements that have gone too far. One of the more pernicious aspects of this perspective is that it allows people to view themselves apart from the systems that are inherently racist and sexist and encourages the kind of colorblind or genderblind attitude that scholars have long challenged.⁶⁴ As discussed above, this formulation also positions male geeks as a kind of “simulated ethnicity” per Kunyosying and Soles—suggesting that their identity is under continuous attack from feminists and social justice warriors who are hell-bent on ruining their favorite things.⁶⁵

The media have played a critical role in perpetuating toxic geek masculinity. Campaigns like #Gamergate (discussed in chapter 2) courted public exposure on social media to recruit more individuals to their cause. And niche YouTube videos and podcasts became significant platforms for #Gamergate supporters to discuss what they perceived as the scourge of social justice warriors in gaming (and beyond).⁶⁶ Later, the movement received publicity from more mainstream outlets—newspapers like the *New York Times*, TV news satire and late night shows like *The Colbert Report*, and cable news outlets like CNN. As scholars working within disinformation studies

have noted, there's a fine line between reporting on these movements and implicitly promoting their dangerous conspiracy theories.⁶⁷ Journalistic norms and the political-economic reality of media organizations often work to platform speech (especially when it's coming from official sources like politicians) in ways that legitimate that speech no matter how untrue or odious. In October 2014, one game journalist suggested the move from niche spaces like 4chan and Reddit to broadcast and print journalism had killed the movement, writing, "Gamergate died ironically from what it most wanted: mainstream exposure."⁶⁸ In hindsight, what actually happened is that many of the core #Gamergate supporters were radicalized into various factions of the alt-right, with some moving into White identitarian, incel/red pill, and QAnon communities and others becoming supporters of Donald Trump's campaign. So #Gamergate wasn't actually killed. It just morphed into something worse. By dismissing #Gamergate as a one-off event involving a small group of young, angry nerds who were mad about video games, many journalists perpetuated a narrative that both minimized the actual harms that occurred and failed to see how the movement was never simply just about video games.

THE INTELLECTUAL DARK WEB AND THE DANGERS OF PLATFORMING TERRIBLENESS

The intellectual dark web (IDW) is an underdiscussed and wildly popular introductory point for individuals looking into the murky space of the alt-right. It has also been popularized by the media. In a 2018 profile for the *New York Times*, journalist Bari Weiss (herself a member) introduced a loose confederation of podcasters (Joe Rogan and Dave Rubin), new atheists (Sam Harris and Steven Pinker), journalists (Andrew Sullivan), and academics (Jordan Peterson and Jonathan Haidt), suggesting they were united in their opposition to the left's supposed authoritarian impulses and its desire to censor views it finds unpalatable.⁶⁹ Members of the network, while politically diverse, demonstrate a distain for what they see as the evils of "identity politics," "wokeism," "cultural

Marxism,” and “postmodernism” (particularly on university campuses); champion a libertarian worldview (especially when it comes to personal liberties); and prize “rationality.” By this, I mean many of them position themselves as intellectuals who are simply challenging the status quo and encouraging their audiences to question the current social and political order—rather than potentially undermining the progress being made on expanding trans, LGBTQIA+, and BIPOC rights. They venerate the intellectual traditions associated with the Global North as offering the only valid form of knowledge production, despite long histories of indigenous, feminist, and decolonialized ways of knowing. As with other alt-right communities (such as the manosphere),⁷⁰ much of the toxic masculinity embraced by the IDW is driven by a fascination with classical thought. Donna Zuckerberg notes, “By turning frequently to authors such as Marcus Aurelius and Ovid, they attempt to perpetuate the idea that white men are the guardians of intellectual authority, especially when such authority is perceived to be under threat from women and people of color.”⁷¹ Members of the IDW believe that the current “politically correct” climate represents an embrace of identity politics in lieu of deep, intellectual engagement where multiple viewpoints can be expressed. However, I would suggest that this argument is actually used as subterfuge to escape the consequences of hate speech that others might find objectionable.

Members of the IDW are also connected by their embrace of social media, while chafing at what they perceive as its overly paternalistic nature. They often express transphobic, racist, misogynistic/antifeminist, authoritarian, and Islamophobic views in the guise of intellectual debate, while offering simplistic biologically essentialist arguments and reviving outdated ideologies like race science. When confronted on social media with rebuttals or threatened with deplatforming because of the hate speech they spread, they declare themselves the victim of a culture that has grown soft and unwilling to engage in substantive intellectual debates. Often their odious viewpoints are cloaked in ways that suggest they are merely “asking hard questions” or “saying what

everyone else thinks but are too scared to say.” Even more commonly, they suggest that they are providing a platform for others to speak and that they themselves have no opinions about “politics.” Joe Rogan is one such example. The former comedian, actor, and mixed martial arts enthusiast hosts long, rambling conversations with a wide variety of guests on his popular podcast *The Joe Rogan Experience*. Rogan demonstrates a stunning carelessness about his role in platforming and perpetuating harmful ideas and seems to have little issue with hosting people like antivaxxer Dr. Robert Malone, Trump supporter and conspiracist Alex Jones, and Proud Boys founder Gavin McInnes (twice). And while Rogan also invites plenty of celebrities, technologists, and presidential candidates (including Bernie Sanders) to smoke marijuana or cigars with him on his show, his willingness to broadcast a two-hour conversation with those directly associated with the alt-right in which he makes no attempt to challenge or even question their views contributes to normalizing their odious perspectives. In addition, those accessing *The Joe Rogan Experience* through YouTube (Rogan posts videos of his conversations on YouTube and audio-only versions on Spotify and other streaming sites) are often exposed to more extremist content after viewing Rogan’s episodes with particularly provocative guests. Rogan continues to underplay or deny his influence and seems unconcerned that his large audience may be exposed to misinformation about COVID-19 or conspiracy theories like QAnon and incel ideology.

In his analysis of the ideological underpinnings of the intellectual dark web, Alan Finlayson argues that the views espoused are united not by what vision they have for the world but rather by what they stand against.⁷² In particular, they critique the “new class” of elites at the center of “technocratic liberalism”—namely, professors, journalists, Hollywood elites, experts, and government officials. They generally view liberalism as being “based on denial of nature ... forcefully imposed by institutions of education, and systems of communication controlled by cynical and elitist ‘universal’ intellectuals, ready to deploy the weapons of censure and censorship.”⁷³ Thus, members of the IDW see themselves as offering

the unvarnished truth about the world and as being “brave, honest, subversive thinkers unafraid to challenge established power.”⁷⁴ In suggesting they are subversive and honest, members of the IDW elide their privileged positions and ignore the reality that they are not actually being refused a platform to speak.⁷⁵ Much like the geeks mentioned above, members of the IDW believe themselves to be marginalized and victims of threats from social justice warriors, cultural Marxists, postmodernists, cancel culture, and wokeism. The threats that supposedly persecute members of the IDW have increasingly become regular talking points in mainstream conservative circles and the Republican Party in the United States.

While united in their sense of persecution, individual members of the IDW may vary in their actual politics. Many, like Jordan Peterson and Andrew Sullivan, would likely describe themselves as classic liberals. Others, like Joe Rogan, veer into libertarian territory (embracing marijuana legalization, for example, but also championing law enforcement). Still others (such as Dave Rubin) have publicly disavowed their prior support for the Democratic Party and realigned with the Republican Party or other right-wing parties. While the IDW is not unified under a particular party or political ideology, discussions about certain social issues on Joe Rogan’s podcast can sound strikingly similar to opinions espoused by someone like former Fox News anchor Tucker Carlson. Trans rights, in particular, seem to be a favorite topic of ridicule for members of the IDW, even if they might identify as sympathetic to other LGBT causes. One member of the IDW, Jordan Peterson, gained prominence after objecting to Bill C-16 when its provisions to update the Canadian Human Rights Act were before the Canadian Parliament. Peterson, a psychology professor at the University of Toronto before his resignation in 2022, disagreed with the bill on the grounds that it would force him to use the pronouns consistent with his students’ gender identities.⁷⁶ Like their conservative counterparts, the IDW views anything relating to identity politics with suspicion if not outright disdain.

Just as the alternative web (discussed in chapter 2) bridges fringe spaces like 8chan and mainstream ones like Facebook, the IDW also

serves as a conduit for introducing individuals to more extremist viewpoints by offering a platform to key players within the alt-right. By couching their discourse in the guise of intellectualism, members of the IDW suggest that their opinions, however objectionable, are necessary and that audiences should be able to draw their own conclusions about their value. IDW members venerate an absolutist version of the American “marketplace of ideas” approach to free speech, often introducing their audiences to increasingly fringe perspectives that legitimate them as reasonable if not rational. So when podcaster Joe Rogan offers a platform to Proud Boy’s founder Gavin McInnes and conspiracy theorist Alex Jones for a two-hour conversation during which they smoke cigars together, he normalizes their views as reasonable, even if he doesn’t personally agree with them. Rogan hides behind the veneer of being an actor and does not follow any journalistic norms on his podcast. But this makes his platforming of people like McInnes and Jones even more troubling. Like many other members of the intellectual dark web, Joe Rogan’s insistence that he is apolitical or liberal is problematic. It belies the fact that providing a platform is a political act, even if the desired outcome is for one to appear neutral. And while Rogan (much like Facebook) does not want to view himself as a media outlet, it’s hard to argue that he is not a major player in introducing his listeners to a wide variety of public figures, including comedians, politicians, pundits, celebrities, conspiracy theorists, entrepreneurs, hacks, and racists.

This is a problem for many reasons. Rogan is not an effective interlocuter (that is, he doesn’t actually question or counter any of Gavin McInnes’s racist opinions and treats Alex Jones as merely a wacky friend), suggesting the dangerous perspectives of these figures are actually worth considering. This fact, coupled with algorithmic logics of YouTube and other podcasting platforms, means that listeners are often sent down a rabbit hole into more extremist content after listening to these episodes.⁷⁷ Additionally, Joe Rogan (like much of the intellectual dark web) has a huge audience of mostly young White men⁷⁸—a group perfectly situated to become more radicalized into the world of the alt-right and conservative

conspiracy theories like QAnon. Offering McInnes and Jones a platform both normalizes and amplifies their toxic speech.

Many members of the intellectual dark web decry deplatforming (removal of a registered user from a social media platform) and its supposed effects on their ability to court an audience and make money, suggesting that deplatforming amounts to censorship. Research has shown that some of the most controversial figures within the alt-right (such as Alex Jones and Milo Yiannopoulos) who have been banned from spaces like Twitter/X were discussed less frequently on the platform after their removal.⁷⁹ And refusing to platform the kind of speech McInnes and Jones traffic in has also made a difference in decreasing toxicity overall on spaces like Reddit.⁸⁰ However, the IDW's suggestion that not having access to mainstream platforms like Twitter or YouTube is a violation of the right to free speech is inaccurate. Social media platforms are private companies and thus are not bound by the First Amendment (in the US) in the same way that federal, state, and local governments are. Additionally, numerous other places on the alternative web (such as BitChute, Gab, and Donald Trump's Truth Social) are happy to host these individuals and their noxious followers. It's interesting that conversations around the threat of deplatforming have grown in the years since #Gamergate. Google Trends suggests that the term was first used in June 2015 and its use spiked in January 2021 (likely because of the January 6 insurrection).⁸¹ While the early web had its own version of deplatforming (usually called *banning*), the IDW's implication here is that having access to mainstream social media platforms, not just those affiliated with the alternative web (discussed in chapter 5) or the alt-tech space, is a fundamental right.

#DONGLEGATE AND THE GOOGLE MEMO

To understand the ways that Silicon Valley, like the intellectual dark web, implicitly positions cishet White men as central figures, it's useful to examine a case in which someone doesn't fit these categories. It began when Adria Richards, a Black video game

developer, attended PyCon 2013, the conference for users of the open-source Python programming language that was held in Santa Clara, California. At one conference talk, Richards overheard two men (later identified as employees of the mobile game monetization company PlayHaven) seated behind her using the terms *dongles* (small devices that plug in to computers) and *forking* (a branching off of source code) as euphemisms for penises and sexual intercourse.⁸² These sexual comments were against the conference's code of conduct, and she reported the men to conference organizers, who pulled the individuals aside to remind them of the code. Richards also tweeted about the incident (stating, "Not cool. Jokes about forking repro's in a sexual way and 'big' dongles. Right behind me. #pycon") and included a photograph of the men with her post. The image identified the individuals and underscored that the PyCon audience was almost entirely White men, highlighting Richards's status as an anomaly in this tech bro-friendly space.

One of the PlayHaven developers was later fired, with the company's CEO noting that there had been inaccuracies in what had been made public but that "we believe in the importance of discussing sensitive topics such as gender and conduct and we hope to move forward with a civil dialogue based on the facts."⁸³ In a post on Hacker News (a geek-friendly social news site focused on tech), the fired developer claimed that Richards's blog post about the incident was why he lost his job, but he apologized for his behavior.⁸⁴ Richards disputed this timeline in her own account of the story, suggesting that the firing occurred before she posted about the event on her blog.

Although the PyCon story occurred nearly a year and a half before #Gamergate, PyCon attackers used the same tactics that later became synonymous with mob actions—memetic warfare, direct online attacks, and offline harassment. After the story moved from Hacker News to 4chan's /b/ (random) board, Richards was subjected to intense online attacks and harassment. The hashtag #Donglegate was deployed and weaponized to spread vitriol about Richards, with image macros featuring the developer spreading quickly on 4chan and Twitter. Individuals trawled her public Twitter feed to find

material they suggested was as offensive as what she heard at PyCon and therefore made her a hypocrite.⁸⁵ Later, she was doxed by the mob and subject to death and rape threats. Her employer, SendGrid, faced distributed denial of service (DDoS) attacks during this period, and numerous attackers signed a petition asking SendGrid to fire Adria Richards, presumably implying the mob would stop the DDoS attacks if the company complied.

Richards was quickly fired from her position as a developer, with her employer noting that “SendGrid supports the right to report inappropriate behavior, whenever and wherever it occurs. What we do not support was how she [Richards] reported the conduct. Her decision to tweet the comments and photographs of the people who made the comments crossed the line. Publicly shaming the offenders—and bystanders—was not the appropriate way to handle the situation.”⁸⁶ These words might be seen as examples of both victim-blaming and tone-policing. SendGrid’s statement centered on Richards’s response to the conference comments and not on the words of the men themselves. It suggests that reporting such behavior was an acceptable response (almost as if Richards needed permission to do so) but did not articulate the actual issue—that the men at the conference assumed their conduct was if not welcomed then tacitly accepted in a space that catered to cishet White men and not BIPOC women. By stating that Richards should have handled the men’s comments differently, her employer also implied that the issue was her use of Twitter to call out the behavior. As Lisa Nakamura argues, this sort of public naming (of someone who has done something wrong) is a form of digital labor but one that is not recognized as such because it is often performed by women of color.⁸⁷ Public “naming and shaming” necessarily calls into question often unstated assumptions about the nature of harassment and abuse, including the assumption that the victims and their allies should stay silent in the hopes that institutions can address these issues adequately. This also points to an unstated presumption of social media—that visibility online is situated and normed around amplifying the voices of cishet White men and not Black women.

Instead, visibility in these cases becomes weaponized against those, like Richards, who speak out.

Unsurprisingly, both companies failed to support Richards. PlayHaven, the employer of the developers who joked about dongles and forking, also issued a lackluster response after the PyCon incident. In characterizing the entire #Donglegate affair as simply “a topic concerning a former PlayHaven employee [that] has generated a passionate online debate,” the company obfuscated what happened and downplayed the nature of the harassment.⁸⁸ Like SendGrid, PlayHaven’s management did not suggest that anything meaningful would change in its organization. The company’s blog post about the events did not announce any larger training or diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) initiatives. Instead, it framed the incident as a singular event rather than an endemic pattern within tech spaces.

Richards’s harassment after her complaint and the lack of support she received from the broader tech community are unfortunately not surprising given her social location and the realities of being a Black woman. As Moya Bailey argues, Black women are subjected to a toxic mixture of racism and sexism online that she describes as “misogynoir.”⁸⁹ Bailey’s work echoes other Black feminist scholarship that considers the intersectional nature of identity and the ways that Black women (in particular) are subject to multiple axes of oppression.⁹⁰ Richards is doubly marked: she is a Black woman on social media (which already subjects her to disproportionate harassment, as Bailey and others have noted), and she is also a Black woman developer. Like the category of geek, Richards’s presence in the developer community made her an oddity. This mirrors other geek-friendly spaces, where marginalized individuals are often marked as “deviant.”⁹¹ Kishonna L. Gray astutely notes that marginalized gamers, for example, “lack the symbolic capital to be seen as full participants” and that their presence is seen as a threat to the unspoken norms that mark gamers as White.⁹² This is also true in other online spaces, where Whiteness acts a kind of “default setting.”⁹³

Adria Richards's story also demonstrates the way that women themselves often internalize the norms of geek masculinity as a way of surviving in spaces that can be hostile.⁹⁴ In one Hacker News posting about the incident, several people who identified themselves as women in tech suggested that they would have laughed at the jokes. (It's entirely possible that these individuals were not women.) They further criticized Richards for not dealing with the matter privately instead of tweeting about the incident to her followers. However, Richards likely publicized the incident to demonstrate how rampant sexism and misogyny are embedded in tech culture. It's a common assumption that women who downplay their femininity in Silicon Valley are more successful. During her tenure at Theranos, Elizabeth Holmes spoke in a lower register and wore gender-neutral clothing in the form of black turtlenecks and trousers. The reality is more complicated, however. As Lauren Alfrey and France Winddance Twine have argued, White and Asian women who present as gender fluid and identify as LGBTQIA+ are more likely to find success on their male-dominated teams.⁹⁵ However, they found this did not hold true for LGBTQIA+ Black women, who struggled to be seen as "one of the guys." Clearly, it is not gender alone that is a marker of difference in tech spaces. It's also Whiteness.

Richards was publicly shamed in part because she was viewed as not a *real* geek (or, rather, not the right *kind* of geek) within the developer community. Her case is striking in comparison to another event that occurred in 2017 (post-#Gamergate), when James Damore, a White engineer at Google, wrote a screed decrying the company's "ideological echo chamber," implying that the real victims of Google's DEI efforts were White, conservative men. He echoed a discredited line of reasoning that suggests women and BIPOC are underrepresented in jobs in leadership and programming at Google because of inherent biological differences.

Damore's memo can be read as connecting the culture of Silicon Valley to the right-wing views of members of the intellectual dark web. Damore starts from the premise that Google is a liberal-leaning organization that has suppressed certain political or moral (presumably right-leaning) viewpoints. He suggests this lack of

honest discussion about issues around diversity has created what he terms an “echo chamber” where not everyone feels included and certain perspectives are repressed. Damore continues by suggesting that Google’s approach to DEI issues is inherently “extreme and authoritarian.” For him, the approach suggests that lack of representation at the company is due exclusively to “oppression” and that the company’s solution has been to “discriminate” against certain individuals to address these realities. Instead, Damore argues that what is missing is a clear understanding that issues of representation at Google reflect real-world biological differences and social preferences rather than structural barriers.

In the case of tech firms, programming jobs are considered more valuable and desirable (coded as masculine) than front-facing design jobs or jobs that involve working with people (coded as feminine).⁹⁶ Damore’s memo implies a similar rationale, suggesting that “women on average show a higher interest in people and men in things,”⁹⁷ are “generally more cooperative and agreeable than men,”⁹⁸ and “are more prone to anxiety.”⁹⁹ Women, minorities, and other marginalized individuals are not “techie” enough to work for Google. While Damore asks the right question (“Why are there so few women and BIPOC at Google?”), he manages to get the answer entirely backward. He refuses to see how structural barriers to participation act as a form of gatekeeping that is reinforced by the tech bro-centric culture of Silicon Valley.

Damore’s memo also repeats many assumptions about meritocracy that have been refuted by scholars but stubbornly remain integral parts of American life. First, the memo implies that a given talent is present from birth and is either developed or not. In the memo, Damore claims that particular individuals (cishet White and Asian men) are predisposed to careers in science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM), while others are not. As Jo Littler argues, however, the logical conclusion of this perspective moves dangerously close to advocating for eugenics.¹⁰⁰ Second, the memo suggests that there is a linear progression by which some people advance and others are left behind, which makes this system inherently competitive and reinforces hierarchies. Damore’s emphasis

on the importance of competition at Google implies that not everyone will be able to succeed and that this is, in fact, a desirable result. It ignores the problem of culture—that is, that many marginalized individuals do not succeed in companies like Google precisely because the companies' culture is hostile to their existence in high-tech spaces. This kind of logic obscures the real inequalities that are barriers to women, BIPOC, LGBTQIA+, and other marginalized groups. In Damore's case, he wrongly suggests that attempts to address these inequalities at Google are a kind of misplaced compassion. In fact, he recommends that Google should "de-emphasize empathy" because "being emotionally unengaged helps us better reason about the facts."¹⁰¹

The ideology underlying the memo not only reflects the dominant culture of Silicon Valley but also echoes many of the views espoused by the intellectual dark web and the alt-right. First, Damore argues that the "overwhelming majority of the social sciences, media, and Google lean left," implying not just that tech culture reflects a liberal bias but that the social sciences (not hard sciences) and the mainstream media promulgate leftist views. He further suggests that this "liberal bias" within the academy "maintains myths like social constructionism and the gender wage gap."¹⁰² In his identification of the media and academics as leftist crusaders for social justice, Damore falls into the same ideological space as those alt-right pundits he chooses to cite in his memo. Second, he argues that "viewpoint diversity is arguably the most important type of diversity" and compares the experience of being a conservative at Google to someone who is still closeted.¹⁰³ Third, he makes numerous claims that suggest the issue is not actually a Google problem, even though he is discussing Google (or maybe Silicon Valley writ large). For example, he argues that "nearly every difference between men and women is interpreted as a form of women's oppression" and "compassion for those seen as weak creates political correctness and is complacent to the extremely sensitive PC-authoritarians that use violence and shaming to advance their cause."¹⁰⁴ He later argues that Google might experience "violent leftist protests" in the same way that university campuses have as a result of their unwillingness

to tolerate conservative viewpoints.¹⁰⁵ And his reliance on faulty “scientific” explanations for why women don’t inhabit leadership positions at Google (for example) strongly echoes long discredited theories.¹⁰⁶ It also fails to acknowledge that these realities are cultural in nature and not easily understood by positivistic approaches. To support his perspective, he cites many within the intellectual dark web—Claire Lehmann and her “free thought” online magazine Quillette;¹⁰⁷ Christina Hoff Sommers, an antifeminist author affiliated with the conservative American Enterprise Institute who gained prominence when she supported the #Gamergate harassment campaign; men’s rights activist Warren Farrell; and academic Jonathan Haidt, the founder of Heterodox Academy who has written extensively about the supposed suppression of conservative views on college campuses. Basically, Damore’s missive reads like a who’s who of pundits associated with the intellectual dark web.

Even though the memo is ostensibly about Google’s approach to DEI initiatives, it’s clear that Damore views these as indicative of a larger problem beyond tech. In his insistence that “freedom from offense” is one of Google’s primary goals with these initiatives, he echoes a familiar line of reasoning that suggests individuals are too sensitive while at the same time claiming that the people whose opinions are being suppressed (meaning, conservatives) are actually the ones experiencing harm. In a somewhat contradictory perspective, Damore equates “psychological safety” with “speaking up without the fear of being harshly judged,”¹⁰⁸ seemingly unwilling or unable to understand the very real psychological toll that marginalized individuals face daily because of macro- and micro-level aggressions.

After his memo was published by Gizmodo, Damore was fired, with Google’s CEO noting, “portions of the memo violate our Code of Conduct and cross the line by advancing harmful gender stereotypes in our workplace.... To suggest a group of our colleagues have traits that make them less biologically suited to that work is offensive and not OK.... At the same time, there are co-workers who are questioning whether they can safely express their views in the

workplace (especially those with a minority viewpoint). They too feel under threat, and that is also not OK.”^{[109](#)} Thus, Google executives created a false equivalence between the harms that someone might face for being a conservative at the company with those faced for being a BIPOC woman. Damore sued Google in 2018 on the grounds that he was punished for being a conservative White man.^{[110](#)} Both parties agreed to have the case dismissed in 2020.^{[111](#)}

James Damore is a paradigmatic example of toxic geek masculinity. Unfortunately, his opinions about women and BIPOC are not uncommon within Silicon Valley, despite the suggestion that it is a leftist paradise. Like others within the intellectual dark web proper, Damore sees himself as unfairly victimized by liberals and social justice warriors. But contrary to narratives complaining that those who have been “cancelled” are unable to make a living or access a platform to share their views, Damore found himself feted by libertarian, conservative, and alt-right media. He appeared on IDW-affiliated podcasts like *The Joe Rogan Experience* and was interviewed by Jordan Peterson, who told him to “stick to your damn guns” after hearing about his experience at Google.^{[112](#)} He also appeared on White nationalist Stefan Molyneux’s YouTube channel before Molyneux was deplatformed because he violated their policy against hate speech.^{[113](#)} A profile in *The Guardian* suggests that Damore regretted some of the wording he used in the memo. He asserted that he was a centrist/libertarian but not a White supremacist or alt-right sympathizer and that he was challenged by “understanding how his words will be interpreted by other people.”^{[114](#)} As of this writing, he had launched a Red Bubble site (that allows you to create custom t-shirts and accessories) with the slogan “The Future Is Phallic.”^{[115](#)} According to his LinkedIn profile, he’s been a software engineer at a startup since June 2018.

GAMING FREE SPEECH

Damore’s memo, which repurposed the messaging used by the intellectual dark web, represents a further development of the game being played by the far right. While #Gamergate activists were

mostly content using social media to assert their identity and to attack those they saw as threatening it, the intellectual dark web (and Damore) used it to argue for a consequence-free form of free speech. When Damore was eventually fired for violating Google's code of conduct, he (and those who came to his defense) saw this firing as the pinnacle of hypocrisy—proof that Silicon Valley had capitulated to the “woke” mob.¹¹⁶ They ignored the fact that Damore's memo relied on poor reasoning and bad science. Like Joe Rogan's podcast, the point was that Damore should be provided a platform to speak his mind, regardless of how odious his views were, without any meaningful resistance.

As critic Adrian Daub suggests in his examination of Silicon Valley's intellectual culture, there's a significant amount of performativity in Damore's memo.¹¹⁷ What did he think would happen after its release? Did he think it would change the hiring practices at Google? Or was his goal something else entirely? Daub argues that Damore on some level must have known that his screed would not remain within the confines of Google.¹¹⁸ I tend to agree. It appears that one goal (perhaps the only goal) was to make fringe ideas more mainstream, thus shifting the Overton window.¹¹⁹ As with #Gamergate and the intellectual dark web, Damore's memo meant that tech insiders, the press, and the public would have to wrestle with the ideas he offered—especially when it came to the notion of gendered bodies and brains. You could almost say he was effectively gaming the media.

Damore's logic replicates a problem commonly seen in tech circles—technological solutionism. This is the assumption that technologists can solve any problem more efficiently than other experts even when it's outside of their domain.¹²⁰ And when the solution is questioned or rejected by others, the tech bro suggests the public is too “stupid” to understand what he's trying to do. In Damore's mind, his lack of experience in diversity, equity, and inclusion issues and in the complex structural limitations encountered by women and BIPOC in tech is seen as an asset rather than a liability. And using this line of reasoning, he and others championing his ideas argue that any resistance to his suggestions is

more about the unwillingness of Google and the left to have a conversation about diversity and less about what it really is—a perception that Damore isn’t offering anything of real value because he’s not actually well informed about the issues at play.^{[121](#)} However, who is considered an expert and who isn’t depends largely on the social location and body they inhabit. Adria Richards’s experience (and one could even say expertise) of being a Black woman in a tech space dominated by mostly White men is minimized and discounted. Despite having years of experience being a Black woman in tech, Richards is shamed and told she shouldn’t be offended and doesn’t belong. This outright rejection of expertise has become increasingly a part of right-wing politics, especially in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic.^{[122](#)}

I would further argue that Damore approached the problem of diversity in tech as a gamer would. His line of reasoning, with its dependence on meritocratic explanations for success in tech, echoes the narrative replicated in many video games (as discussed in chapter 2). He was helpfully pointing out a flaw in the game’s design, suggesting that the real victims of diversity initiatives at Google (and elsewhere) were White men. Using Damore’s logic, Richards’s complaints about the developers at PyCon whose actions made it uncomfortable for her to participate in that space would likely be seen as a form of cheating. She was insisting that the culture of tech (one that Damore and many others view as embedded in White/Asian geek masculinity) should recognize her presence and personhood. Using Damore’s worldview, she was asking for an unfair advantage in a game she was simply not designed to win (because she is a woman and a Black woman at that). And, as with current debates around cancel culture, the suggestion here is that the real person harmed by the “calling out labor” (per Lisa Nakamura) is the White man.^{[123](#)} BIPOC women are expected to see jokes about dongles and forking as just the price of entry into tech-centric spaces.

BODIES MATTER—SOME MORE THAN OTHERS

These are two software developers who had two vastly different experiences. Counter to cyberlibertarian myths, bodies do matter—and they matter a lot. In centering the experiences of privileged White men, tech companies perpetuate inequality in their internal culture and in the design choices made on their platforms. The harassment of Adria Richards, like the harassment of those targeted by #Gamergate activists mentioned in chapter 2, demonstrates that social media platforms prize publicness over safety, especially when it comes to marginalized individuals. It also underscores the importance of how intersectional identities come to matter in how shaming and harassment are experienced. Unlike James Damore, Richards has largely left social media altogether. Her last public tweet is from 2016, and her blog is no longer accessible. Although she still works in tech (according to her LinkedIn bio),¹²⁴ she is primarily known for #Donglegate, which is the first result that returns when her name is googled. Her actions questioned an unspoken rule within tech culture: cishet White and Asian men are central to these spaces. Others, like Richards, are expected to be silent about the microaggressions they face daily and about the larger structural inequalities that lead their presence in Silicon Valley and other geek communities to be viewed as an anomaly.

The Richards case also demonstrates how embedded the fantasies of meritocracy are in Silicon Valley and geek culture writ large—and why these kinds of explanations for success in STEM or interest in gaming remain largely wanting. Structural reasons for the relative paucity of, for example, Black women in start-ups are ignored in favor of individualistic explanations that either serve as roundabout victim blaming or ignore the ways geek culture is often hostile to those deemed as not belonging. Equating tech culture with White and Asian maleness both limits entry and creates a culture that normalizes that limitation. It makes unseen an entire set of cultural assumptions about the nature of work and play within these spaces, making them visible only when challenged by the presence of individuals deemed deviant. Clinging to meritocracy is especially

pernicious and problematic as it's been shown to provide a false sense of equality in these spaces. But experimental research has demonstrated that managers working within meritocratic organizations (like those in tech) will monetarily reward men more over similarly qualified women, suggesting that any pretense of fairness within these organizations is a myth.¹²⁵

At the same time, as is discussed above, geeks in privileged positions often view themselves as oppressed minorities. Both a sense of persecution and a valorization of free-speech absolutism are shared with denizens of the intellectual dark web, the manosphere, the alt-right, and, increasingly, mainstream conservatism. In the next chapter, I trace the evolution of the kind of geek masculinity exemplified by James Damore and the intellectual dark web to the more explicitly political and toxic example represented by Reddit's r/The_Donald community. I argue that the politics of Reddit works to disguise alt-right discourse as a form of play. I outline some of the ways the dark play of the r/The_Donald subreddit engages with gaming and geek culture and normalizes toxicity. Ultimately, I argue that r/The_Donald represented a move by the right to game politics through humor and play.

NOTES

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7. Winner, "Cyberlibertarian Myths and the Prospects for Community."
8. But in *Star Trek*, money and capital are also eliminated, which is antithetical to cyberlibertarianism.
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- [26.](#) Gillespie, "The Politics of 'Platforms.'"
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See

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98. Damore, "Google's Ideological Echo Chamber," 7.

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101. Damore, "Google's Ideological Echo Chamber," 9.

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106. For a comprehensive rebuttal of this kind of thinking, see Gina Rippon, *Gender and Our Brains: How New Neuroscience Explodes the Myths of the Male and Female Minds* (New York: Pantheon, 2019).

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29, 2023, <https://nymag.com/intelligencer/2017/08/who-is-james-damore-fired-googler-talks-to-stefan-molyneux.html>.

114. Paul Lewis, "I See Things Differently': James Damore on His Autism and the Google Memo," *The Guardian*, November 17, 2017, accessed March 12, 2024, <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2017/nov/16/james-damore-google-memo-interview-autism-regrets>.

115. On Twitter, Damore confirmed that his slogan "The future is phallic" was a direct response to the popular feminist slogan "The future is female." His original tweet at <https://twitter.com/JamesADamore/status/1537094575579332615> has since been deleted. Thanks to my American University colleague Aram Sinnreich for pointing out this whole awful mess to me.

116. Lewis, "I See Things Differently."

117. Adrian Daub, *What Tech Calls Thinking: An Inquiry into the Intellectual Bedrock of Silicon Valley* (New York: FSG Originals, 2020).

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119. The Overton window originally described shifts in viable political policies, but now is also used to describe political discourse and ideas. The implication is that when the Overton window shifts, previously distasteful or politically untenable ideas can become mainstream policy proposals or discourse. An example might be how progressive economic policies, like single-payer healthcare or universal basic income, which were mostly non-starters within the Democratic party prior to the 2000s, became fundamental to the platform of Senator Bernie Sanders's 2016 presidential campaign and Andrew Yang's 2020 presidential campaign, respectively. Maggie Astor, "How the Politically Unthinkable Can Become Mainstream," *New York Times*, February 26, 2019, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.nytimes.com/2019/02/26/us/politics/overton-window-democrats.html>.

120. Evgeny Morozov, *To Save Everything, Click Here: The Folly of Technological Solutionism* (New York: PublicAffairs, 2013).

121. I'm reminded here of (again) Elon Musk's offer to build a submarine to rescue children trapped in a flooded cave in Thailand. When told his sub wasn't needed, he threw a fit on Twitter and baselessly called the rescue operation leader a pedophile. Sam Levin, "Elon Musk Calls British Diver in Thai Cave Rescue 'Pedo' in Baseless Attack," *The Guardian*, July 16, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2018/jul/15/elon-musk-british-diver-thai-cave-rescue-pedo-twitter>.

122. For more on the public's suspicion of expertise (even before the COVID-19 pandemic), see Tom Nichols, *The Death of Expertise: The Campaign against Established Knowledge and Why It Matters* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2017).

123. Nakamura, "The Unwanted Labour of Social Media."

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4

REDDIT'S LOVE AFFAIR WITH R/THE_DONALD¹

The first episode of Ryan Murphy's 2017 TV show, *American Horror Story: Cult*, opens with a montage of video footage from the 2016 US presidential election.² After a title card noting the date, November 8, 2016, the first scene shows people watching TV as the election returns are announced. The scene cuts between showing a White, middle-aged lesbian couple sitting with friends in a light-filled, cheery living room and a young White man with blue hair sitting alone in a dark basement. As the results indicate that Hillary Clinton will likely lose to Donald Trump, the people in the living room become increasingly panicked as they realize what is happening, while the young man in the basement grows increasingly excited, screaming "USA! USA! USA!," laughing maniacally, jumping around the room, and eventually humping the TV screen with glee. While Murphy is not known for his visual restraint (having also helmed shows like *Nip/Tuck* and *Glee*, which are about as bubblegum and salacious as one can get) this scene is uniquely effective as visual synecdoche, as the analogy to online spaces is clear. The women in this scene embody the ethos of the Facebook group Pantsuit Nation, which supported Hilary Clinton, and its brand of White feminism—liberal (but not too liberal), middle-class and middle-aged, able-bodied, and superficially "woke."³ The young man embodies 4chan's

/pol/ (politically incorrect) imageboard—chaotic, young, nihilistic, depraved, and angry.

In other words, social media platforms have personalities, and they are dependent on the communities they attract, which, in turn, is a function of their design and platform politics. A popular meme uses characters from the 1985 movie *The Breakfast Club* as a way to express these differences: the uptight “it” girl Claire (Molly Ringwald) is labeled Twitter (or Instagram in some versions), the goth basketcase Allison (Ally Sheedy) is called Tumblr (or Deviant Art), and the nerd Brian (Anthony Michael Hall) is marked Reddit ([figure 4.1](#)).⁴



4.1 Five characters from the 1985 movie *The Breakfast Club* labeled as social media platforms.

As is argued in chapter 2, Reddit is one of a handful of platforms that make up the alternative web. Despite being popular in the US, the site has retained an ethos that sets it apart from mainstream

social media platforms like Facebook and TikTok. It is a hub for niche interests that embody a kind of geek masculinity (discussed in chapter 3) that is in no small part enabled by pseudonymity and play.

Reddit trades in transgressive, carnivalesque humor. Some have suggested that it serves as a site for civic engagement and participatory journalism.⁵ However, it has also gained attention for the racist, misogynistic, Islamophobic, anti-Semitic, and trans-/homophobic content that circulates with impunity in many of its communities (subreddits).⁶ The platform has played a critical and yet relatively unexamined role in mainstreaming far-right ideology in the US. In this chapter, I examine one subreddit, r/The_Donald, which until its demise in June 2020 was a popular community for supporters of Donald Trump. I'm particularly interested in the role it played in normalizing discourse associated with the alt-right (AR). I use the concept of dark play to understand how this subreddit created a sense of community and normalized far-right talking points globally.

In Richard Schechner's formulation, dark play subverts the play frame, blurring the lines between play and not-play.⁷ In alt-right communities like Reddit's r/The_Donald or 4chan's /pol/ board, dark play takes many forms, including subtle dog whistles in humorous memes, trolling, and outright harassment and intimidation. Through an examination of the subreddit's most popular postings and discussions, my research reveals the discursive tactics and approaches used to build community among subscribers, spread disinformation, and foment dissent more broadly. It also provides important insights into the complexities of how a space like r/The_Donald (TD) operates in relationship to the larger Reddit ecosystem and how platform administrators are complicit in mainstreaming its message.

DARK PLAY AND MEMETIC AMBIVALENCE ON REDDIT

There are a number of reasons why approaching r/The_Donald from the perspective of dark play is useful. First, this approach mirrors

work that suggests politics is often framed as a game or horserace by pundits and the media. Second, academic critics have noted the increasing tendency for journalists to use tropes drawn from reality television to frame election news—highlighting dramatic events and emotional appeals rather than simply covering policy differences.⁸ Finally, the way Trump frames political opponents as losers invokes the narrative of politics as a game and suggests the increasingly gamified nature of everyday life. Therefore, understanding the ways in which spaces like TD engage in games and play for more antisocial tendencies is critical.

Game and play studies often take as a starting point Johan Huizinga's 1938 text *Homo Ludens: A Study of the Play Element in Culture*. Huizinga argues that play is an integral part of human culture that is somehow set aside from ordinary life and governed by its own set of rules.⁹ Play is contradictory—simultaneously “not serious” and yet utterly absorbing. Roger Caillois later builds on Huizinga's formulation, offering a definition of play and a comprehensive typology of games. Caillois argues that play consists of six elements: it is free (that is, not required), separate, uncertain, unproductive (separate from labor), governed by rules, and make-believe.¹⁰ However, the views of both Huizinga and Caillois on play and games are limited and suggest that a clear distinction can be drawn between play and labor. Many works—including Shira Chess's study of domestic labor in casual mobile games, Julian Dibbell's discussion of virtual gold farming, Brooke Erin Duffy's examination of Instagram influencers, and T. L. Taylor's analysis of e-sports competitions—highlight the increasingly blurred lines between work and play in the digital economy.¹¹ And, as mentioned in chapter 3, tech companies have become strong proponents of the work-as-play mentality. Games researcher Aaron Trammell argues that equating play only with “fun” or as not embedded in systems that can cause harm is problematic—a point that is underscored by r/The_Donald.¹²

Other scholars from a variety of disciplines have argued for understanding the importance of play in everyday life. For performance theorist Richard Schechner, play dissolves hierarchies, with objects taking on new meaning.¹³ Having a specialized space

and time allows players to engage in the liminality of relaxation and anxiety, rules and free-flowing activity. Education scholar Brian Sutton-Smith argues that play is an inherently ambiguous, difficult-to-define activity that nonetheless can be understood as quirky, redundant, flexible, and highly variable.¹⁴ Anthropologist Clifford Geertz's influential treatise on Balinese cockfighting highlights the often ritualistic and culturally resonant nature of some forms of play (which he terms "deep play").¹⁵ And biologists Patrick Bateson and Paul Martin draw a distinction between play and playfulness—the former being an observable behavior and the latter being a positive attitude toward the activity.¹⁶ They suggest that these elements often overlap but that aspects of play (like competition and aggressiveness) are not playful. Similarly, game scholar Miguel Sicart argues that play embraces both Apollonian and Dionysian elements—order and chaos, pleasure and pain.¹⁷

So *play* itself remains a contested term. For the purposes of this chapter, I am interested in a particular form of play—what Richard Schechner terms "dark play."¹⁸ Despite its potential usefulness for understanding all kinds of rituals, performances, and collective action, dark play remains relatively undertheorized.¹⁹ As Schechner writes,

Dark play may be conscious playing, but it can also be playing in the dark, when some or even all of the players don't know they are playing. Dark play occurs when contradictory realities coexist, each seemingly capable of cancelling the other out, as in the double cross.... Dark play subverts order, dissolves frames, breaks its own rules, so that the playing itself is in danger of being destroyed, as in spying, con games, undercover actions, and double agency. Unlike the inversions of carnivals, ritual clowns, and so on (whose agendas are public) dark play's inversions are not declared or resolved; its end is not integration but disruption, deceit, excess, and gratification.²⁰

To repurpose Schechner's phrase, dark play creates a space of "not play" and "not not play," as one or all of the players may be unaware that a game is being played or that the space has been delineated for play. Still, play (and playful activity) always creates rules, both structuring what instead would be complete chaos but also making it

potentially a fun activity.²¹ In dark play, however, the rules are not just mutable but unstated and contradictory.

A way an event is understood or framed provides a critical backdrop to understanding dark play. In his classic text *Frame Analysis: An Essay on the Organization of Experience*, sociologist Erving Goffman argues that the conventions and rules surrounding particular social events (frames) transform them from one recognizable experience to another.²² Drawing on anthropologist Gregory Bateson's work, Goffman notes that play between polecats often takes the shape of fighting, in that the two activities involve the same actions (baring teeth, growling, nipping at the opponent), but that play is "keyed" in such a way to demonstrate that this is not a real fight: it is merely play. This keying is telegraphed between the polecats so that a bite is not a bite in the way it would be during a fight. Still, outsiders watching the events unfold who do not understand the key (unstated rules) of this particular performance can easily mistake their play for a fight. Goffman suggests that keying is but one way frames are vulnerable. Fabrications (especially relevant when considering dark play) are another. Noting that cultures regularly engage in "playful deceit," Goffman argues that there is an important distinction between benign and exploitative fabrications.²³ Benign fabrications include harmless, short-term play like kidding or leg-pulling. Still, even benign play has its own complexity. The bite is not a bite, the joke is not a joke, but unlike Schechner's dark play, these fabrications have a beginning and an end, and the target is eventually brought in on the joke.

Part of what makes dark play so engaging and potentially dangerous is the relative inability for players (and spectators) to determine if a game is actually being played. Richard Schechner suggests that an individual within the frame of dark play "plays out alternative selves ... actions become play retroactively: the events are what they are, but by telling these events, by reperforming them as narratives, they are cast as play."²⁴ Thus, there is a thrill in the retelling of the events *as play*, whether or not they were experienced as such. As Bateson argues, much like dreamers who don't realize they are asleep, within the play frame individuals may not even

realize they are playing.²⁵ In Schnecher's formulation, "the reaction of the nonplayers is a big part of what gives dark play its kick."²⁶ Therefore, a critical aspect of dark play is the audience's participation or, rather, nonparticipation as players who do not understand the keying of a particular frame that might signal "This is a game." Dark play is both thrilling and dangerous because of this duality.

Online spaces are ripe for new and effective forms of dark play through things like memes, which remain impenetrable to outsiders while being easily decoded by those inside these communities. As Whitney Phillips and Ryan M. Milner argue, the internet trades in a kind of "ambivalence" that is inherently polysemic and dialectical.²⁷ In other words, online cultures play with the multiple interpretations that a person can draw from a given text. The dark play of the alt-right takes advantage of this ambivalence to spread far-right ideology while simultaneously disavowing it as mere play or trolling. Reddit has become a welcoming space for this kind of dual play, as a carnivalesque, irreverent spirit characterizes many of the larger subreddits. But the carnivalesque is far more direct than dark play is about the end goal of the play act. The carnival is about upending hierarchies and reveling in the "grotesque body," but it is also sanctioned by those in power—who presumably will remain in power after the carnival is over.²⁸ And however chaotic the carnival appears, it requires the consent (however implicit) of both the performers and spectators. Dark play, on the other hand, is often duplicitous and conniving. Players may be unaware they are playing, spectators may not understand the rules that govern play or realize that the rules are mutable or capricious, and a return to stasis where those in power stay in power is not guaranteed.

Online spaces work to enable dark play in two ways. First, these spaces amplify and render more salient popular content through algorithms. This is particularly true on Reddit, where a system of upvoting and downvoting content suggests a kind of democratic approach to discourse while still being easily manipulated by loose, leaderless publics (as represented by the #Gamergate harassment campaign discussed in chapter 2). Second, the technological

affordances of these spaces may encourage people to participate in dark play as a way to both differentiate themselves and be a part of the community.²⁹ For example, both Reddit and 4chan afford members the ability to play with their identity through anonymity. Anonymity is a key aspect of what makes dark play so appealing—and why it might be so prevalent in these spaces. As Schechner argues, “masking is very important—sneaking off, not being recognized, playing out selves that cannot be displayed at work, or with family. The thrill and gratification of such play is to perform anonymously, in disguise, or in a closet what one cannot do publicly ‘as myself.’”³⁰ Social psychologists have long argued that anonymous platforms may make individuals more likely to disclose aspects of their personality that they might otherwise not.³¹ While Reddit is not fully anonymous, it provides individuals ample opportunities to engage identity play.³² Redditors can thus differentiate themselves from others on the platform where visibility is prized but difficult to acquire. The pseudonymous nature of Reddit creates the potential for play to occur in more subtle ways, through unique usernames that invoke popular culture or puns or make crude jokes and through novelty accounts that exist solely to perform play in particular ways.³³

A BRIEF HISTORY OF R/THE_DONALD’S VIRTUAL PROPAGANDA RALLY

The r/The_Donald (TD) subreddit community represented both a virtual rally and a gathering space for dark play in multiple ways. Created in June 2015 (and banned in 2020), the subreddit grew quickly and became one of the most popular online public forums for Trump supporters. The actual connection between the Trump presidential campaign (and later administration) and r/The_Donald remained murky throughout its tenure on Reddit. Brad Parscale, Donald Trump’s digital media director and later campaign manager for his failed 2020 campaign, tweeted that he visited the subreddit daily.³⁴ But no official connection between the campaign and the subreddit was ever acknowledged.

Pew polling data suggests that many Redditors originally supported primary candidate Bernie Sanders during the 2016 US presidential campaign, but by late 2016, subscribers for r/SandersForPresident were outpaced significantly by TD subscribers (with both subreddits having far more subscribers than r/HillaryClinton).³⁵ Even after TD's quarantine (more on this in a bit), it was still wildly popular compared to other political subreddits on the platform, having around 784,000 subscribers in January 2020.³⁶ Perhaps not surprisingly given its namesake's political style, research suggests that incivility and negative partisanship on TD were particularly high during the election cycle.³⁷ This behavior spilled over to other spaces on Reddit as well.

Unlike other political and candidate subreddits on the platform (such as r/Conservative, r/Democrats, r/Libertarian, r/SandersForPresident, and r/YangForPresHQ), TD featured far more memes than actual news and a *lingua franca* almost impenetrable to outsiders.³⁸ And unlike other political subreddits, which welcomed questions from outsiders, TD was explicitly for supporters only. Moderators regularly banned individuals for disagreeing with Trump's views or even asking for a clarification about his administration's policies. The subreddit's lack of interest in meaningful debate contrasts with the claims by Trump supporters that public spaces and college campuses were overrun with social justice warriors and "snowflakes" who could not tolerate having their ideas challenged.

The r/The_Donald subreddit was extremely effective in pushing far-right ideas and racist speech through memetic content and violent discourse. Researchers have argued that while 4chan's /pol/ (politically incorrect) board creates an outsized number of memes given its size, TD was actually more efficient in spreading them to other spaces online.³⁹ By 2018, TD's denizens had also broken most if not all of Reddit's sitewide rules. Subscribers brigaded other subreddits, doxed journalists, and called for violence against individuals who advocated for gun control after the mass shootings at the Marjory Stoneman Douglas High School in Parkland, Florida.⁴⁰ In a posting discussing how the platform could combat Russian state-supported propaganda following the 2016 US election, Reddit

CEO Steve Huffman was asked about TD's role in disseminating it and why TD remained on the platform.⁴¹ Instead of taking clear action against the subreddit, he suggested that Reddit administrators hoped TD would collapse due to its own "dysfunction" and waning subscriber base.⁴² Redditors pushed Huffman on this point, arguing that the toxicity and problematic discourse of TD impacted other communities on and off the platform. Several observers at the time also suggested that the real reason TD and other troubling (but popular) subreddits were not banned was because the company generated significant revenue from them.⁴³

For a subreddit of its size, r/The_Donald had a tremendous turnover of its moderation team.⁴⁴ TD often used moderation positions as a reward for alt-right celebrities rather than as a critical tool for keeping the subreddit free of spam or hate speech. For example, then-Breitbart News editor (and #Gamergate supporter) Milo Yiannapolous was placed in a moderator position after his Ask Me Anything (AMA) session⁴⁵ on TD, despite having no experience in moderating a Reddit community.⁴⁶ Perhaps as a result, the subreddit's relationship with Reddit remained fraught throughout its tenure. In May 2017, two top moderators were removed by Reddit administrators. Later that year, several other moderators resigned, and the subreddit went temporarily private in protest.⁴⁷

Below I provide some examples of how r/The_Donald recast Trump supporters as fans and engaged in various forms of dark play. One important note: bots are prevalent on Reddit,⁴⁸ and much of TD's content, traffic, and voting behavior likely represented the behavior of fewer actual *human* Trump supporters than subscriber numbers suggest. However, my analysis is centered not on whether the discourse of the subreddit represented solely human actors but on the ways in which both humans and bots came together in a spirit of dark play. Bruno Latour's actor-network theory suggests that nonhuman actors (actants) like bots can be powerful forces that shape our relationship to technology and, in effect, work to co-create our experiences online.⁴⁹ The acceptance of bots, click farms, and other nonhuman agents in the space merely reinforced a particular subject position—supporters as fans.⁵⁰

R/THE_DONALD AS FANDOM COMMUNITY⁵¹

While all modern political campaigns have had elements of spectacle and tribalism, Trump's 2016 campaign and presidency and his 2020 and 2024 campaigns have been marked by an extreme form of both. Recasting support for Donald Trump through the lens of fandom becomes a critical way in which dark play occurred on the r/The_Donald subreddit. It also mirrored how Trump was received by supporters at rallies and events.

As discussed in chapter 3, fandom is often associated with popular cultural products, such as games, movies, comic books, and bands, and scholars have noted the potential for communities to create new forms of participatory culture where the lines between producer and fan are increasingly blurred.⁵² Fans often view the fandom object as offering an organizing principle for their lives—as becoming a core part of their identity.⁵³ Therefore, fans are productive in that they create new forms of culture based on or inspired by the fandom object.⁵⁴ Fandom theorists have tended to emphasize the democratic, liberatory potential of fandom and the possibility it offers for political activism around social issues.⁵⁵ However, events like #Gamergate (as discussed in chapter 2) have also demonstrated that fan communities are often divisive, exclusionary, and toxic.⁵⁶

Enter Donald Trump—as not simply a political candidate but a transmedia phenomenon.⁵⁷ Perhaps this shift should not have surprised us, as Trump had been a fixture in US popular culture from the 1980s onward. In particular, his role as a media gadfly and ostentatious brand ambassador and his substantial presence on reality television and on social media suggested his campaign would be unusual. But the media coverage of Trump and the mobilization of supporters on spaces like the r/The_Donald subreddit and 4chan's /pol/ (politically incorrect) board worked in tandem to remake Trump as a fandom object rather than simply as a political candidate. Trump as candidate implicitly understood and was motivated by the idea of the fan (he repeatedly used the term *fan* throughout the campaign, especially when referring to “My biggest fans”) and

created catchphrases (like Make America Great Again or MAGA) that were memorable and potent. In turn, his supporters (particularly those from 4chan and Reddit), anointed him their “God Emperor”—a larger-than-life figure that was part relatable everyman and part untouchable superhero. Their productivity was enormous. They repurposed content like Pepe the Frog, forever associated it with their cause, created a new lexicon (“cucks,” “pedes,” “SJWs”), and flooded social media with memes in support of Trump. Not all Trump supporters were creating and sharing memes or inhabiting the more marginal spaces of the alternative web discussed in chapter 2. As with all fandom communities, only a small subset actually engages in textual productivity.⁵⁸ Still, a narrative solidified that suggested that the left (as represented by the campaign of Hillary Clinton) “couldn’t meme.”⁵⁹ While initially perpetuated by the denizens of 4chan’s /pol/ board, this eventually became a common refrain in media postmortems of the election that sought to understand how predictions for Clinton’s win could have been wrong.

Fandoms cultivate affective relationships, drawing people toward one another through emotional connections to the fandom object. Affect scholar Sara Ahmed notes that “emotions circulate between bodies and signs,” creating powerful connective tissue by which communities are sustained (or torn apart).⁶⁰ In the case of the Trump fan community, the emotions are often anxiety, fear, anger (directed at immigrants, women, liberals, academics, and BIPOC), and nostalgia for an imagined past that never existed. Much like Ahmed’s examination of White nationalist propaganda, Trump fandom operates an “economy of hate,” wherein emotions become a kind of capital that circulates between individuals and signs. As she argues, “figures of hate circulate, and indeed accumulate affective value, precisely because they do not have a fixed referent.”⁶¹ Emotions in these economies are powerful, attaching bodies together in the hatred of the other, but this other is mutable and easily transferable. Using this logic, every immigrant might be a criminal, and every liberal is a possible baby killer. These imaginaries become a kind of currency that was invoked by Trump during his

candidacy and presidency and circulated within the disparate groups that fall under the rubric of the alt-right.

This affective economy was mirrored in the fandom community of r/The_Donald. The subreddit's community description warned possible casual visitors that it was "for serious supporters" of Trump:

Welcome to the forum of choice for The President of The United States, Donald Trump!

Be advised this forum is for serious supporters of President Trump. We have discussions, memes, AMAs, and more. We are not politically correct. Please read and respect our rules below *before* contributing.

In addition to mirroring Trump's own rather odd capitalization style, the community description implied that there was a difference between mere supporters and "serious" supporters—the former perhaps being more likely to question other participants or even challenge Trump's policies. Noting that the subreddit was not "politically correct" reinforced an increasingly common opinion among conservatives (in particular) that liberals are too easily offended by particular language choices.⁶² Rules listed on the subreddit's sidebar again reinforced the community's purpose as a space for "serious supporters," noting, "This forum is for Trump supporters only. If you have questions about our president, our way of thinking or other discussion questions, post on r/AskThe_Donald, where we will gladly answer. This forum is NOT for that" ([figure 4.2](#)). This suggested that any disagreements that might happen between "serious supporters" were not ideological ones. The subreddit instead served as a simulation of one of Trump's rallies. Dissent was nonexistent. Those who were not true believers were booted.

R/THE_DONALD RULES

1. Violates Site-wide Content Policy ^

Do not violate Reddit's site-wide content policy. You will be banned. [Reddit's policy can be seen here](#)

2. No Trolling or Concern Trolling ^

No type of trolling will be tolerated on The_Donald. [What is concern trolling?](#)

3. No Racism and Anti-Semitism ^

Racism and Anti-Semitism will not be tolerated. You have been warned.

4. No Releasing Personal Information / Doxxing ^

Releasing, linking or requesting personal information is not allowed. (This includes surveys, polls & petitions)

5. No merchandise or fundraising promotion ^

Linking or promoting merchandise, fundraising or donations is not permitted. [DonaldJTrump.com](#) links are allowed.

6. Trump Supporters Only. No Cucks or Leftists. ^

This forum is for Trump supporters only. If you have questions about our president, our way of thinking or other discussion questions, post on [r/AskThe_Donald](#), where we will gladly answer. This forum is NOT for that.

[4.2](#) A portion of the rules for the r/The_Donald subreddit.

During the 2016 election cycle, this rule against dissent was even more plainly articulated, with the sidebar at various times stating “No BernieBots or SJWs” and “No Dissenters or SJWs.”^{[63](#)} This reluctance of r/The_Donald to consider alternative opinions about Trump contrasted with several other Reddit communities dedicated to the political figure. For example, the much smaller r/DonaldTrump, dedicated to his 2020 reelection campaign, included a pinned note telling visitors that submissions could be posted only by moderator-approved supporters of Trump but that anyone could comment on posts.^{[64](#)} The slightly larger r/Donald_Trump (around 8,500 subscribers) featured an automatic reminder on every posting reminding visitors to remain civil in their disagreements, noting, “We do encourage rational debate from all perspectives, but do not condone in hostilities or the airing of grievances, and request that all participants remain civil at all times.”^{[65](#)} And r/Trump (which at 28,000 subscribers was the largest of the three) noted on its rules wiki page that “This is a pro-Trump subreddit. Do not post here explicitly or implicitly [sic] to slander President Donald Trump. We encourage rational debate from all perspectives, so long as it is based on evidence and presented in ethical discussion.” A cursory view of these much less popular subreddits suggested they featured far more links to news stories and campaign information about the then-president and far fewer memes than r/The_Donald did. And their design also suggested a more traditional approach to campaigning than TD’s. They were outfitted in red, white, and blue and featured formal press photos of the president (and his wife) rather than angry stills taken from rallies or smug images of Trump that had been repurposed into memes. In other words, these subreddits encouraged a more nuanced view of Trump that might allow one to be a supporter without necessarily agreeing with all of his viewpoints or policies.^{[66](#)}

Recasting Trump supporters as fans was a critical aspect of the r/The_Donald’s dark play. By creating a simulated rally, moderators

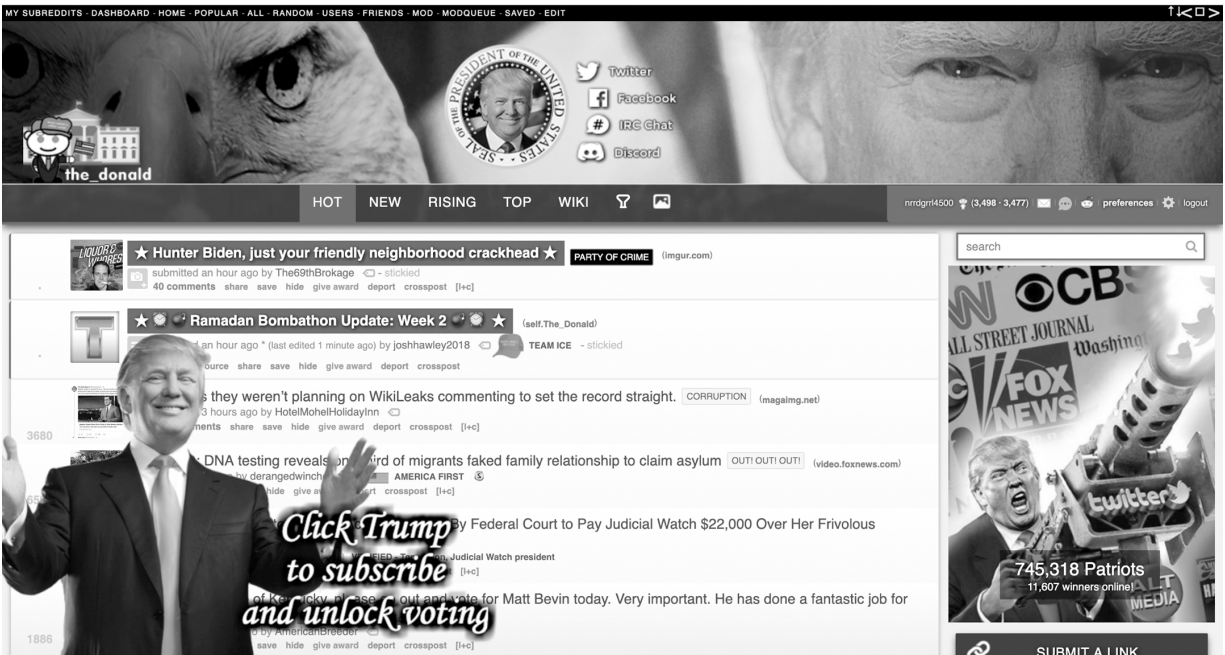
and participants were able to distance themselves from the violent realities entailed in being a Trump fan. The Unite the Right rally in Charlottesville (which led to the death of activist Heather Heyer and injured many others) repeated calls for violent action, and conspiracy theories like QAnon were remade so that they were acceptable aspects of Trump fandom.⁶⁷ Contrary to other fandom communities, where fans “talk back” to the objects of their fandom and often have conflicts and disagreements among themselves, TD’s fan base was unified and compliant.⁶⁸ In other words, it mirrored the authoritarian leanings of Trump himself. The “God Emperor” requires sycophants, and r/The_Donald provided them.

REINFORCING DARK PLAY THROUGH DESIGN

The moderators at r/The_Donald made small but meaningful changes to Reddit’s default design. These could be considered examples of *dark design patterns*, the term that design critics use for design choices that work to obscure their real intention and undermine user autonomy. The phrase borrows from Christopher Alexander’s foundational architecture text, which outlines a kind of pattern language for buildings (ones that presumably improve our experiences of the built environment).⁶⁹ The most notorious examples of dark design patterns are discussed in Natasha Dow Schüll’s *Addiction by Design: Machine Gambling in Las Vegas*, which details the ways in which the built environment of Las Vegas casinos and video poker machines works to keep players in the “zone,” simultaneously enabling addictive behaviors.⁷⁰ Loot boxes that offer in-game upgrades for real-world money are another example.⁷¹ Web interfaces, in particular, are riddled with these ethically questionable designs. During the last step of checkout, for example, hidden costs are often added to a product during *confirmshaming*, where the buyer is pushed into subscribing to a newsletter or purchasing an add-on with a shaming message (like “No thanks. I don’t want 10% off my next purchase”) if the offer isn’t accepted.⁷² By obscuring users’ ability to see material that might be controversial in the universe of r/The_Donald, the moderators subtly but effectively

foreclosed the idea that any differences of opinion exist when it came to Trump or his policies.

Prior to its quarantine, r/The_Donald featured a robust subreddit desktop style that disciplined visitors and reinforced community norms for subscribers through its design.⁷³ First, the design featured a picture of Trump with a note that visitors must subscribe before voting would be enabled. By default, subreddits show both upvote and downvote buttons, with upvotes increasing the visibility of a given post or comment, regardless of whether an individual is a subscriber. Subreddit postings often appear in spaces where nonsubscribers can see and vote on them, such as on r/Popular (which features the most popular postings across subreddits and filters out NSFW postings and postings from a selected set of subreddits). Subreddits like r/Politics also state that visitors need to subscribe before they can vote on material (and they eliminate the upvote and downvote buttons, presumably to restrict individuals from mass downvoting material). The medium shot image of Trump on the subreddit's homepage was large and obscured much of the subreddit's content ([figure 4.3](#)). It featured Trump with his hands raised as if welcoming the crowd at one of his rallies. His eyes are squinting, and his teeth are exposed in a forced, somewhat menacing smile.



4.3 Design for the r/The_Donald subreddit under Reddit's old design. Accessed May 2019 using old.reddit.com.

Second, its moderators removed the option to sort subreddit postings by the “controversial” category (that is, postings that received about the same amount of upvotes and downvotes). Sorting by “top,” “new,” and “best” was still allowed.⁷⁴ This change reinforced a particular view of the subreddit that downplayed potential discord and suggested that the community was unified around Trump as fandom object.⁷⁵ Somewhat surprisingly, r/The_Donald did not alter the upvote and downvote arrows as other subreddits have. For example, r/Politics has at times made its downvote arrow slightly smaller than its upvote arrow (presumably to encourage individuals to consider their decision to downvote material they disagree with). And in keeping with a subreddit dedicated to critiquing Reddit’s problematic discourse, r/ShitRedditSays has at times removed the upvote function entirely so that individuals could only downvote material.⁷⁶ By retaining the default Reddit voting options, TD implied that subscribers could disagree with material posted by others on the subreddit by downvoting. But given the moderators’ willingness to ban individuals

who showed any indication of not supporting Trump or his policies, the power of any downvote was effectively limited.

The r/The_Donald subreddit's use of flairs (tags that categorize similar postings) also served as a way to discipline the community ([figure 4.4](#)).⁷⁷ Flair categories are created by a subreddit's moderators, and some subreddits (like TD) allow posters to choose a flair for their submissions and even make their own edits to the flair.⁷⁸ Clicking on a given flair leads to a page with all similar postings. Some flairs on TD were descriptive in nature. For example, a flair for postings that linked to Trump's Twitter feed might be designated as "Trump Tweet." Unsurprisingly, Trump's own words featured heavily in the flair categories,⁷⁹ including "VERY FAKE NEWS," "AMERICA FIRST," "MAGA," "NASTY WOMAN," and "DRAIN THE SWAMP." Still others referred to the vernacular embraced by the alt-right, such as "PEPE" (the comic frog embraced by 4chan's /pol/ community), "NSFCucks" (a play on the abbreviation NSFW), and "GOD EMPEROR" (referring to Trump). Other flairs reinforced the notion of a perceived threat presented by their opponents—namely, the left and the press. These categories included "PARTY OF CRIME," "VIOLENT LEFT," "VERY FAKE NEWS," and "LYING MSM." Presumably, flairs that didn't fit the dominant discourse would be deleted or lead to a ban.



4.4 Examples of flairs that r/The_Donald subscribers could link to a post. In this case, the flairs are attached to a sample posting I created entitled “asdfasdf.”

Repetition of particular phrases, tropes, and memes also worked to shift the discourse on the rest of Reddit (a process that has been termed the *Overton window*).⁸⁰ In the same way that the okay hand gesture was coopted by the far right ironically and became a semiotic marker of affiliation with the movement in certain circles while simultaneously being disavowed to outsiders as a joke, the play-not-play aspect of r/The_Donald was not contained simply to this one subreddit. Not surprisingly, researchers have noted that TD subscribers also posted in the most problematic subreddits on Reddit.⁸¹ Unfortunately, for too long the platform administrators took a hands-off approach that suggested that TD existed in a self-contained vacuum of terribleness. The reality was far more complicated.

PLAY AND GAMES AS (SUB)CULTURAL CAPITAL

In the dark play of the r/The_Donald subreddit, games became not just a metaphor but an important form of cultural capital. In Pierre Bourdieu’s formulation, individuals have varying access to several forms of capital—economic (monetary), social (networks and connections to others), and cultural (the assets, including cultural literacy, that promote social mobility).⁸² Subcultures also trade in a

form of niche cultural capital meaningful for that community.⁸³ But subcultural capital might mark a person as marginal within the mainstream culture. For example, a fan of hardcore punk might demonstrate high subcultural capital (after amassing a collection of rare seven-inch vinyl records by Minor Threat and authoring a popular zine about the genre) but might have relatively low cultural capital in the mainstream (as knowledge of punk rock is considered niche or is not valued outside this particular subculture). As noted previously, video games and gaming culture are part of the Reddit's ethos and *habitus*.⁸⁴ Games also serve as an important form of subcultural capital on the platform, with some gaming subreddits being the most trafficked spaces on Reddit. In this way, r/The_Donald was no different: games served as a reference point that was expected to be understood by subscribers, and they were woven into the subreddit's discourse.

[Figure 4.5](#) shows how using games as both metaphor and cultural capital works in practice. Posted on r/The_Donald in November 2018 after Republican Texas senator Ted Cruz retained his seat after a highly contested campaign against Democratic newcomer Beto O'Rourke, the image shows a parody of the cover art for the game *Red Dead Redemption II* (created by *Grand Theft Auto* publisher Rockstar Games) with Cruz replacing the game's protagonist, Arthur Morgan. Cruz is pictured wearing a bandolier (and in a pose reminiscent of Clint Eastwood in a Sergio Leone western) and pointing a gun directly at the viewer, with a silhouette of a group of men riding on horseback in front of an improbably large setting sun.



4.5 Ted Cruz as the lead character in *Red Ted Redemption II*, a parody of the game box art for *Red Dead Redemption II* (Rockstar Games, 2018). Retrieved from r/The_Donald on November 7, 2018. Available via Wayback Machine at https://www.reddit.com/r/The_Donald/comments/9uvomw/cruz_retains_senate_seat.

In the game, Arthur Morgan is a complex outlaw figure who runs with a gang in 1899 in a fictionalized version of the western US at a time when it is changing from an untamed frontier to a “civilized” landscape. The open-world game encourages players to act out their own version of the Western power fantasy (White man as outlaw-savior), but in ways that some critics suggest also question the value of such fantasies to begin with.⁸⁵ As cultural historian Richard Slotkin argues, the myth of the frontier is a powerful political tool that crosses partisan and ideological boundaries. He writes, “the myth represent(s) the redemption of American spirit or fortune as something to be achieved by playing through a scenario of separation, temporary regression to a more primitive or ‘natural’ state, and regeneration through violence.”⁸⁶ Thus, playing with the image of Cruz as frontier outlaw reinforced a narrative in which conservatives are outlaws practicing frontier justice against a wild landscape in which their livelihood is threatened by liberal elites and the mainstream media.

At first glance, the remixed box art suggests a connection between Senator Cruz, the state of Texas, the mythic imaginary of the West, and nostalgia wrapped in a violent image of hegemonic masculinity. And yet the use of *this particular* senator in the place of protagonist Arthur Morgan remains perplexing. Cruz and Trump had an acrimonious relationship prior to the 2016 election, with both men repeatedly trading insults. It therefore is surprising to see Trump followers recasting Cruz as a hero in 2018. Also, Cruz has an awkward public image that does not embody elements of hegemonic masculinity. He is not portrayed in the media as particularly likable, virile, or physically domineering.⁸⁷ In many ways, Cruz is better understood as an embodiment of geek masculinity (discussed at length in chapter 3) than as a Western frontier outlaw. In the

parody, Cruz is reframed as a figure of hegemonic masculinity, but this transformation happened only after he publicly supported Trump. While posters to r/The_Donald expressed glee that Beto O'Rourke (often referred to as "Beta" or "Robert") did not win a senate seat, most seemed concerned that the close nature of the race indicated Texas might become purple and that illegal voters (and undocumented immigrants) were to blame.⁸⁸ As confirmation of the idea that games served as a known reference for TD denizens, no posters asked for clarification about the image or the game it referenced. Some commenters even referred to games in their responses, with one individual claiming that the election results were so close because "NPCs in r texas [r/Texas]" were voting, which ignored the demographic shifts occurring in the state.⁸⁹

Returning to the issue of flairs, a particular phrase, "Learn to code," appeared on numerous postings to r/The_Donald. While originally intended as a slur on Twitter to brigade media outlets and journalists who lost their jobs, the phrase appeared in widely varying memes and stories—including discussions of "Bernie bros" (young men who supported Bernie Sanders during his 2016 presidential campaign), the Democratic National Committee's use of technology, liberal arts majors, American rapper Cardi B, anti-Trump protesters, and ironically, given his background as a tech CEO, tweets made by then-Democratic presidential candidate Andrew Yang.⁹⁰ The phrase emphasizes a kind of technophilic view of both politics and everyday life. It reprises an element of geek masculinity (discussed in the last chapter) that valorizes technical knowledge and know-how over other humanistic ways of knowing. Along with the refrain "The left can't meme," it reifies technical prowess but obscures who is allowed to participate in this technophilic world. And while both people on the left and right of the political divide might agree in principle that technology is a net good for society, for TD, "Learn to code" is also a statement about breaking the current system and remaking it into something else. It invokes the concept of hacking as a solution to remake political and social life. Just as meninists suggest that taking "the red pill" allows men to understand how the world *really* works and that they are the victims of feminism, "Learn to code" implies

that critiquing the current political system without the ability or desire to remake it in r/The_Donald's image is useless.⁹¹

This interweaving of games and play as subcultural capital on r/The_Donald is also notable in a posting about the death of conservative American actor (and former Marine) R. Lee Ermey in April 2018. This post's flair read "Press F," an abbreviated reference to the 2014 video game *Call of Duty: Advanced Warfare*, in which player characters (PCs) are instructed to "Press F to pay respects" during a scene in which the PC attends a funeral for a fellow soldier.⁹² Confusingly, the game's original sequence was broadly derided and ridiculed by many gamers after its release.⁹³ So the use of this flair suggests both an ironic wink toward the gaming franchise and a real attempt at expressing sorrow over Ermey's death. Highly upvoted comments on the posting suggested the latter, but many commenters just posted a bolded "F" in response.

As with other examples of dark play on TD, earnestness is always mixed with shitposting (one of the community's flairs was literally "  SHITPOST  "), and the line between the two remained blurry. This also mirrored the collapse of differences between trolling and extremism that characterizes some elements of the alt-right.⁹⁴ TD's community delighted in the idea that "libs" took whatever they said seriously, but unlike Goffman's example (noted above) of biting that is keyed as play rather than fighting, postings on the subreddit were never really harmless bites.

Ultimately, posts on r/The_Donald embraced a narrative common within many games. Trump and his supporters are cast as invincible protagonists who are under attack by powerful villains. Using this logic, Trump supporters are threatened by the mainstream media, political correctness, and social justice warriors who are attacking their very existence. But this viewpoint remains an inversion of reality. Those who are actually threatened by the rhetoric of Trump and his GOP allies are the victims of state-sponsored violence through policing and the vigilante justice meted out by his supporters. So TD's play becomes dark when its implications become clear. In the same way that the term *social justice warrior* (SJW)

contains the threat of eliminationist rhetoric, the violent memes that populated TD were meant to be taken seriously.⁹⁵ But they also contained a kernel of plausible deniability, mirroring the words spoken by their “God Emperor,” who himself increasingly engaged in a kind of dark play. Trump’s tendency to say something outrageous and then deny it later worked as a kind of “wink wink, nudge nudge” to his supporters and also chummed the water for an increasingly panicked press and public.⁹⁶

SPEZGIVING, THE QUARANTINE, AND DEMISE OF R/THE_DONALD

Long after Trump’s election in 2016, posters to r/The_Donald continued to see themselves as persecuted on many fronts, as did others within the alt-right coalition. Despite the long history of the Reddit platform doing little to limit this subreddit, the community often suggested that Reddit administrators actively suppressed TD posters’ right to “free speech.”⁹⁷ As noted above, Reddit’s cofounder and current CEO, Steve Huffman (username “spez”), was criticized repeatedly for his unwillingness to ban the TD subreddit by other Redditors. However, his role in what came to be called “Spezgiving” complicated his relationship to r/The_Donald and led community members to see themselves as victims of a larger conspiracy perpetrated by social justice warriors.⁹⁸ Soon after the 2016 US presidential election, Reddit banned r/Pizzagate (a subreddit dedicated to a complex conspiracy theory involving pedophilia, the Democratic Party, and a pizzeria in Washington, DC). After the r/Pizzagate ban, TD was filled with highly upvoted comments that accused Huffman of being a pedophilia apologist or, with some variation of “Fuck u/spez,” blamed the CEO for banning the subreddit. Appending u/ to a Reddit username creates a clickable link to the person’s profile and sends them a direct message. Soon Huffman’s inbox was overflowing with messages from TD subscribers who were unhappy with the r/Pizzagate ban. In response, Huffman, who has admitted to the press that he considers himself a troll, wrote a script using his high-level admin privileges that replaced

every instance of his username with the names of some of TD's well-known posters.⁹⁹ The TD community was thrown into chaos as it was revealed that Huffman had the ability to edit user comments with impunity. Huffman later apologized, saying he'd "ruined Thanksgiving" (hence the event being named "Spezgiving" by Reddit drama gadflies) and admitted that his actions violated the trust that Redditors had in the platform.¹⁰⁰

In June 2019, r/The_Donald was placed into "quarantine"—a kind of virtual jail meant to reduce the traffic and autonomy of subreddits considered problematic by Reddit administrators. Quarantined subreddits display an opt-in message that must be accepted before they can be viewed, are not featured on r/All or r/Popular (subreddits that show a selection of popular content from across the site), do not produce ad revenue for the platform, and can no longer override Reddit's default style with custom CSS layouts.¹⁰¹ The sanction on TD was due to violent threats that were made against public officials in Oregon, where a climate bill stalled in the state legislature after Republican lawmakers walked out. TD denizens responded with threats against the police officers who were charged with returning the state legislators to the capitol to ensure a quorum.¹⁰²

Quarantining is a kind of neutered deplatforming that allows Reddit admins to disavow the content being shared on a subreddit without banning it outright, presumably because banning would be anathema to the platform's hands-off approach to content moderation.¹⁰³ While outright bans of subreddits are rare, they are effective in reducing (if not eliminating) the kind of problematic content and objectionable speech that prompts the ban. A study of changes to content policies enacted in 2015 (prompted, at least in part, by r/FatPeopleHate) suggested that kicking troubling subreddits off Reddit worked to reduce toxicity across the platform.¹⁰⁴

Why did Reddit quarantine r/The_Donald in 2019 but not ban it? Other Trump-friendly subreddits (such as r/Incels, r/Pizzagate, and r/QAnon) had already been banned. As a result, TD was losing subscribers prior to the quarantine, as far-right communities moved away from Reddit to platforms like Discord, Gab, and Voat that

promised they were free of the kind of “censorship” Reddit practiced.¹⁰⁵ As a result of the TD quarantine, subreddit traffic and subscriptions dropped precipitously. Much of the TD community moved off the platform completely to thedonald.win (now patriots.win). The new site mimicked the design and functionality of the old TD subreddit and later became its new home.

Certainly, the r/The_Donald subreddit’s close connection to a political figure made it a difficult case. In much the same way that Twitter before Elon Musk refused to enforce its own rules against @TheRealDonaldTrump (Trump’s personal Twitter account), despite numerous examples of Trump using the feed to author or retweet violent threats against individuals and communities, Reddit likely saw few options that did not draw more attention to the problem. As mentioned in chapter 3, the technolibertarian leanings of Silicon Valley tend toward a free-speech absolutism that claims that discourse is inherently rational and democratic and bad ideas can be dismantled when confronted with logical arguments. While TD eventually was banned, its long run on the platform suggests that Reddit administrators were unwilling to stray from free-speech absolutism even when a subreddit is wildly problematic and were reluctant to admit that the presence of toxic spaces like TD does, in fact, shape public discourse.

On June 29, 2020, a year after r/The_Donald was placed into quarantine—during the height of both the COVID-19 pandemic and the #BlackLivesMatter protests in the US—r/The_Donald was banned from Reddit. Administrators noted that r/The_Donald violated newly announced changes to the platform’s content policies.¹⁰⁶ Other factors also played a role. The first was that former CEO and cofounder Alexis Ohanian resigned from Reddit’s board and stated he wanted his board seat to be filled by a Black candidate (which it later was).¹⁰⁷ Ohanian’s resignation was a response to larger political unrest and protests in the wake of the deaths of George Floyd and Breonna Taylor. Second, advertisers were placing increasing pressure on social media companies to do something about violent speech on their platforms. On the same day that Reddit banned r/The_Donald, YouTube suspended the accounts of

several well-known White supremacists (including David Duke, Stefan Molyneux, and Richard Spencer), and Twitch temporarily suspended Trump's streaming channel.¹⁰⁸ In the end, however, r/The_Donald's ban was mostly a symbolic gesture, as the subreddit had been losing subscribers since it was first quarantined.

Under Reddit's new content policy, which led to the ban on r/The_Donald, communities that "incite violence or that promote hate based on identity or vulnerability will be banned." In its longer discussion of what constituted "identity or vulnerability," Reddit policy noted that

Marginalized or vulnerable groups include, but are not limited to, groups based on their actual and perceived race, color, religion, national origin, ethnicity, immigration status, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, pregnancy, or disability. These include victims of a major violent event and their families.

While the rule on hate protects such groups, it does not protect all groups or all forms of identity. For example, the rule does not protect groups of people who are in the majority or who promote such attacks of hate.¹⁰⁹

In his defense of TD's ban, Steve Huffman wrote, "All communities on Reddit must abide by our content policy in good faith. We banned r/The_Donald because it has not done so, despite every opportunity. The community has consistently hosted and upvoted more rule-breaking content than average ... antagonized us and other communities ... and its mods have refused to meet our most basic expectations. Until now, we've worked in good faith to help them preserve the community as a space for its users—through warnings, mod changes, quarantining, and more."¹¹⁰ In a later interview with the *New York Times*, Huffman admitted that the decision was hastened by the #BlackLivesMatter protests that year.¹¹¹

GAMING POLITICS

Gaming culture remains complicit in a *hegemony of play*, which, according to game theorist Janine Fron, refers to the ways that the "hegemonic game industry has infused both individuals' and societies' experiences of games with values and norms that reinforce that industry's technological, commercial and cultural investments in

a particular definition of games and play, creating a cyclical system of supply and demand in which alternate products of play are marginalized and devalued.”¹¹² While the video game industry and gaming culture are not solely responsible for the alt-right’s rise to prominence, I am suggesting that this hegemony of play serves as a kind of moral backdrop for spaces like r/The_Donald. Play, as conceived of in big-budget triple-A titles like *Red Dead Redemption*, remains preoccupied with a narrow definition of what winning means, idealizes hypermasculinity, valorizes violence, and portrays an egocentric, individualist world in which players are at the moral and ethical center. It is not difficult to see how this kind of play connects to the world inhabited by TD (and the alt-right more broadly). In the ideological space of this world, resources are scarce (so, for example, immigrants are going to steal jobs from citizens), winning is the ultimate goal of the game, and everyone playing the game has an equal likelihood of winning. As mentioned in chapter 3, this mirrors much of Silicon Valley’s preoccupation with meritocratic explanations for success and failure, marginalization of structural explanations, and reinforcement of the sense that individuals are ultimately responsible for their own success playing the game.

The dark play found at r/The_Donald also suggested another game played by the alt-right that was set in motion by those who saw #Gamergate supporters as convenient virtual foot soldiers—using the kind of “identity nostalgia” around gaming discussed in chapter 2 that was further enabled by the paucity of rules restricting speech on Reddit. By cloaking their discourse in the language of (dark) play and games, activists at TD were able to introduce a kind of memetic warfare into the world of politics. Subsequently, the far right’s agenda has become entwined with the language of memes and outrage, expressed in everything from Pepe the Frog to the latest social media post from politicians affiliated with the alt-right in the US and around the world. This moves beyond the internet ambivalence that has long characterized digital cultures.¹¹³ Instead, it exemplifies the potent ways technological platforms routinely decontextualize, amplify, and enable toxicity through design decisions despite their best intentions to do otherwise.

r/The_Donald's ban, while inevitable, occurred long after its impact had already been felt. In keeping with the conspiratorial tone Trump himself and those in his orbit have promulgated, it was just another example of the liberal bias of social media. But for Reddit, the timing of the ban allowed the company to deplatform a community that had long troubled it while also doing nothing about other popular subreddits that were rife with misogyny and racism (including r/KotakuInAction, r/MensRights, and r/TheRedPill). And since many on TD were also active participants on other parts of Reddit, it reified the media's construction of the far right as a set of bad actors to be deplatformed rather than a well-coordinated network of disparate individuals who would move elsewhere and find more insidious ways to recruit like-minded members. Banning TD provided Reddit some political cover as well. In an era when tech company execs like Mark Zuckerberg are subpoenaed to testify before Congress to explain their role in polarizing US political life, Reddit's move could be viewed as a stunt to avoid becoming a political target. It also highlighted the fraught relationship platforms like Reddit have with moderation. Relying on unpaid volunteers who could easily game Reddit's algorithm and design and ban dissenters with impunity created fertile ground for a feedback loop where the dark play (and fandom of Trump) became more virulent, violent, and extreme.

The dark play that characterized r/The_Donald continues to spread far beyond the now-shuttered community. The January 6, 2021, insurrection at the US Capitol was the most notable example of how the far right has fomented hostilities online that become violent action offline. And other moments have suggested that technology remains a critical component of a strategy to recruit and invite young people into the movement. In September 2020, the *Washington Post* reported on an apparently coordinated attempt by teenagers to use their social media accounts to spout pro-Trump talking points about topics such as COVID-19 and mail-in voter fraud.¹¹⁴ The investigation revealed that the teens did not disclose that they were being paid by the conservative organization Turning Point USA, also known for its ongoing attempts to "unmask" liberal

bias in college classrooms through its Professor Watchlist. In fact, their postings mirrored troll farms' use of bots to repost the same messages across multiple accounts. Perhaps inevitably, then, the dark play seeded by r/The_Donald has moved into a new phase that's simultaneously more visible (through the vast conspiracy theory that is QAnon and the numerous Republican politicians who now repeat alt-right talking points) but also more difficult to trace. When humans act like bots that act like humans, how exactly can this kind of "play" be combatted? Especially concerning is the reality that the alt-right is recruiting young people (contradicting the media construction of Gen Z as more liberal and diverse than prior generations) who have limited understanding of the end goal of this particular form of play. The events in Charlottesville,^{[115](#)} in Kenosha,^{[116](#)} and at the US Capitol demonstrated both the real-world implications of this kind of dark play and the reality that far-right movements in the US (and around the world) are getting bolder, younger, and more technologically adept. And despite Trump's loss in the 2020 presidential election, the memetic and network logics that provided fertile soil for his brand of persecutorial and conspiratorial thinking have intensified. Since he's running for reelection in 2024 while also facing numerous federal criminal charges, the possibility of an even more violent response is not only possible but, unfortunately, probable—unless we change things.

NOTES

¹. A small portion of this chapter appeared in Adrienne L. Massanari, "Reddit's Alt-Right: Toxic Masculinity, Free Speech, and /r/The_Donald," in *Fake News: Understanding Media and Misinformation in the Digital Age*, ed. Melissa Zimdars and Kembrew McLeod, 179–190 (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2020).

². Episode 1, "Election Night," directed by Bradley Buecker, *American Horror Story: Cult*, aired September 5, 2017, on FX.

³. Pantsuit Nation, named in honor of Hillary Clinton's presidential campaign attire of choice, was a private Facebook group started by Libby Chamberlain in October 2016. It eventually grew to about three million people by around election day. Postings were mostly personal in nature, with members often discussing their reasons for supporting the candidate and offering support for those who were the only one in their families or friendship group to do so. Postelection, Chamberlain

wrote a book based on the group's postings—a controversial move to many who were unhappy with this attempt to capitalize on the user-generated content posted in the group. See Alexandra Alter, "A Book Deal for Pantsuit Nation, and Then a Backlash," *New York Times*, December 21, 2016, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.nytimes.com/2016/12/21/business/a-book-deal-for-pantsuit-nation-and-then-a-backlash.html>; Jake Nevins, "Inside the Civil War over Hillary Clinton's 'Pantsuit Nation,'" *Vice*, December 27, 2016, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.vice.com/en_us/article/qkb5ab/inside-the-civil-war-over-hillary-clintons-pantsuit-nation. The Facebook group existed until March 2023, but Pantsuit Nation is also the name of a nonprofit focused on grassroots political organizing started by Chamberlain. See Rebecca Ruiz, "Feminist Facebook Group Pantsuit Nation Is Abruptly Shut Down," *Mashable*, March 17, 2023, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://mashable.com/article/pantsuit-nation-shuts-down>. Critics have taken issue with the brand of white feminism the group seems to promote. See, for example, Catherine A. Dobris and Rachel D. Davidson, "Pantsuit Nation: A Feminist Invitation to Engage," in *Gender, Race, and Social Identity in American Politics: The Past and Future of Political Access*, ed. Lori L. Montalbano, 5–22 (Lanham, MD: Lexington Books, 2019).

4. See GetFreeCash, "If the Breakfast Club Was Made Up of Websites," *r/Funny*, Reddit, July 22, 2013, updated August 2, 2015, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.reddit.com/r/funny/comments/3fiqad/if_the_breakfast_club_was_made_up_of_websites.

5. Michael Buoziš, "Doxing or Deliberative Democracy? Evidence and Digital Affordances in the Serial Subreddit," *Convergence: The International Journal of Research into New Media Technologies* 29, no. 3 (2017), <https://doi.org/10.1177/1354856517721809>; Alex Leavitt and Joshua A. Clark, "Upvoting Hurricane Sandy: Event-Based News Production Processes on a Social News Site," in *CHI '14: Proceedings of the SIGCHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, Toronto, Ontario, Canada* (New York: Association for Computing Machinery, 2014), 1495–1504, 2557140.

6. Adrienne L. Massanari, "#Gamergate and the Fappening: How Reddit's Algorithm, Governance, and Culture Support Toxic Technocultures," *New Media & Society* (2017): 329–346, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444815608807>.

7. Richard Schechner, *The Future of Ritual: Writings on Culture and Performance* (London: Routledge, 1995), 36.

8. W. Lance Bennett, "Beyond Pseudoevents: Election News as Reality TV," *American Behavioral Scientist* 49, no. 3 (2005): 364–378, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0002764205280919>.

9. Johan Huizinga, *Homo Ludens: A Study of the Play Element in Culture* (Boston, MA: Beacon Press, 1971; originally published 1938 in Dutch).

- [10.](#) Roger Caillois, *Man, Play and Games*, trans. Meyer Barash (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 2001).
- [11.](#) Shira Chess, *Ready Player Two: Women Gamers and Designed Identity* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2017); Julian Dibbell, *Play Money: Or, How I Quit My Day Job and Made Millions Trading Virtual Loot* (New York: Basic Books, 2007); Brooke Erin Duffy, *(Not) Getting Paid to Do What You Love: Gender, Social Media, and Aspirational Work* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2017); T. L. Taylor, *Raising the Stakes: E-Sports and the Professionalization of Computer Gaming* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2012).
- [12.](#) Aaron Trammell, *Repairing Play: A Black Phenomenology* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2023).
- [13.](#) Richard Schechner, *Between Theater and Anthropology* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1985).
- [14.](#) Brian Sutton-Smith, *The Ambiguity of Play* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1997).
- [15.](#) Clifford Geertz, *The Interpretation of Cultures* (New York: Basic Books, 1973).
- [16.](#) Patrick Bateson and Paul Martin, *Play, Playfulness, Creativity and Innovation* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2013).
- [17.](#) Miguel Sicart, *Play Matters* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2014).
- [18.](#) I am using Schechner's phrase here, even though it problematically equates darkness with something that is bad, ugly, or scary (and is a metaphor rooted in colorism and antiblackness).
- [19.](#) One notable exception is the edited collection *The Dark Side of Gameplay*, which suggests a far broader conceptualization of dark play that is focused on "issues such as playful transformations of problematic themes in game actions and behaviours that are deviant and controversial content in games." See Jonas Linderöth and Torill Elvira Mortensen, "Dark Play: The Aesthetics of Controversial Playfulness," in *The Dark Side of Game Play: Controversial Issues in Playful Environments*, ed. Torill Elvira Mortensen, Jonas Linderöth, and Ashley M. L. Brown (New York: Routledge, 2015), 5.
- [20.](#) Schechner, *The Future of Ritual*, 36.
- [21.](#) Richard Schechner, *Performance Theory*, 2nd ed. (New York: Routledge, 2003).
- [22.](#) Erving Goffman, *Frame Analysis: An Essay on the Organization of Experience* (New York: Harper Colophon Press, 1974).
- [23.](#) Goffman, *Frame Analysis*, 87–123.
- [24.](#) Schechner, *The Future of Ritual*, 39.

- [25.](#) Gregory Bateson, "A Theory of Play and Fantasy," in *The Game Design Reader: A Rules of Play Anthology*, ed. Katie Salen and Eric Zimmerman, 314–328 (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2006).
- [26.](#) Schechner, *The Future of Ritual*, 38.
- [27.](#) Whitney Phillips and Ryan M. Milner, *The Ambivalent Internet: Mischief, Oddity, and Antagonism Online* (Cambridge, UK: Polity, 2017).
- [28.](#) Mikhail Bakhtin, *Rabelais and His World*, trans. Hélène Iswolsky (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1984).
- [29.](#) Jenny L. Davis and James B. Chouinard, "Theorizing Affordances: From Request to Refuse," *Bulletin of Science, Technology & Society* 36, no. 4 (2016): 241–248, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0270467617714944>.
- [30.](#) Schechner, *The Future of Ritual*, 38.
- [31.](#) Lee Knuttila, "User Unknown: 4chan, Anonymity and Contingency," *First Monday* 16, no. 10 (September 19, 2011), accessed January 1, 2013, <https://doi.org/10.5210/fm.v16i10.3665>. For more on online disinhibition effect, see John Suler, "The Online Disinhibition Effect," *Cyberpsychology & Behavior* 7, no. 3 (2004): 321–326, <https://doi.org/10.1089/1094931041291295>.
- [32.](#) Pseudonymous spaces like Reddit allow individuals to create one or more persistent usernames to represent themselves.
- [33.](#) Adrienne L. Massanari, "Contested Play: The Culture and Politics of Reddit Bots," in *Socialbots and Their Friends: Digital Media and the Automation of Sociality*, ed. Robert W. Gehl and Maria Bakardjieva, 321–326 (New York: Routledge, 2016); Adrienne L. Massanari, *Participatory Culture, Community, and Play: Learning from Reddit* (New York: Peter Lang, 2015).
- [34.](#) Brad Parscale, "@reddit Yes," Twitter, June 23, 2016, <https://twitter.com/parscale/status/745988936028192768>. See also Ben Collins, "Analysis: Woman-Haters and Pickup Artists Love Trump on Reddit," *Daily Beast*, November 8, 2016, updated April 13, 2017, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.thedailybeast.com/analysis-woman-haters-and-pickup-artists-love-trump-on-reddit>.
- [35.](#) Michael Barthel et al., *Nearly Eight-in-Ten Reddit Users Get News on the Site*, Pew Research Center, February 26 2016, https://www.pewresearch.org/wp-content/uploads/sites/8/2016/02/PJ_2016.02.25_Reddit_FINAL.pdf.
- [36.](#) See "r/The_Donald Stats," SubredditStats, updated May 14, 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, https://subredditstats.com/r/the_donald.
- [37.](#) Rishab Nithyanand, Brian Schaffner, and Phillipa Gill, "Online Political Discourse in the Trump Era," arXiv, Cornell University, November 14, 2017, arXiv: 1711.05303, <https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.1711.05303>.

38. Nikhil Sonnad and Tim Squirrel, "The Alt-Right Is Creating Its Own Dialect: Here's the Dictionary," Quartz, updated October 30, 2017, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://qz.com/1092037/the-alt-right-is-creating-its-own-dialect-heres-a-complete-guide>.

39. Savvas Zannettou et al., "On the Origins of Memes by Means of Fringe Web Communities," arXiv, Cornell University, May 31, 2018, updated September 22, 2018, arXiv:1805.12512, <https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.1805.12512>.

40. DubTeeDub, "Reddit Admins Have Confirmed They Are Comfortable with T_D and Other Altright Subs Engaging in a Harassment Campaign Attacking Survivors of the Parkland School Shooting," r/AgainstHateSubreddits, Reddit, updated February 22, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.reddit.com/r/AgainstHateSubreddits/comments/7zgo1c/reddit_admins_have_confirmed_they_are_comfortable/?st=jixmxa4o&sh=9efae7f0.

41. Along with other reactionary subreddits and bots, r/The_Donald played a significant role in spreading fake news from Russian sources during the 2016 election cycle. See Ryan Broderick, "Reddit's Largest Pro-Trump Subreddit Appears to Have Been Targeted by Russian Propaganda for Years," BuzzFeed, September 24, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.buzzfeednews.com/article/ryanhatesthis/reddits-largest-pro-trump-subreddit-appears-to-have-been>; Issie Lapowsky, "Russian Propaganda Remains on Reddit," *Wired*, March 9, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.wired.com/story/reddit-russian-propaganda>.

42. spez, "In Response to Recent Reports about the Integrity of Reddit, I'd Like to Share Our Thinking," r/Announcements, Reddit, updated March 5, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.reddit.com/r/announcements/comments/827zqc/in_response_to_recent_reports_about_the_integrity/dv824bf/?context=5&st=jixne4wl&sh=9a183ffb.

43. Tim Squirrel, "Opinion: Reddit's Advertising Strategies Still Hide Hate Speech," Quartz, April 6, 2018, accessed June 20, 2018, <https://qz.com/1246087/opinion-reddits-advertising-strategies-still-hide-hate-speech>.

44. As of February 19, 2019, the moderation team consisted of eighteen moderators who had been in the position for a year, with an additional seven having served as little as two months.

45. Other Ask Me Anything sessions featured members of Trump's 2016 presidential campaign (including Trump himself), Tucker Carlson, Ann Coulter, right-wing conspiracy peddlers Alex Jones and Mike Cernovich, YouTube personalities Diamond and Silk, Proud Boys founder and "Western chauvinist" Gavin McInnes, and political operative and convicted felon Roger Stone.

46. No set credentials are needed to be a moderator (as a default, whoever creates a subreddit is a moderator), but moderators at the largest subreddits tend

to be long-time Reddit users who are familiar with the platform's functionality.

47. Amrita Khalid, "Unpacking The_Donald, the Internet's Pro-Trump Bunker," Daily Dot, September 15, 2017, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.dailydot.com/layer8/reddit-the-donald>. For more on the specific 2017 moderator event, see "Megathread: Reddit Admins Remove Leading Moderators of The_Donald," r/AskThe_Donald, Reddit, updated May 19, 2017, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.reddit.com/r/AskThe_Donald/comments/6c7zuc/megathread_reddit_admins_remove_leading.

48. Massanari, "Contested Play."

49. Bruno Latour, *Reassembling the Social: An Introduction to Actor-Network-Theory* (Oxford, UK: Oxford University Press, 2005).

50. Louis Althusser, *Lenin and Philosophy and Other Essays*, trans. Ben Brewster (New York: Monthly Review Press, 2001).

51. As with the other case studies in this book, this chapter is based on a close textual reading and critical discourse analysis of the r/The_Donald (TD) subreddit and associated media coverage. See Norman Fairclough, *Critical Discourse Analysis: The Critical Study of Language*, 2nd ed. (London: Routledge, 2010). Critical discourse analysis examines texts and pays particular attention to issues of power in an effort to critique and change social realities. While critical discourse analysis often focuses exclusively on linguistic texts, I have also employed techniques drawn from visual studies to analyze how the verbal and visual elements reinforce (or contradict) one another. For more, see Dennis Jancsary, Markus Höllerer, and Renate Meyer, "Critical Analysis of Visual and Multimodal Texts," in *Methods of Critical Discourse Studies*, ed. Ruth Wodak and Michael Meyer, 180–204 (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage, 2015); Gillian Rose, *Visual Methodologies: An Introduction to Researching with Visual Materials*, 4th ed. (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage, 2016). Examining both verbal and visual elements is critical to understanding a space like r/The_Donald because communities that coalesced around Trump's candidacy (and eventual presidency) often did so through memes and image-based conspiracy theories. The primary question that guided my analysis is "How does r/The_Donald use dark play as a way to create community?"

Much of this chapter is based on an examination of the "top" 100 postings at r/The_Donald over the course of one year based on a collection date of March 4, 2019 (prior to the subreddit's quarantine of June 2019 and its eventual ban the following year). I limited my analysis to one year rather than examining the top postings of all time, as this represented a better selection of the day-to-day conversations that occurred on the subreddit rather than initial responses to Trump's election (which are overrepresented in the "all time" list). In addition, to determine how counterdiscourses were received by the TD community, I examined

100 of the most “controversial” postings over the same time period. Postings were analyzed noting two types of comments—moments where the play frame employed elements of dark play (through memetic ambivalence, where players subverted the game’s own rules or denied that a game was being played at all) as well as moments where games and gaming culture were specifically invoked by the community. While I read a selection of comments on postings to understand the ideological underpinnings of TD, I randomly selected a subset of ten top postings and analyzed their comments in greater detail for the ways in which community members engaged in play and dark play. I also revisited the subreddit after the subreddit was quarantined (in June 2019) to see how TD subscribers discussed Reddit administrators and the possible impacts of the quarantine.

[52.](#) Henry Jenkins, *Convergence Culture: Where Old and New Media Collide* (New York: NYU Press, 2006); Henry Jenkins, *Textual Poachers: Television Fans and Participatory Culture*, 2nd ed. (New York: Routledge, 2012).

[53.](#) John Fiske, “The Cultural Economy of Fandom,” in *The Adoring Audience: Fan Culture and Popular Media*, ed. Lisa A. Lewis, 167–190 (New York: Routledge, 2002);

[54.](#) Fiske, “The Cultural Economy of Fandom.”

[55.](#) Melissa M. Brough and Sangita Shresthova, “Fandom Meets Activism: Rethinking Civic and Political Participation,” *Transformative Works and Cultures* 10 (2012): 1–27, <https://journal.transformativeworks.org/index.php/twc/article/view/303/265>.

[56.](#) See Mia Consalvo, “Confronting Toxic Gamer Culture: A Challenge for Feminist Game Studies Scholars,” *Ada: A Journal of Gender, New Media, and Technology* 1, no. 1 (2012), <https://scholarsbank.uoregon.edu/xmlui/handle/1794/26289>; Christopher A. Paul, *The Toxic Meritocracy of Video Games: Why Gaming Culture Is the Worst* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2018); Anastasia Salter and Bridget Blodgett, *Toxic Geek Masculinity in Media: Sexism, Trolling, and Identity Policing* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2017).

[57.](#) Jenkins, *Convergence Culture*.

[58.](#) Fiske, “The Cultural Economy of Fandom.”

[59.](#) Stephanie Mencimer, “‘The Left Can’t Meme’: How Right-Wing Groups Are Training the Next Generation of Social Media Warriors,” *Mother Jones*, April 2, 2019, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.motherjones.com/politics/2019/04/right-wing-groups-are-training-young-conservatives-to-win-the-next-meme-war>; Emily Reynolds. “The Left-Wing Meme-Makers Trying to Reclaim Meme Culture,” *Wired*, August 24, 2019, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.wired.co.uk/article/left-wing-memes>.

[60.](#) Sara Ahmed, “Affective Economies,” *Social Text* 22, no. 2 (2004): 117, muse.jhu.edu/article/55780.

[61.](#) Ahmed, "Affective Economies," 123.

[62.](#) Hannah Fingerhut, "In 'Political Correctness' Debate, Most Americans Think Too Many People Are Easily Offended," Pew Research Center, July 20, 2016, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2016/07/20/in-political-correctness-debate-most-americans-think-too-many-people-are-easily-offended>.

[63.](#) Another rule at r/The_Donald read "AfterBerners (BernieBots) must assimilate." This likely referred to Sanders's presidential primary losses to Clinton and the subsequent controversy over the nomination process, which some within the Sanders camp said was rigged in favor of Clinton. For more detail, see Ezra Klein, "Was the Democratic Primary Rigged?," Vox, November 14, 2017, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.vox.com/policy-and-politics/2017/11/14/16640082/donna-brazile-warren-bernie-sanders-democratic-primary-rigged>. The rule links to a posting that was made by a presumed moderator at the time (later listed only as "[deleted]") and that featured an extensive guide for "reformed" BernieBots as to how they might "assimilate" and "decuckify" by supporting Trump.

[64.](#) As of January 2020, r/DonaldTrump had around four thousand subscribers.

[65.](#) Many subreddit moderators use the Reddit AutoModerator (automod) tool to create automatic postings that remind individuals of the rules or give advice based on a keyword in the original post. For example, whenever someone asks a question on Reddit about moving to Chicago, the r/Chicago automod posts an automatic message with a pointer to the subreddit's wiki, where rental resources created by the community have been collected.

[66.](#) It's striking to see how this possibility has changed, especially since the 2020 election cycle. To support Trump now is to embrace a narrative that sees him as wholly a victim (of the press, judicial unfairness, etc.) and as the only possible savior of White America. Any other possibility for a more nuanced view of him is foreclosed.

[67.](#) For an excellent (and chilling) primer on QAnon, see Adrienne LaFrance, "The Prophecies of Q: American Conspiracy Theories Are Entering a Dangerous New Phase," *The Atlantic*, June 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/2020/06/qanon-nothing-can-stop-what-is-coming/610567>.

[68.](#) For more on conflict within fandom communities, see Derek Johnson, "Fantagonism: Factions, Institutions, and Constitutive Hegemonies of Fandom," in *Fandom: Identities and Communities in a Mediated World*, ed. Jonathan Gray, Cornel Sandvoss, and C. Lee Harrington, 369–386 (New York: New York University, 2017).

69. Christopher Alexander, *A Pattern Language: Towns, Buildings, Construction* (Cambridge, UK: Oxford University Press, 1977).

70. Natasha Dow Schüll, *Addiction by Design: Machine Gambling in Las Vegas* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2012).

71. Aaron Drummond and James D. Sauer, "Video Game Loot Boxes Are Psychologically Akin to Gambling," *Nature Human Behaviour* 2, no. 8 (2018): 530–532, <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-018-0360-1>, <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-018-0360-1>; José P Zagal, Staffan Björk, and Chris Lewis, "Dark Patterns in the Design of Games" (paper presented at the International Conference on Foundations of Digital Games, Chania, Crete, Greece, 2013).

72. For more examples, see "Deceptive Patterns," Deception.Design, <https://www.darkpatterns.org> and "Confirmshaming," Confirmshaming.Tumblr.com, <https://confirmshaming.tumblr.com>.

73. At one point, subreddit styles could be turned off at the desktop site and were limited or overridden by the default subreddit style on many third-party mobile applications (such as BaconReader on Android). Discussions of the site and screenshots represent Reddit's design prior to its redesign in April 2018, which many long-time Reddit users rejected for what they saw as an attempt by the platform to make it more friendly to advertisers as it limited the ability of individual subreddits to modify their CSS as they saw fit. See LanterneRougeOG. "We Are Making Some Changes and Here's How to Keep the Feedback Going," Reddit, September 19, 2019, accessed February 15, 2024, https://www.reddit.com/r/redesign/comments/d6icz0/we_are_making_some_changes_and_heres_how_to_keep.

Many long-time users (including myself) have continued to use the old design as their default. See Reddit, "Welcome to Reddit," accessed February 15, 2024, <https://old.reddit.com>. For coverage about the redesign, see Shanon Liao, "Reddit Begins Rolling Out First Redesign in a Decade," The Verge, April 2, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.theverge.com/2018/4/2/17190244/reddit-redesign-begins-rolling-out>. Discussions of the subreddit's design are based on the author's own screenshots and notes taken at the time of analysis. Unfortunately, parts of the subreddit's design are difficult to replicate using publicly accessible archival tools like the Internet Archive's Wayback Machine. This is, in part, because the archive does not properly display how the subreddit might appear to logged-in users who are not current subscribers to r/The_Donald. Additionally, after TD was quarantined, many of the pages crawled by the Wayback Machine were effectively broken.

74. Under the new design, sorting by "controversial" at the subreddit or posting level is no longer allowed. Only "hot," "new," "top," and "rising" options are offered. Individual comments default sort by "best" but can also be sorted by "top," "new," "controversial," "old," and "Q&A." See martinator001, "The New

Sorting Looks Cool, but It's Missing Something," r/Redesign, Reddit, updated August 16, 2019, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.reddit.com/r/redesign/comments/cr9tv7/the_new_sorting_looks_cool_but_its_missing.

75. Again, these changes are for only the desktop version and do not carry over to the mobile version of Reddit.

76. See Adrienne L. Massanari, *Participatory Culture, Community, and Play: Learning from Reddit* (New York: Peter Lang, 2015). Under the new design, the subreddit r/ShitRedditSays has changed the upvote and downvote buttons.

77. Depending on the settings enabled by a subreddit's moderators, a flair can also be attached to a username.

78. See Reddit, "Post Flair," accessed July 29, 2023, <https://mods.reddithelp.com/hc/en-us/articles/360010513191-Post-Flair>.

79. Most of the flair categories are written in all-caps, likely an homage to Trump's Twitter feed, which features odd capitalization choices. "The Mystery behind Trump's Twitter Capitalization Habit, Somewhat Explained," Vox, updated July 3, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.vox.com/2018/7/3/17532802/trump-capitalization-tweet>.

80. Derek Robertson, "How an Obscure Conservative Theory Became the Trump Era's Go-to Nerd Phrase," Politico, February 25, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.politico.com/magazine/story/2018/02/25/overton-window-explained-definition-meaning-217010>.

81. Trevor Martin, "Dissecting Trump's Most Rabid Online Following," FiveThirtyEight, March 23, 2017, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://fivethirtyeight.com/features/dissecting-trumps-most-rabid-online-following>.

82. Pierre Bourdieu, "The Forms of Capital," in *Handbook of Theory and Research for the Sociology of Education*, ed. John G. Richardson, 241–258 (Westport, CT: Greenwood, 1986).

83. Sarah Thorton, *Club Cultures: Music, Media and Subcultural Capital* (Middletown, CT: Wesleyan University Press, 1996).

84. Pierre Bourdieu, *Outline of a Theory of Practice* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1977).

85. Ben Kuchera and Jeffrey Parkin, "Red Dead Redemption 2 Is a Criticism of Power Fantasies," Polygon, November 2, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.polygon.com/2018/11/2/18042220/red-dead-redemption-2-power-fantasy>.

86. Richard Slotkin, *Gunfighter Nation: The Myth of the Frontier in Twentieth-Century America* (Norman: University of Oklahoma Press, 1998), 12.

87. See Raewyn W. Connell and James W. Messerschmidt, "Hegemonic Masculinity: Rethinking the Concept," *Gender & Society* 19, no. 6 (2005): 829–859, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/27640853>. For more on Ted Cruz's unlikability, see Andrew Prokop, "Want to Know Why So Many Republicans Hate Ted Cruz? Read His Book," Vox, updated April 28, 2016, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.vox.com/2016/1/28/10846212/ted-cruz-republicans-hate>.
88. See in_case_u_didnt_know, "Cruz Retains Senate Seat," Reddit, Internet Archive Wayback Machine, accessed February 15, 2024, https://web.archive.org/web/20190117201253/https://www.reddit.com/r/The_Donald/comments/9uvomw/cruz_retains_senate_seat.
89. The term *nonplayer characters* (NPCs) was borrowed from role-playing games where the dungeon master played a character for the purposes of advancing the story. The term is used in other subreddits. Here the term presumably refers to people the poster believes might be shells or plants spouting particular viewpoints.
90. For more on how "Learn to code" became an alt-right meme, see Talia Lavin, "The Fetid, Right-Wing Origins of 'Learn to Code,'" *New Republic*, February 1, 2019, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://newrepublic.com/article/153019/fetid-right-wing-origins-learn-code>.
91. In this, the "Learn to code" statement mirrors comments often received by feminist game critics on Twitter when they point out that games frequently lack nonstereotypical representations of women or other marginalized groups. These critics are admonished that they should make the video games they want to see instead of critiquing the ones that exist. As Adrienne Shaw argues, this position is troubling and ultimately reproduces market logics of who is and is not a gamer. Adrienne Shaw, "On Not Becoming Gamers: Moving beyond the Constructed Audience," *Ada: A Journal of Gender, New Media, and Technology*, no. 2 (2013), <https://scholarsbank.uoregon.edu/xmlui/handle/1794/26292>.
92. Know Your Meme, "Press F to Pay Respects," December 20, 2014, updated February 3, 2021, accessed February 15, 2024, <https://knowyourmeme.com/memes/press-f-to-pay-respects>.
93. Andrew Vestal, "All Due Respect: Press F for Farce," Gamasutra, November 6, 2014, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.gamasutra.com/blogs/AndrewVestal/20141105/229523/All_Due_Respect_Press_F_for_Farce.php.
94. Munn Luke, "Alt-Right Pipeline: Individual Journeys to Extremism Online," *First Monday* 24, no. 6 (2019), <https://doi.org/10.5210/fm.v24i6.10108>.
95. Adrienne L. Massanari and Shira Chess, "Attack of the 50-Foot Social Justice Warrior: The Discursive Construction of SJW Memes as the Monstrous Feminine," *Feminist Media Studies* 18, no. 4 (2018): 525–542.

96. Linda Qiu, "17 Times Donald Trump Said One Thing and Then Denied It," *Politifact*, July 6, 2016, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.politifact.com/article/2016/jul/06/17-things-donald-trump-said-and-then-denied-saying>.

97. The r/The_Donald community also suggested that Reddit moderators manipulated the mechanics of Reddit, as I mentioned earlier. For a time, TD had an outsized presence on r/All (a page that lists all of the most-upvoted material across Reddit) given its membership. This was because TD moderators gamed a particular feature of the platform. The "pin" makes a given posting appear at the top of the subreddit, which is a useful tool for making announcements about rule changes or for responding to current events going on in the community. Moderators determined that by repeatedly pinning and unpinning postings on their subreddit, they could gain more karma points more quickly, making the site rise in the ranks of r/All. An adjustment to the algorithm in June 2016 eventually fixed this loophole (much to the chagrin of moderators at r/The_Donald), but it still meant that for many months it dominated the conversation on the platform. For more on this, see Ryan P. Shepherd, "Gaming Reddit's Algorithm: r/The_Donald, Amplification, and the Rhetoric of Sorting," *Computers and Composition* 56 (2020): 102572, <https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.1016/j.compcom.2020.102572>.

98. This kind of persecutorial complex and conflicted relationship with platform administrators by communities affiliated with the alt-right/-lite is not new and is not unique to Reddit. As I detail in chapter 2, #Gamergate discussions were eventually banned from 4chan after numerous incidents of doxing and harassment of developer Zoë Quinn. In an ironic twist (given the platform's role in hosting violent and toxic content), 4chan founder Christopher "moot" Poole was castigated as a social justice warrior for the decision. He later admitted #Gamergate had been a primary reason for his departure from the company. See David Kushner, "4chan's Overlord Christopher Poole Reveals Why He Walked Away," *Rolling Stone*, March 13, 2015, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.rollingstone.com/culture/culture-features/4chans-overlord-christopher-poole-reveals-why-he-walked-away-93894>.

99. Andrew Marantz, "Reddit and the Struggle to Detoxify the Internet," *The New Yorker*, updated March 12, 2018, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2018/03/19/reddit-and-the-struggle-to-detoxify-the-internet>.

100. spez, "Tifu by Editing Some Comments and Creating an Unnecessary Controversy," r/Announcements, Reddit, updated November 30, 2016, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.reddit.com/r/announcements/comments/5frg1n/tifu_by_editing_some_comments_and_creating_an.

101. Reddit, "Quarantined Subreddits," 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.reddithelp.com/hc/en-us/articles/360043069012>.

102. Umair Irfan, "Oregon Republicans to Return after a Week-Long Walkout to Block a Climate Bill," Vox, June 25, 2019, updated June 28, 2019, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.vox.com/2019/6/25/18758554/oregon-republican-walkout-climate-change-cap-and-trade>; Emily Stewart, "Reddit Restricts Its Biggest Pro-Trump Board over Violent Threats," Recode, Vox, June 26, 2019, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.vox.com/recode/2019/6/26/18760288/reddit-the-donald-trump-message-board-quarantine-ban>.

103. Deplatforming occurs when popular social media platforms ban certain accounts because of ongoing rule-breaking behavior. Within conservative circles, complaints about the ban of individuals like Milo Yiannapolous from Twitter (for example) are provided as further evidence that Silicon Valley favors liberals and left-leaning pundits. For more on deplatforming, see Richard Rogers, "Deplatforming: Following Extreme Internet Celebrities to Telegram and Alternative Social Media," *European Journal of Communication* 35, no. 3 (2020): 213–229, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0267323120922066>

104. Eshwar Chandrasekharan et al., "You Can't Stay Here: The Efficacy of Reddit's 2015 Ban Examined through Hate Speech," *Proceedings ACM Human-Computer Interaction* 1, no. CSCW (2017), art. 31, <https://doi.org/10.1145/3134666>, <https://doi.org/10.1145/3134666>

105. Voat was later shut down after numerous funding problems. Adi Robertson, "'Free Speech' Reddit Clone Voat Says It Will Shut Down on Christmas," The Verge, December 22, 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.theverge.com/2020/12/22/22195115/voat-free-speech-right-wing-reddit-clone-shutdown-investor>.

106. In around 2000, other communities were banned (most with few subscribers). Most notably was r/ChapoTrapHouse (an unofficial subreddit for fans of the leftwing, populist "dirtbag left" podcast of the same name), which some on Reddit suggested was banned in part so the platform would not be accused of having a liberal bias.

107. The CEO of startup accelerator Y Combinator, Michael Seibel, was appointed to fill Ohanian's seat. Karya Yurieff and Sara Ashley O'Brien, "Alexis Ohanian Asked to Be Replaced by a Black Candidate on Reddit's Board. Reddit Listened," CNN, updated June 10, 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.cnn.com/2020/06/10/tech/reddit-michael-seibel/index.html>.

108. Julia Alexander, "YouTube Bans Stefan Molyneux, David Duke, Richard Spencer, and More for Hate Speech," The Verge, June 29, 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.theverge.com/2020/6/29/21307303/youtube-bans-molyneux-duke-richard-spencer-conduct-hate-speech>; Kellen Browning, "Twitch Suspends Trump's Channel for 'Hateful Conduct,'" *New York Times*, June 29, 2020, updated

June 30, 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/06/29/technology/twitch-trump.html>.

109. See Reddit, "Promoting Hate Based on Identity or Vulnerability," updated July 13, 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://support.reddithelp.com/hc/en-us/articles/360045715951>.

110. See spez, "Update to Our Content Policy," r/Announcements, Reddit, updated June 29, 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.reddit.com/r/announcements/comments/hi3oht/update_to_our_content_policy/.

111. Kevin Roose, "Reddit's C.E.O. on Why He Banned 'The_Donald' Subreddit," *New York Times*, June 30, 2020, updated January 20, 2021, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/06/30/us/politics/reddit-bans-steve-huffman.html>.

112. Janine Fron et al., "The Hegemony of Play," in *DiGRA '07: Proceedings of the 2007 DiGRA International Conference: Situated Play*, University of Tokyo, September 24–27, 2007, vol. 4 (DiGRA, 2007), 1.

113. Whitney Phillips and Ryan M. Milner, *The Ambivalent Internet: Mischief, Oddity, and Antagonism Online* (Cambridge, UK: Polity, 2017).

114. Issac Stanley-Becker, "Pro-Trump Youth Group Enlists Teens in Secretive Campaign Likened to a 'Troll Farm,' Prompting Rebuke by Facebook and Twitter," *Washington Post*, September 15, 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, https://www.washingtonpost.com/politics/turning-point-teens-disinformation-trump/2020/09/15/c84091ae-f20a-11ea-b796-2dd09962649c_story.html.

115. Charlottesville was the site of the aforementioned Unite the Right rally in August 2017 that resulted in the death of antiracist activist Heather Heyer when a car driven by a White supremacist plowed into counterprotesters. See Joe Heim, "Recounting a Day of Rage, Hate, Violence and Death," *Washington Post*, August 14, 2017, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.washingtonpost.com/graphics/2017/local/charlottesville-timeline>.

116. In August 2020, Black Lives Matter protests formed in Kenosha, Wisconsin, after police shot Jacob Blake, a Black man, in front of his children. A White seventeen-year-old from Illinois, illegally armed with an AK-47, was driven by his mother to the scene where he later shot and killed two protesters. The teenager was later defended on Twitter by President Trump. Haley Willis et al., "Tracking the Suspect in the Fatal Kenosha Shootings," *New York Times*, August 27, 2020, updated November 3, 2020, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/08/27/us/kyle-rittenhouse-kenosha-shooting-video.html>.

5

METAGAMING DEMOCRACY

While researching the case studies discussed in this book and the events that have transpired subsequently, I've been struck by how much play and games have become embedded in our political life. #Gamergate revealed the ways groups could *game* the affordances of platforms. The intellectual dark web and James Damore's memo showed us how the right could *game* free speech. And the community that coalesced on the r/The_Donald subreddit demonstrated how the right could *game* politics through humor and play. These cases provide ample evidence that Silicon Valley, while not entirely responsible for our current predicament, certainly hasn't helped foster an inclusive and just online sphere. And these cases also demonstrate that the larger goal of the far right is to *metagame* democracy (more on this below).

In this book's introduction, I suggest we might view the last twenty years as a game that has been designed by Silicon Valley and that has welcomed the far right into our everyday lives through social media. In the 1983 movie *WarGames*, Matthew Broderick's character hacks into a supercomputer that controls the US missile response system and triggers a real-world nuclear panic when he insists on playing Global Thermonuclear War thinking it's just an exciting video game. After the computer cycles through various nuclear war scenarios, it concludes that "the only winning move is not to play."¹ There is no win condition if we continue playing the

game as Silicon Valley designed it or even viewing it as a game at all. Even the notion of winning and losing is a problem.

My analysis suggests that Silicon Valley's system of values, while pervasive in the technologies we use, is ultimately harmful. It positions all players as equals, when most of us are, by design, increasingly nonplayer characters who have little agency in a game world structured by technologies (like algorithms and artificial intelligence) we can't fully grasp. The Mark Zuckerbergs of the world have more power as they are designing the game, but they also downplay their ability to structure political and cultural discourse through the technologies they create. This system of values also positions the trolls and those who use their exploits (like political operatives Steve Bannon and Roger Stone) as simply bad actors and not as a logical outcome of platform design and a toxic gaming culture. And it ignores the backdrop where politics is presented as a spectacle and a game with winners and losers. There's almost no discussion of the complex ways that the media and politics intersect or are increasingly influential in a world that is both more connected and more fragmented than ever before. And there's very little conversation about how the game of politics is also rigged against most of us, especially the most marginalized. Instead, we're told that everyone is equal and that any unfortunate outcomes could not have been forecasted. In the same breath, we're assured that the brightest and best minds of tech are working every day to improve our lives through their creations—even though they don't even seem to know how their creations really work.

This particular game reinforces core assumptions about US exceptionalism and uniqueness. These assumptions, for better but mostly for worse, have also been exported globally through Silicon Valley's outsized influence on technology worldwide. But despite all of its claims that it is eliminating hierarchies and creating flat organizations and is a meritocracy, Silicon Valley itself has never been a democracy. Amazon founder Jeff Bezos is rewarded with billions of dollars for his contributions to society, but the warehouse employees who work for him and want to unionize aren't. What Big Tech creates therefore has come to reflect a limited set of values—

one that just so happens to keep people like Bezos in power. This mindset suggests that the reason the people behind these technologies are in charge is because they are just better at these things—not that they had access to immense amounts of social and economic capital. The platforms that they’ve created are also predicated on a very narrow, very American set of values (like free-speech absolutism) that ignore global realities and do little to support marginalized communities and those outside the Global North.

There are moments when even Silicon Valley lifts the curtain and acknowledges the game it’s playing. Elon Musk’s purchase of Twitter, his outspokenness about the platform, and his repeated concerns about its supposed restrictions on free speech belie both his greed and his out-of-touch worldview.² His offer to purchase Twitter capped a week of *Succession*-style developments.³ After Musk tweeted that he was the company’s largest individual shareholder, Twitter’s CEO, Parag Agrawal, announced that Musk would be joining the board of directors, suggesting that Musk’s thoughts about new platform features (like an edit function for tweets) would be given serious consideration as the company moved forward. When it was announced that Musk wasn’t interested in joining the board and instead was pursuing a hostile takeover plan to buy Twitter shares and take the company private (citing, in particular, his concerns with the company’s limitations on free speech),⁴ the board accepted Musk’s offer. But when Musk tried to pull out of the deal, citing vague concerns about fake accounts, Twitter threatened legal action against him, and after much back and forth, Musk became Twitter’s new owner. Donald Trump and many others who had been banned due to hate-speech violations were allowed to return. Content policies were revised and loosened. And up to 75 percent of Twitter’s workforce was fired.⁵

In the wake of Musk’s Twitter takeover (and its renaming as X), the platform has gone from bad to worse. It has been inundated with hate speech (employees who were in charge of trust and safety have been fired or resigned) and random musings from its owner about features and changes. One change was that anyone with \$8 a

month can have a verified account, a new feature that is nearly useless for those who aren't willing to pay and means that someone owning @420tokeup (as a fictional example) can now become a verified account purporting to be Delta Airlines. Previous to this change in verified accounts, Twitter worked with brands and notable people (such as celebrities and journalists) to authenticate their identities. Under Musk, however, anyone could purchase a verified badge by paying a monthly fee. Musk, like the angry gamers of #Gamergate who turned social media into a kind of game they could manipulate, decided that the game of Twitter was easier to control as the designer rather than simply as a player. And yet his disastrous tenure suggests that Musk and his hubris will end up destroying the platform. Like many gamers before him, Musk is learning that designing and running the game are work. His actions might serve as a final repudiation of the "Learn to code" meme parroted in toxic geek spaces (like r/The_Donald, discussed in chapter 4). Knowing how to code and knowing how to make platforms usable, safe, and less toxic are two different things. And the latter is not always fun or rewarding, as Musk is quickly learning. He was someone who purported to love the platform, and yet he managed to destroy it in a matter of months. Maybe this was his intention all along. It seems remarkably similar to the ways that many within the Republican Party yell about the superiority of the US while also making it clear that they are intent on destroying it from within.

FROM GAMES TO METAGAMES

Many of those associated with the alt-right view democracy as a kind of game that can be manipulated at will and made to ensure those who have power will stay in power. And they're not entirely wrong in one sense: democracy as an institution is already rigged/gamed. In the US, problematic political realities—like gerrymandering, the Electoral College, the *Citizens United* Supreme Court decision⁶ (which allowed corporations to funnel almost unlimited funds into political campaigns), and the structure of the Senate where a state with a population under 600,000 (like Wyoming) has the same number of

senators as a state with a population close to 40 million (like California)—all contribute to a game that’s never been equal. (As a District of Columbia resident, I’m particularly salty that the 700,000 people who live here have zero meaningful representation in Congress.) By ostensibly using the tools of democratic systems to ensure their stranglehold on power, the alt-right (and their GOP enablers) are ensuring a late-stage capitalist oligarchical nightmare where anyone who isn’t a White, Christian, able-bodied, wealthy, cishet man is a second-class citizen.⁷ This has happened with the help of those who control, program, and design the media that we all create, consume, and share. The result is a polluted information environment and a world that seems far more divisive and violent than ever.

This reality means that the alt-right is not just gaming platforms or technology but has been playing a much bigger game—a metagame focused on undermining democracy. Again, for our purposes here, metagaming is simply a game played about (or around) another game. Game theorists Stephanie Boluk and Patrick LeMieux broaden this definition significantly, suggesting that games themselves have become almost indistinguishable from metagames.⁸ As they note, “the concept has taken on renewed importance and political urgency in a media landscape in which videogames not only colonize and enclose the very concept of games, play, and leisure, but ideologically conflate the creativity, criticality, and craft of play with the act of consumption.”⁹ While they’re speaking specifically about the world of video games, their point rings true for the kinds of games those on the alt-right have been playing: they’re fundamentally reshaping political life globally in attempt to ideologically conflate democracy with things like cultural Marxism and wokeism.

The Stop the Steal riot fully revealed this metagame on January 6, 2021. It was a shocking development to many within middle-class White America as it demonstrated the fragility of a democracy they had assumed was stable. However, it also forced us to confront an ugly truth: the US has never been democratic for a large portion of its population. Since the insurrection, it’s apparent that those in the

Republican Party (with few exceptions) have continued to embrace Trumpism, conspiracism, and the kinds of attacks seen during #Gamergate (discussed in chapter 2) as legitimate strategies for fomenting anger and hostility. Any institutions and individuals suspected of harboring liberal or even pro-democratic viewpoints are under attack, with marginalized communities facing the worst invective—on- and offline. This reality—one that BIPOC and queer women have long warned us about—has been largely ignored.^{[10](#)}

Perhaps the only positive thing that comes out of all of this mess is that we will take seriously the words of those who have been harmed the most by Silicon Valley's value system and start considering ways to imagine a future in which spaces like Twitter, Reddit, and Facebook don't become overrun with toxicity and violent rhetoric. Platforms have long been designed around some core assumptions that we're beginning to realize aren't particularly helpful. These include deeply held, but misguided, beliefs—that people are rational actors, that harassment is an anomaly rather than an unfortunately common occurrence, and that everyone is equally served by the sort of meritocratic logics that permeate the culture of tech. As in politics, the reality is far more complex—especially when a handful of individuals can act in bad faith and metagame the system. These moments remind us that democracy is fragile. Big Tech needs to redesign their game so it's actually fair. What happens online and in Silicon Valley doesn't stay there. It reflects much larger and more pernicious cultural and political realities.

Some might argue that the alt-right is cheating, not metagaming. For most people, cheating is fundamentally about using deception to gain an advantage. But what constitutes cheating versus playing the game well is often contested and contextually dependent.^{[11](#)} What the alt-right is doing is not cheating per se. First, while the Stop the Steal rally and US Capitol insurrection were predicated on a lie (the lie that Trump won the 2020 presidential election), the actions of the rioters were committed in the open. There was no deception or real attempt to hide what was going to happen. Anyone reading the chatter online on spaces like Gab, Parler, and Twitter in the months

leading up to January 2021 was aware that the right was fomenting violence among its ranks. The rioters themselves felt no reluctance in sharing their exploits with the public in real time. Numerous Facebook Live streams, TikTok videos, tweets, and other posts offered a front-row seat to anyone who wanted to watch.¹² Second, the January 6 events were enabled by structures around federal elections that already exist within the American democratic system. Mostly, there was an exploitation of informal rules that have never been fully codified because our democratic institutions don't really account for players who are intent on destroying them from the inside. In other words, the far right has been playing a metagame enabled by game mechanics that were always flawed on some level. And our insistence that the Framers of the Constitution were infallible and could foresee the world that would exist in the twenty-first century has exacerbated the ability of the alt-right to metagame.

However, the far right's attempt to metagame democracy isn't limited to political moves made globally by authoritarian leaders such as Jair Bolsonaro in Brazil, Recep Tayyip Erdoğan in Turkey, Boris Johnson in the UK, Viktor Orbán in Hungary, and Vladimir Putin in Russia. It's also a strategy made possible by members of the technocratic elite and their disdain for anything that might impede their "Move fast and break things" approach. This disdain often shows up in subtle and small ways. For example, when Meta's Mark Zuckerberg testified before the Senate's Judiciary and Commerce committees in 2018 about Cambridge Analytica and the role Facebook has played in propagating extremism, he wore a poorly tailored suit. In deference to the institution, he wore something other than his signature blue jeans and hoodie sweatshirt. But the slightly ill-fitting suit, which fashion critics called "perfunctory," and its oversized shirt collar that suggested a kind of "sartorial dog collar" did two things.¹³ It implied he was "taking this seriously" because he wasn't in a t-shirt or hoodie. But it also indicated that he was a slightly awkward geek who understood technology far more than he did fashion. While the sartorial choice was meant to be seen as a silly coincidence born out of his social ineptness, it actually

signaled a strategic move on his part. He is a billionaire who can afford any tailored outfit on the planet. Coupled with his lackluster and often contemptuous responses to the questioning he faced, Zuckerberg telegraphed the game he was playing to anyone willing to notice. First and foremost, he was a geek who understood the technology. Congress did not. Therefore, it should not regulate what it did not understand. Check and mate.

Unfortunately, everyone—except the political elite—is hurt when democracy is framed as a kind of game to be won or lost. Voters are left to think their votes don't matter, that the system is rigged but there's no way to fix it, that politics should answer to the wealthy and the powerful and not the people, and that fear, rage, and a denial of our global interconnectedness are the only way forward. This kind of game has most often benefited those making broadly authoritarian populist appeals on the right, because it's inherently conservative.¹⁴ It's a strategy predicated on worries about how a world that moves toward justice, equality, and collectivism might impact those who have traditionally held power in public and private life.

LET'S STOP PLAYING THIS GAME!

As of this writing, massive layoffs are occurring in Silicon Valley, and those who work in user-facing roles within tech companies—like ensuring that election misinformation doesn't spread and that harassment and hate speech are minimized—have been among the first to be fired.¹⁵ The future of many large social media platforms remains uncertain. Maybe this is a good thing. But unfortunately for all of us, even if Silicon Valley ends one play session, the larger campaign continues. Now the focus has turned to artificial intelligence. But the culture of Silicon Valley remains unchanged. Those in tech bear some responsibility for where we are today, but it's unlikely that this new game will be any different than the last. As media theorist Douglas Rushkoff argues, "In the future envisioned by Wall Street and Silicon Valley alike, humans are just another externality."¹⁶ Artificial general intelligence might eliminate that

externality entirely. So if we keep playing the game as Silicon Valley has designed it, we face our own obsolescence (assuming climate change doesn't get us first). But what can we do?

A number of political solutions in the US are critically needed, including protecting voting rights, removing money from politics, expanding the Supreme Court, and eliminating the Electoral College. These reforms are unlikely to be enacted in the next five years, given the lack of political will and public divisiveness. But other interventions could help prevent this kind of metagaming from undermining democracy globally. Some of these ideas are listed below.

The tech industry needs to diversify significantly. While diversity isn't a panacea, increasing the number of women and BIPOC, disabled, and LGBTQIA+ individuals working in tech is critical to decentering cishet White men as the design subject. One of the most important things tech companies and platform administrators could do immediately is to take seriously the methods and approaches used by the design justice, participatory design, value-sensitive design, and feminist human-computer interaction communities.¹⁷ Also critical is having more on-the-ground, local representation in communities around the world so that Silicon Valley isn't simply exporting its (problematic) culture elsewhere. Companies also need to presume that their technologies will be used for harassment and violence, reexamine the affordances of their platforms to minimize these risks, create tools (and not just algorithmic ones) to prevent these harms, and design reporting systems that don't retraumatize those who are victimized. As Jenny L. Davis notes, affordances are inherently value-laden and often reflect the "politics of the powerful."¹⁸ Silicon Valley needs to recognize this reality and do more to dismantle the systems (cultural, political, and social) that support and replicate it.

The triple-A gaming industry also needs to recognize its own complicity in this mess. The industry is woefully lacking in meaningful representation of women and marginalized individuals. While the solution is not simply "add diversity and stir," as Adrienne Shaw argues, increasing the rates of BIPOC in design and

development roles in these companies could introduce new perspectives into both the narratives these games tell and the mechanics they employ.¹⁹ Additionally, as with the technology industry writ large, game companies need to recognize that fan communities can be toxic spaces for noncis het White men and are also prime spaces for recruitment into far-right ideologies. For example, a recent Anti-Defamation League report noted that games are increasingly sites of propaganda and White supremacist content.²⁰ While games have long been sites of political and cultural struggles as their status as either frivolous entertainment or serious art remains contested, companies in the video game industry has long avoided taking responsibility for the kinds of narratives and mechanics they rely on. In trying to sidestep the whole messy debate about whether games like *Call of Duty* (for example) are causal agents for violent behavior, game companies have effectively ignored any responsibility they might have for the toxicity of some gaming communities. Likewise, the misogynistic and racist tropes that populate many games remain relatively unchallenged. And while the game industry is changing, the changes are not happening fast enough.

The media also shoulders significant responsibility in perpetuating harmful myths about technology and in mainstreaming the alt-right's ideology. The press has often elided its journalistic responsibilities by framing stories about technology in a way that reinforces the myth of the tech bro as an idealistic wunderkind or as a lone, self-made inventor (rather than as the recipient of significant capital from family members and investment firms). In addition, the media's tendency to frame any new technology as all good or all bad rather than necessarily complex provides the public with very little insight or sense of ownership about how technologies reflect the values of their creators and the public. In addition to changing how the press reports on technology, media outlets need to stop amplifying the alt-right's toxic ideology. Journalistic objectivity has been equated with a discussion of the two sides of any given debate as if they are equally valid. But far-right pundits and politicians (and many within the GOP) aren't arguing in good faith, and providing them with a platform

legitimizes their message instead of defusing it. Unfortunately, the political and economic realities of most media companies lead them to prioritize advertising dollars over public-interest reporting, which makes it difficult for journalists to report on the threat the alt-right poses without resorting to salacious, personality-driven stories and clickbait. We should also be wary when technologists (like Amazon's Jeff Bezos) own media outlets (like the *Washington Post*). Investigative journalism in the US may be in decline, but it's one of the only tools we have to check the power of the elite.

What can the public do? One good place to start is to lobby Congress (in the US) and other legislative bodies globally to place greater restrictions on social media companies. This could include rethinking platforms' responsibilities for the harassment that takes place there, calling for transparency about moderation decisions and algorithmic audits, and pushing for better laws regulating data privacy and revenge porn. The US has long lagged behind other countries in regulating technology, but the European Union places reasonable restrictions on tech that help ensure it's being developed in ways that do not deprive users of their humanity and privacy. A larger, global conversation needs to address the ethical consequences of technology to minimize its use as a tool that reentrenches existing power structures. But much work can be done by individuals. As Whitney Phillips and Ryan M. Milner argue, one of the most powerful things that members of the public can do is to avoid polluting the information ecosystem themselves.²¹ This requires being mindful of the kind of content that we're sharing and remembering that social media is not great for enabling meaningful, deliberative conversations.

It might also be possible to harness the power of those who play games (nearly all of us) to remake this system. Game designers like Jane McGonigal have suggested that serious social and political issues can be addressed by gamers because they have unique problem-solving skills.²² And the serious games movement (in which games are created to educate or provide training) has also demonstrated that games have the potential to offer communities new tools for collaboration.²³ While such interventions may work on

the smaller scale, however, creating lasting social and political change probably will require an altogether different kind of approach. Regardless, we should demand better representation, narratives, mechanics, and complex characters in the games we play. And parents, please play games with your kids so they learn how to become critical consumers of them.

I want to return to where we started, with the Honkey Kong meme mentioned in the first chapter. The image envisions the insurrectionists climbing the US Capitol as merely background characters who may or may not be threatened by the barrels that Donkey Kong is throwing. Presumably we, the viewers, are Mario, who now has to jump over barrels and navigate around these rioters to reach Pauline. It's tempting to view this meme as proof that the left *can* meme and to embrace it as a funny artifact from a desperate moment when we needed some levity.²⁴ And while the meme does imply a political critique by highlighting the insurrectionists' Whiteness (by using the term *honkey*), there is some danger that reimagining them as background cannon fodder in a video game elides the seriousness of the moment. As Audre Lorde's words remind us, we can't actually make meaningful changes if we rely on the same kinds of dark play that the far right has used to metagame social media and democracy.²⁵ Instead, we have to envision a different kind of world using a better set of tools and reclaim the digital future for ourselves if we want one that is just and inclusive.

It would be easy to be pessimistic given the success the far right has had so far in metagaming democracy. But maybe there's hope. Maybe we've finally realized that we can't look to Silicon Valley and people like Elon Musk (who until relatively recently was celebrated by the geeks hanging out on Reddit) for solutions to our problems. Maybe we can finally question their "Move fast and break things" mentality and the belief that the tech billionaires are somehow better equipped to fix these problems than the rest of us are. Maybe we can persuade Congress and governments globally to regulate technology companies. Maybe we will start realizing that relying on social media platforms and technology companies isn't a good proxy

for developing meaningful local public spaces and mutual aid networks, and we will start valuing the contributions of those who are most dispossessed by our political systems under late capitalism. And maybe we can finally take seriously the threat of White supremacist terrorism globally and listen to those who have been warning us for years about the fragility of democracy and the ease with which cultures slide into fascism. Here's hoping.

NOTES

1. *WarGames*, dir. John Badham (United Artists, 1983).
2. Or to remix a phrase from the celebrity gossip magazine *Us Weekly* ("Stars—They're just like us!"), "Silicon Valley billionaires—They're just (not) like us!"
3. *Succession* is a satirical dark comedy television show focused on a massive media conglomerate (Waystar-RoyCo) run by a Rupert Murdoch-style patriarch (Logan Roy, played by Brian Cox) and his backstabbing children (all of whom hope to succeed him in the family business). I bet Elon Musk views himself as Luckas Matsson (played by Alexander Skarsgård), the crafty owner of a technology company who attempts to buy Waystar in the later seasons of the show. But he's really more like Kendall Roy (played Jeremy Strong), the eldest son from Logan's second marriage, who manages to botch every business deal he's involved in because he's wildly overconfident and profoundly unlikeable. *Succession* (HBO Entertainment).
4. Thomas Lotito, "Updates: Elon Musk Takes over Twitter," *New York Times*, October 28, 2022, accessed July 29, 2023, <https://www.nytimes.com/live/2022/10/28/business/twitter-elon-musk#elon-musk-twitter-deal-complete>.
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APPENDIX: TIMELINE OF EVENTS

June 2007	Steve Bannon becomes CEO of Internet Gaming Entertainment, a company that sold virtual goods for various real currencies.
2008	Paul Gottfried gives a speech titled "The Decline and Rise of the Alternative Right" in a speech at his H. L. Menken Club in Baltimore.
2010	Richard Spencer coins the term <i>alt-right</i> .
March 2012	Steve Bannon becomes executive chairperson of the Breitbart News website.
March 2013	Video game developer Adria Richards is harassed at the PyCon tech conference, and #donglegate trends on Twitter.
September 2013	Jeff Bezos, founder and executive chairperson of Amazon, purchases the <i>Washington Post</i> .
August 16, 2014	A blog called <i>The Zoe Post</i> is published and posted to the Something Awful website and the 4chan imageboard.
August 24, 2014	A pro-#Gamergate subreddit called r/KotakuInAction is created on Reddit.
August 27, 2014	Actor Adam Baldwin refers to #Gamergate in a tweet.
August 28, 2014	Leigh Alexander's article titled "'Gamers' Don't Have to Be Your Audience. 'Gamers' Are Over'" is published on the Gamasutra website.
September 2014	Discussions of #Gamergate are banned from 4chan.
June 27, 2015	The subreddit r/The_Donald is created on Reddit.

October 2015	Milo Yiannopoulos becomes the editor of the Breitbart Tech section of the Breitbart News website.
March 2016	John Podesta, campaign manager for Hilary Clinton's presidential bid, has his email hacked.
August 17, 2016	Steve Bannon is appointed chief executive of Donald Trump's political campaign and later becomes his chief strategist.
October–November 2016	Wikileaks publishes John Podesta's hacked emails, and #Pizzagate adherents link coded messages in those emails to far-fetched conspiracy theories.
November 8, 2016	Donald Trump is elected US president.
December 4, 2016	After reading false #Pizzagate claims, Edgar Maddison Welch enters the Comet Ping Pong pizzeria in Washington, DC, with a rifle and fires three shots.
July 2017	Google engineer James Damore writes an internal memo called "Google's Ideological Echo Chamber."
August 5, 2017	Activists at the r/The_Donald subreddit encourage attendance at the Unite the Right rally in Charlottesville, Virginia.
August 12, 2017	Heather Heyer is murdered during the counterprotest at the Unite the Right rally in Charlottesville.
October 28, 2017	Q Clearance Patriot makes his first post to 4chan's /pol/ (politically incorrect) board, and the QAnon conspiracy is born.
April 10, 2018	Mark Zuckerberg, founder and chief executive of Facebook, testifies before Congress about data privacy and Russian election interference.
April 2019	Carl Benjamin (Sargon of Akkad) announces his election bid to the European Parliament as a member of the UK Independence Party.
June 16, 2019	The r/The_Donald subreddit is quarantined.
March 11, 2020	The World Health Organization declares COVID-19 a pandemic.
May 26, 2020	Black Lives Matter protests start in Minneapolis after a police officer killed George Floyd during an arrest.
June 29, 2020	The r/The_Donald subreddit is banned.

November 3, 2020	Joe Biden is elected US president.
January 6, 2021	Supporters of Donald Trump attack the US Capitol in an effort to overthrow the results of the November presidential election.
May 8, 2021	Elon Musk, CEO of Tesla and Space X, hosts the TV comedy show <i>Saturday Night Live</i> .
October 27, 2022	Elon Musk completes his purchase of Twitter.
July 24, 2023	Elon Musk rebrands Twitter as "X."

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